



Global Standard
PACKAGING
MATERIALS
ISSUE 7



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Global Standard PACKAGING MATERIALS ISSUE 7

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How this publication is organised

This publication sets out the requirements for the auditing and certification of packaging manufacturers in order for them to achieve certification for the Global Standard Packaging Materials, Issue 7.

The document consists of the following parts:

Part I Introduction

Provides an introduction and background to the development and benefits of the Standard.

Part II Requirements

Details the requirements of the Standard with which a company must comply with to gain certification.

Part III Audit protocol

Provides information on the audit process and rules for the awarding of certificates. It details the different audit programmes available within the Standard, as well as information on the logos and the BRCGS Directory.

Part IV Management and governance

Describes the management and governance systems in place for the Standard and for the management of certification bodies registered to operate the scheme.

Appendices

The appendices provide other useful information, including auditor competency requirements, product categories and a glossary of terms.

The text of the Standard, as well as documents derived from and supporting the Standard have been written in English.

BRCGS makes every effort to review and check versions created in other languages but cannot guarantee all precise details. In the event of a query the English version shall be regarded as the definitive version.

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Part I

Introduction

Welcome to Issue 7 of the Global Standard Packaging Materials (hereafter referred to as the Standard). Originally developed and published in 2001, the Global Standard Packaging Materials was designed to protect the consumer by providing a common basis for the certification of companies supplying packaging to food producers. The Standard has been updated at regular intervals since, to reflect the latest thinking in product safety, and to encourage adoption of the Standard globally. It has attained usage worldwide not only by food packaging producers, but also producers of packaging for all applications at all levels of the supply chain. This now includes producers of packaging for hygiene-sensitive consumer products such as cosmetics and pharmaceuticals, and single use disposable products such as paper napkins.

The Standard provides all types of packaging manufacturers with a robust framework to assist them:

- in the operational manufacture of safe packaging materials and related products
- to manage product quality to meet customers' requirements
- to fulfil obligations regarding legal compliance and protection of the consumer or user.

The format and content are designed to allow a company's premises, operational systems and procedures to be assessed against the requirements of the Standard by a competent third party – the certification body.

Certification against the Standard is recognised globally by many brand owners, retailers, procurement companies, agents and brokers, food service companies and manufacturers when assessing the capabilities of their suppliers. In response to demand, the Standard has been translated into several languages to facilitate implementation by packaging materials companies across the world.

What's new in Issue 7?

The development of Issue 7 followed a wide consultation to understand stakeholders' requirements. A review of emerging issues in the packaging industry was also carried out along with the industries it supplies. The information has been developed and reviewed by a working group composed of international stakeholders representing different sized packaging materials manufacturers, retailers, brand owners, trade associations, food service companies, certification bodies and independent technical experts.

The focus for this issue has been on:

- updating the requirements for hazard analysis and risks assessment systems
- enhancing and reinforcing the understanding of product safety and quality culture in the drive to improve transparency and coherence across the supply chains
- formally including the manufacture of single use/disposable products into the scope of the Standard
- enhancing the importance of allergen management
- expanding the audit options to include a blended announced audit and the use of information and communication technology (ICT)
- ensuring global applicability with the Global Food Safety Initiative (GFSI) benchmarking requirements
- continuing to ensure consistency of the audit process
- simplifying the expectations of assurance within the supply chain to minimise potential risks.

The requirements of Issue 7 have evolved from those of previous issues. There continues to be an emphasis on management commitment, a hazard and risk analysis-based product safety programme and a supporting quality management system. The objective has been to direct the focus of the audit towards the implementation of good manufacturing practices within the manufacturing areas while recognising the diversity and breadth of the packaging industry, and the skills required to audit it.

Key features remain integral to the Standard, such as:

- the key role of product safety culture in ensuring attitudes, beliefs and behaviours of employees that affect the integrity of a product are embedded
- meeting the needs of retailers and brand owners to reduce the audit burden
- better recognition of the diversity of the packaging industry and its customers' demands
- encouraging greater transparency and traceability in the supply chain
- updating the requirements with core product safety activities such as internal audit, root cause analysis, preventive actions, incident management and allergen management control
- encouraging adoption of the Standard as a means of improving product safety at small sites and facilities where processes are still in development.

Audits

There are a range of audit options available for sites. These have expanded for Issue 7.

Announced audit programme (with mandatory unannounced audit every 3 years)

For announced audits, the audit date is agreed between the site and the certification body in advance of the audit and all requirements of the Standard are audited within the on-site audit visit.

Due to the added confidence provided by unannounced audits, the GFSI benchmark introduced a requirement for all certificated sites to have at least one unannounced audit within every 3-year period, even where they have opted to be part of the announced audit programme. Therefore, every 3 years, the audit will be unannounced. The certification body will notify the site and agree which year this will be. This will ensure that the site is aware that an unannounced audit will take place in the coming year. However, the actual date of the unannounced audit will not be communicated to the site in advance.

All other aspects of the announced audit protocol remain unchanged. More details on the announced audit programme can be found in Part III, section 1.1.1.

Blended announced audit programme (with mandatory unannounced audit every 3 years)

The introduction of the blended announced audit option utilises the evolving role of information and communication, technology (ICT) to incorporate remote assessment into the audit process.

The significance of this audit option resides in the flexibility provided to the audit scheduling. At the time of publication, this option is only available for re-certification audits and not for initial audits (the first BRCGS audit at a site or where certification has lapsed for over 2 years). The audit is split into two separate parts: a remote audit, followed by an on-site audit. The remote audit (first part) looks predominantly at the documented systems and records using ICT, while the announced on-site audit (the second part) focuses mainly on manufacturing, storage and other on-site areas.

The blended announced audit is only offered by a certification body following a risk assessment which:

- confirms that a robust audit is possible (e.g. availability of remote technology at the site)
- assesses the percentage of the audit that can be completed remotely, up to a maximum of 50% of the audit duration.

As explained above, sites opting for announced audits, including the blended announced audit, are required to have at least one unannounced audit within every 3-year period.

More details on the blended announced audit protocol can be found in Part III, section 1.1.2.

Unannounced audit programme

The unannounced audit is largely unchanged from Issue 6. It remains voluntary but provides added confidence in certification to customers and creates marketing benefits where sites achieve the top BRCGS grade of AA+.

For Issue 7, the audit may occur at any stage within the last 4 months of the audit cycle, including the 28 calendar days before the audit due date (i.e. the unannounced audit occurs within the 4 months prior to the audit due date). The audit will be unannounced, and the date of the audit shall not be notified to the site in advance. Where justified, a site may select up to 10 days when an audit cannot take place (for example, due to a customer visit). These non-audit days must be notified to the certification body in advance of the audit.

More details on the unannounced audit programme can be found in Part III, section 1.1.3.

Additional modules

Issue 7 maintains the principles that enable the incorporation of additional modules. These modules allow sites to include extra requirements during their audit to meet the needs of particular customers, regions or schemes and reduce the number of site audits. BRCGS will review each additional module to align it with updates to this version of the Standard. BRCGS will continue to develop such modules in response to market demand and make these available via its website and Participate.

More details can be found in in Part III, section 5.

The scope of the Standard

The Standard sets out the requirements for the manufacture of packaging materials that are used in:

- the manufacture of, and filling operations for:
 - food, beverages and feed
 - hygiene-sensitive consumer products (including cosmetics and pharmaceutical products)
- raw materials, and other consumer products such as single use disposable products (where appropriate).

The requirements are also intended to apply to:

- prior operations (e.g. manufacture of products/materials for conversion or printing)
- operations that are supplying packaging material from stock where additional product processing or repacking occurs, where this has been demonstrated to require the same level of control as a final/integrated conversion operation
- the manufacture and supply of materials that are unconverted or semi-converted and used or incorporated (e.g. inks, varnishes, coatings and adhesives), where this is based on a risk analysis and mutually agreed between those involved
- other products using similar manufacturing technologies, but are not packaging, that would otherwise be considered as consumer products, e.g., disposable cutlery and crockery, napkins, straws, polythene gloves.

The Standard shall not apply to packaging or materials (with the exception of traded products) that do not undergo any process at the site audited, or to activities relating to wholesale, importation, distribution or storage outside the direct control of the company.

Where the primary operation of the factory is the manufacture of consumer products and not the manufacture of packaging materials, the products are audited under the BRCGS Global Standard Consumer Products.

BRCGS has developed a series of standards setting out the requirements for the wide range of activities undertaken in the manufacture, packaging, storage and distribution of food or consumer products. Appendix 6 provides further details of the scopes of, and relationships between, the current standards.

Companies that meet the requirements of a satisfactory quality management system – for example, one conforming to that specified in ISO 9001 – may already meet many of the requirements of the Standard. It is in the interest of the company to bring these points to the attention of the certification body. The auditor will verify that the procedures are adequate for the purpose of compliance with this Standard.

Packaging materials legislation

The Standard has always been intended to assist sites and their customers to comply with legislative requirements for product safety.

Legislation covering packaging differs in detail worldwide and commonly focuses on packaging materials in contact with food. Though product safety culture is not explicitly mentioned in packaging legislation, adhering to packaging legislation ensures that food contact materials are safe and suitable for their intended purpose. It generally requires packaging manufacturers to:

- produce packaging that does not pose a hazard to human health
- provide a processing environment which ensures that the risks of product contamination are minimised
- use raw materials or ingredients that are not injurious to human health
- preserve, protect and contain products adequately throughout the supply chain and the life of the product
- ensure information about the product is presented to the consumer.

The Standard has been developed to assist packaging manufacturers in meeting these requirements.

The product safety and quality management system

Principles of the Standard

A packaging business must have a full understanding of the processes and products it manufactures and distributes. It must also have systems in place to ensure that products are produced and stored in an environment with appropriate levels of housekeeping and consistently meet the product safety, legality and quality expectations of its customers. The Standard is based on the key components of:

- senior management commitment
- hazard analysis and risk assessment of the product and manufacturing operation
- a systematic approach to managing product safety, legality and quality
- the establishment of prerequisite programmes.

Senior management commitment

Within a business, the safety, legality and quality of the products produced must be seen as a cross-functional responsibility, involving and using different skills and expertise in the organisation. Effective adoption of the principles of this Standard extends beyond the responsibility of a single individual or technical department and must involve commitment from manufacturing operations, engineering, distribution management, procurement of raw materials and those concerned with customer feedback and human resource activity such as training.

The starting point for effective implementation of the Standard is the commitment of senior management to:

- the development of an all-encompassing policy as a means to guide the activities that collectively assure the manufacture of safe and legal products
- the provision of resources required
- embedding a product safety and quality culture necessary for achieving the requirements.

The Standard places a high priority on clear evidence of senior management commitment. The requirements for senior management commitment are located in Part II, section 1.

Hazard analysis and risk assessment

The Standard requires an evaluation of the risks to product safety and quality associated with the manufacture of packaging materials. The hazard analysis and risk assessment (HARA) requirements defined in the Standard

should enable potential risks to be identified and controlled, either through existing prerequisite programmes, such as cleaning, pest control and maintenance, or by the introduction of specific controls. An effective hazard analysis and risk assessment provides a basis for the management system. The development of the system requires the input of all relevant departments and must be supported by senior management.

The requirements for hazard analysis and risk assessments are located in Part II, section 2.

A product safety and quality management system

The Standard requires the company to document the framework of management policies and procedures by which it will achieve the main requirements of this Standard. It also expects the company to maintain an environment with appropriate levels of housekeeping and operational conditions that are necessary for the manufacture of safe, legal and quality products.

The requirements for product safety and quality management are located in Part II, section 3.

Prerequisite programmes

These are the basic environmental and operational conditions in a packaging business that are necessary for the manufacture of safe and hygienic packaging materials. These control generic hazards, covering good manufacturing and good hygienic practice, and are detailed in Part II, sections 4–6.

The certification process

The Standard is a process and product certification scheme. In this scheme, packaging manufacturers are certificated upon completion of a satisfactory audit by an auditor employed by an independent third party – the certification body. The certification body in turn shall have been assessed and judged as competent by a national accreditation body.

In order for a packaging materials manufacturing operation to receive a valid certificate on completion of a satisfactory audit, the organisation must select a BRCGS approved certification body. BRCGS lays down detailed requirements that a certification body must satisfy in order to gain approval, and operates a comprehensive Certification Integrity programme to ensure high standards are maintained.

A list of approved certification bodies is available on the **BRCGS Directory**.

Preparation for the audit and planning for success

For everyone to gain the most value from certification to the Standard, retailers and other specifiers should have a clear understanding of both the demands it places on their suppliers and the benefits that ensue. Equally, manufacturers need to plan carefully to achieve certification.

Both specifiers and companies seeking certification should understand that considerable effort may be needed to work towards certification, especially for companies that have no previous experience of third-party certification schemes or quality management system certification.

It is important to set realistic timescales in which to gain certification and have a clear project plan to ensure that all the necessary actions are completed before the certification audit visit. After the audit visit, 28 calendar days are allowed in which to correct any failures to meet the requirements of the Standard; these are identified on the audit report as non-conformities. This period is extended to 90 calendar days for any non-conformities at initial audits where there is no temporary solution or there is a justifiable delay to resolve the issue. During this period, the site remains uncertificated. There is a limit to the number of non-conformities that are allowed before certification is refused (see Part III, section 2.4 for details). If the number of non-conformities exceeds that allowed, or if the non-conformities are not corrected within the allowed timeframe, a complete re-audit will be needed before certification can be granted. It is therefore not advisable to attempt an audit without adequate preparation.

For specifiers

Retailers, brand owners, food service companies and others contemplating specifying the use of the Standard by their suppliers are advised to inform their suppliers and the certification bodies well in advance of the implementation requirement. This will ensure that the companies have time for adequate planning and that the certification bodies have suitable infrastructure, such as auditor capacity, in place in the countries of demand and for the correct packaging categories. Specifiers (including retailers) may want to organise internal training to ensure that their personnel have a good understanding of the Standard. It may be helpful to arrange supplier briefings or other training events to explain the requirements of the scheme and other steps to implementation. Assistance with such matters is available from the BRCGS team.

For manufacturers

A detailed explanation of the audit process is given in Part III (Audit protocol). Companies already certificated to previous versions of this Standard should work through the steps to certification but may find that many aspects have already been addressed.

The packaging industry produces a wide variety of packaging materials, involving an extensive range of materials for use in many diverse industries. Given the scope of this activity, it is essential that the audit against the Standard is appropriate for the nature of the material produced and its intended use. Customers expect that all the packaging materials they purchase are safe for their intended use and produced to the quality agreed in the specification. It is recognised, however, that the manufacture of packaging for some particular uses (e.g. for direct food contact, feed or hygiene-sensitive products) places more stringent and demanding hygiene requirements on the manufacturer. The Standard directs manufacturers to determine the levels of hygiene required for the manufacture of safe packaging materials in the hazard analysis and risk assessment.

Explanation of terms

Within the Standard there are some specific terms and language used and familiarity with these terms will aid interpretation of the requirements. A full glossary is given in Appendix 8.

Annual frequency

Many requirements in the Standard refer to an annual frequency for the completion of specific tasks or, for example, product recall tests. The aim is to ensure that the tasks are completed within 12 months since the task was last conducted.

Note: there is a difference of 23 months between a test being completed in January of one year, and a subsequent test occurring in December of the following year. This would not meet the requirement for an annual frequency.

Appropriate

A number of clauses within the Standard refer to the need to fulfil requirements 'where appropriate'. 'Appropriate' is defined as suitable for a particular condition or occasion, and requirements shall be met where it is an industry requirement, or it is justified to do so.

A number of the requirements specify appropriate timescales, appropriate personnel etc., and thus contain a level of judgement. They are designed to provide a degree of flexibility to ensure the policies or procedures put in place are right for the organisation and the risks associated with the specific products.

Documented procedures

In many instances, the Standard specifically states that requirements shall be satisfied by procedures, processes, plans or records; in others, this is implied. However, the definition for procedure in the glossary clearly indicates that a documented system is required, as the company needs to be able to demonstrate that systems are in place and working consistently, and that documents are available for reference when required.

Any policies and documents must be written in sufficient detail to satisfy their purpose and must reflect the activities that happen in practice.

These documents can be hard copy (i.e. paper-based) or electronic.

Risk assessment

If the requirement says, 'on the basis of risk' or 'the site shall use risk assessment', this indicates that the first step is to carry out a risk assessment, document it, then use it to determine the company's policy/procedure/process in order to meet that requirement.

'Shall' versus 'may' or 'should'

Shall - indicates a mandatory requirement.

Should or may - indicates a recommendation/permission.

The style of the Standard is to allow companies to ensure that all aspects of control have been considered, so that thorough and comprehensive policies and procedures may be developed. In some instances, the Standard requires that criteria be included within a policy or procedure, and this is generally covered by the term 'shall'. If any of the points included are not covered adequately, a non-conformity will result.

However, there are also a number of clauses that provide examples or guidelines, generally preceded by the words 'may' or 'should'. This information is provided as guidance for incorporation in company policies and procedures. It is the responsibility of the company to ensure that the auditor is satisfied that the system in place is appropriate.

Products, packaging materials, raw materials

This standard has been reviewed to include all packaging materials, packaging raw materials and other products manufactured using similar technologies. These other products include single use disposable products (explained in more detail below). Therefore, the use of the term 'packaging' has been replaced in the Standard by the term 'product' to encompass all applicable products.

Single use disposable products

The Standard recognises that some packaging manufacturing sites also manufacture disposable plastic and paper products for use in the food service sector. The manufacturing material or technologies used are the same for both the packaging materials and the disposable products.

In terms of functionality, these products sit on the borderline between packaging materials and what BRCGS would term "consumer products".

Examples of these products include single use plastic or paper cups, lids, straws, paper or plastic plates, napkins, paper or plastic bags (including bin bags), paper or plastic tablecloths and cutlery. This is not an exhaustive list.

The BRCGS Global Standard Consumer Products is intended for manufacturing sites producing non-food raw materials, components and finished products destined for purchase by the end consumers for personal use. There is no GFSI Benchmark available for non-food consumer products.

The Global Standard Packaging Materials covers areas common to **all** BRCGS Standards e.g. senior management commitment, hazard analysis and risk assessment, documented product safety and quality management systems, good manufacturing practices and personnel. There is a specific emphasis on the management of product safety and quality, product development, functionality, and print control.

By allowing these single use products only destined for the food service sector to be included in this Standard it supports:

- compliance with specific customer requirements e.g. for GFSI-recognised certification
- certification to one standard rather than multiple standards, thus reducing audit and certification costs for sites
- certification to a standard which provides a valid assurance of consumer protection and legality
- accreditation of the certification process
- appropriate auditor competence criteria to undertake the assessment process effectively.

Note: Where a standard other than the primary standard is used it shall be understood that the certificate may not be accredited, dependent on the certification body and accreditation body. This should be checked with the certification body.

In order to be covered by the Global Standard Packaging Materials for the manufacture of single use products, the site must be predominantly producing packaging materials (at least 70% by volume).

Refer to Appendix 2 for further clarification on the manufacturing categories.

Benefits of the Standard

Adoption of the Standard leads to a number of benefits for the manufacturers of packaging materials. These include:

- providing a framework for the development of quality and hygiene management systems in companies, encouraging continual improvement, effective environmental monitoring, management of waste, and increased efficiency
- ensuring a comprehensive scope covering product safety, legality and quality
- providing a single standard and protocol that governs an accredited audit by third-party certification bodies, allowing a credible independent assessment of a company's product safety and quality systems
- addressing part of the legislative requirements of the packaging manufacturer/supplier, packer/filler and retailer
- enabling companies to ensure their suppliers are following good manufacturing practices in product safety and are fulfilling legal requirements
- requiring the completion of corrective actions, root cause analysis and preventive actions to any non-conformities, and within the site's product safety and quality management systems. This reduces the need for customers to follow up audit reports, and demonstrates continual improvement
- demonstrating a commitment to the prevention of loss of raw materials that may contaminate the environment
- being internationally recognised, based on the benchmark requirements of GFSI and providing a report and certification that can be accepted by customers in place of their own audits, reducing time and cost
- enabling certificated companies to appear in the publicly available part of the BRCGS Directory, allowing recognition of their achievements and use of a globally recognised logo for marketing purposes
- providing three audit options, announced, unannounced and blended. These will not only satisfy customer demands, but also enable companies to demonstrate compliance through a process which best suits their operation and the maturity of their product safety and quality management systems
- access to an all-inclusive set of tools designed to drive continuous improvement.

Guidance and training

BRCGS produces an interpretation guideline to support sites in their certification preparation. It is important to understand that the interpretation document is not an auditable document.

There is also a range of guidance documents, training courses and a self-assessment tool to assist sites with the application of the Standard and an understanding of the core skills needed. Further information about BRCGS publications and training can be found on the **BRCGS website**.

BRCGS guidance covers a range of topics including (but not limited to):

- risk assessments
- internal audits
- vulnerability assessments
- allergen management
- root cause analysis
- product changeover.

Sites certificated to this Standard can download BRCGS publications from Participate. For details, see Appendix 9.

Effective date of Issue 7

As with all revisions of BRCGS Standards, there must be recognition that a transition period is in place between publication and full implementation. This allows time for the retraining of all auditors and allows manufacturers to prepare for the new issue of the Standard. Therefore, certification against Issue 7 will commence from 28 April 2025. All certificates issued against audits carried out prior to this date will be against Issue 6 and will be valid for the period specified on the certificate.

Acknowledgements

BRCGS wishes to acknowledge all those members of the packaging materials technical working group, made up of international stakeholders representing packaging manufacturers, retailers, food services companies, trade associations, certification bodies and independent technical experts who have contributed to the preparation of the Global Standard Packaging Materials, Issue 7. Appendix 10 lists those who participated in the working groups.

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Part II

Requirements

How the requirements are set out

Each main section or subsection of the requirements in the Standard begins with a statement of intent. This sets out the expected outcome of compliance with the requirements of that section. It forms part of the audit, and all sites must comply with the statements of intent in order to gain certification.

Below the statement of intent in the tables are more specific and detailed requirements (clauses) that, if applied appropriately, will help to achieve the stated objective of the requirement. All of the requirements shall form part of the audit.

Colour-coding of requirements

Manufacturing represents the key activities on site. The audit process therefore gives specific emphasis to the practical implementation of product safety procedures within the factory and general good manufacturing practices. Auditing these areas forms a significant proportion of the audit (around 50% of the audit time) and this includes auditing manufacturing and site facilities, interviewing personnel, observing manufacturing operations, and reviewing documentation in manufacturing areas with the relevant personnel. All areas of the site, and off-site operations, within the scope of the certification will be audited. This will include personnel facilities, storage, dispatch, engineering, on-site laboratory facilities, and external areas such as security.

As an aid to this process, the requirements within the Standard have been colour-coded. Colour-coding shows the activities that would usually be audited as part of the assessment of the manufacturing areas and facilities, and those that would form part of an audit of records, systems and documentation.

Key to colour-coding of requirements

Audit of site facilities and good manufacturing practice	Yellow	
Audit of records, systems and documentation	Blue	
Requirements assessed in both	Blue	Yellow

Fundamental requirements

Within the Standard, certain statements of intent have been designated as 'fundamental'. These are marked with the word 'FUNDAMENTAL' and denoted with the following symbol ★. The requirements that accompany these fundamental statements relate to the systems which are crucial to the establishment of an effective product quality and safety operation. The requirements deemed fundamental are:

- Senior management commitment and continual improvement (1.1)
- Hazard analysis and risk assessment (2)
- Specifications (3.4)
- Internal audits (3.5)
- Traceability (3.10)

- Corrective and preventive actions (3.13)
- Housekeeping and cleaning (4.8)
- Manufacturing process control (5.4)
- Training and competence (6.1)

Failure to comply with the statement of intent of a fundamental requirement (i.e. a major non-conformity) leads to non-certification at an initial audit or withdrawal of certification at subsequent audits. This will require a further full audit to demonstrate evidence of compliance.

Additional requirements and non-applicable clauses

The requirements in sections 1–6 shall be applied in all operations, with the following exceptions:

- Section 5.2, Graphic design and artwork control which only applies to sites that design and/or control artwork development.
- Section 5.3, Print control which only applies to sites that print or decorate packaging.
- Where a site trades other products it can opt to include these products within the scope of their BRCGS audit. The requirements for traded products are detailed in section 7. A full definition of traded products can be found in the glossary.

Any such specific requirements may be omitted and will be marked as not applicable (N/A) in the final audit report. The auditor will assess and decide on the applicability of any requirements that the site believes are not applicable.

Position statements

During the lifetime of a published standard, the BRCGS technical advisory committee (TAC) may be asked to review the wording of a clause or provide an interpretation of a requirement or a detail of the protocol. The decision made by the TAC is known as a position statement. Position statements are binding on the way that the audit and certification process is carried out and are an extension of the Standard. Further details are available in Part III, section 6.2, and Appendix 7.

1 Senior management commitment

1.1 Senior management commitment and continual improvement



Fundamental

The site's senior management shall demonstrate that they are fully committed to the implementation of the requirements of the Global Standard Packaging Materials and to processes which facilitate continual improvement of product safety, quality management, and the site's product safety and quality culture.

Clause	Requirements
1.1.1	The site shall maintain a documented policy which states the site's intention to meet its obligation to produce safe and legally compliant products to the specified quality and confirms its responsibility to its customers. This shall: • be signed by the person with overall responsibility for the site • be communicated to all personnel • include commitment to continuously improve the site's product safety and quality culture.
1.1.2	The site's senior management shall define and maintain a clear and effective plan for the development and continuing improvement of a product safety and quality culture. The plan shall include measures needed to achieve a positive culture change. This shall include: • defined activities which aim to improve and further develop product safety and quality culture. As a minimum, these activities shall be designed around: • clear and open communication of product safety • training • feedback from personnel • the behaviours required to maintain and improve product safety processes • performance measurement of activities related to the safety, legality and quality of products • an action plan indicating how the activities will be undertaken and measured, and the intended timescales • a review of the effectiveness of completed and ongoing activities. The plan shall be reviewed and updated, at a minimum, annually.
1.1.3	The company shall have a confidential reporting system to enable personnel to report concerns relating to product safety, legality, and quality. The mechanism for reporting concerns shall be clearly communicated to all personnel. The company's senior management shall have a process for assessing any concerns raised. Records of the assessment and, where appropriate, actions taken, shall be documented.
1.1.4	The site's senior management shall establish clear objectives to maintain and improve the safety, legality and quality of products manufactured, in accordance with the site's product safety and quality policy and this Standard. These objectives shall be: • documented and include targets or clear measures of success • clearly communicated to relevant personnel • monitored, and the results reported at a suitable predetermined frequency to the site's senior management.

Clause	Requirements
1.1.5	The company's senior management shall provide the human and financial resources required for the manufacture of safe and legally compliant products, to the required quality, and in compliance with the requirements of this Standard.
1.1.6	The company's senior management shall have a system in place to ensure that the site is kept informed of and reviews: • scientific and technical developments • industry codes of practice • all relevant legislation applicable in the country of manufacture and, where known, the country where the product will be used.
1.1.7	The site shall have a genuine, original hard copy or electronic version of the current Standard and be aware of any changes to the Standard or protocol that are published on the BRCGS website and Participate.
1.1.8	Where the site is certificated to the Standard, it shall ensure that announced or blended announced re-certification audits occur on or before the audit due date indicated on the certificate. It is the site's responsibility to ensure that all requirements are met, to ensure the unannounced audit can be undertaken in accordance with the audit protocol of the Standard (see Part III, section 4.7.1).
1.1.9	The most senior manufacturing or operations manager on site shall participate in the opening and closing meetings of the audit for certification to the Standard. Relevant departmental managers or their deputies shall be available as required during the audit. A member of the senior management team on site shall be available during the audit for a discussion on effective implementation of the product safety and quality culture plan.
1.1.10	The site's senior management shall ensure that the root causes of any non-conformities identified at the previous audit against the Standard have been effectively addressed to prevent recurrence.
1.1.11	The BRCGS logo and references to certification status shall be used only in accordance with the conditions of use detailed in the audit protocol section (Part III, section 6.8) of the Standard.

1.2 Management review

The site's senior management shall undertake a management review to ensure that the product safety and quality management system is both fully implemented and effective, and that opportunities for improvement are identified.

Clause	Requirements
1.2.1	Management review meetings attended by the site's senior management shall be undertaken at appropriate scheduled intervals (at a minimum annually) to review the site's performance against the Standard and the objectives set out in clause 1.1.4.

Clause	Requirements
1.2.2	The review process shall include the evaluation of: • previous management review documents, action plans and timescales • the results of internal, second-party and third-party audits • any customer performance indicators, complaints and feedback • the effectiveness of the hazard analysis and risk assessment • the impact of any applicable legislative and certification scheme changes • any incidents, corrective actions, out-of-specification results and non-conforming materials • resource requirements • any objectives that have not been met, to understand the underlying reasons. This information shall be used when setting future objectives and to facilitate continual improvement • the effectiveness of the product defence, product fraud prevention plans, and product safety and quality culture plans.
1.2.3	The meeting shall be documented and used to revise the objectives. The decisions and actions agreed within the review process shall be effectively communicated to appropriate personnel, and actions implemented within agreed timescales.
1.2.4	Personnel shall be aware of the need to report any risks or any evidence of unsafe or out-of-specification product, equipment or raw materials, to a designated manager to enable the resolution of issues requiring immediate action.

1.3 Organisational structure, responsibilities and management authority

The company shall have a clear organisational structure and lines of communication to enable effective management of product safety, legality, and quality.

Clause	Requirements
1.3.1	There shall be a current organisation chart demonstrating the management structure and reporting channels of the company. The responsibilities for the management of activities which ensure product safety, legality and quality shall be clearly allocated and understood by the managers responsible. It shall be clearly documented who deputises in the absence of the responsible person.
1.3.2	The site's senior management shall ensure that all personnel are aware of their responsibilities. Where documented work instructions exist for activities undertaken, the relevant personnel shall have access to these and be able to demonstrate that work is carried out in accordance with the instructions.
1.3.3	If the site does not have the appropriate in-house knowledge of product safety, legality and quality, external expertise (e.g. consultants, technical experts) may be used; however the day-to-day management of the product safety and quality management systems shall remain the responsibility of the company.

2 Hazard analysis and risk assessment



Fundamental

A hazard analysis and risk assessment (HARA) shall be implemented and maintained to ensure that all hazards to product safety and legality are identified, and appropriate controls established.

2.1 The hazard analysis and risk assessment team

Clause	Requirements
2.1.1	The hazard analysis and risk assessment (HARA) shall be developed, reviewed and managed by a multi-disciplinary team that includes those responsible for quality, technical, manufacturing operations and other relevant functions (e.g. engineering, product development). The multi-disciplinary team shall have a designated team leader who shall be suitably trained and able to demonstrate competence and experience of hazard analysis and risk assessment. The team shall be able to demonstrate competence in hazard analysis and risk assessment principles. The team shall ensure that the appropriate knowledge and expertise are available for the development and maintenance of an effective HARA, including being kept up to date with factory changes and customer requirements as they occur.

2.2 Prerequisite programmes

Clause	Requirements
2.2.1	The team shall establish and maintain environmental and operational programmes necessary to create an environment suitable to produce safe and legal products (prerequisite programmes). As a guide these may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • supplier approval and purchasing (section 3.6) • maintenance programmes for equipment and buildings (section 4.7) • cleaning and housekeeping (section 4.8) • product contamination control (section 4.9) • pest management (section 4.11) • product development (section 5.1) • print control (section 5.3) • dispatch and transport (section 5.9) • personnel training and competence (section 6.1) • personal hygiene requirements (section 6.2) The control measures and monitoring procedures for the prerequisite programmes shall be clearly documented and shall be included within the development and reviews of the HARA.

2.3 Describe the product

Clause	Requirements
2.3.1	The scope of the HARA shall be clearly defined and shall include all products and manufacturing operations within the intended scope of certification.

Clause	Requirements
2.3.2	A full description of the products or groups of products shall be developed, which includes all relevant information. As a guide, this may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • composition (e.g. raw materials, additives, inks, varnishes, coatings and other print chemicals) • origin of raw materials, including use of recycled materials • treatments and processes undertaken • intended use of the finished products and defined restrictions on use, e.g. direct contact with food or other hygiene-sensitive products • functional properties • storage conditions and expected usable life of the finished product.
2.3.3	All relevant information needed to conduct the HARA shall be collected, maintained, documented and updated. As a guide, this may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • historical and known hazards associated with specific processes, raw materials and finished products • relevant codes of practice or recognised guidelines • legislation relevant to the manufacturing and sale of finished products • customer requirements • a copy of any existing site HARA plans (e.g., for products already in manufacture at the site) • a map of the premises and equipment layout • intended use of the product (where known) • known likely product defects that affect safety • allergen-containing raw materials • conditions for storage, method of transport and distribution • packing materials used for the protection of the finished product.

2.4 Construct and verify process flow diagram

Clause	Requirements
2.4.1	A flow diagram shall be prepared to cover each product, group of products or manufacturing process. This shall set out the sequence and interaction of the steps in the operation. As a guide, this may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • receipt and approval of artwork and specification • receipt and preparation of raw materials such as additives, inks and adhesives • each step of the manufacturing process or work in progress retention stage • introduction of utilities and other contact materials (e.g., air, water and packing materials) • outsourced processes • in-line testing or measuring equipment • the use of rework and recycled materials • waste • finished product storage and dispatch • customer returns or materials to be returned to the supplier.

Clause	Requirements
2.4.2	Confirmation shall be completed by the HARA team to ensure the accuracy of the flow diagram(s) at least annually and whenever there are changes, by following the actual process flow diagram in relevant areas on site. Records of verified flow diagrams shall be maintained.

2.5 List all potential hazards associated with each manufacturing step, conduct a hazard analysis and consider any measures to control identified hazards

Clause	Requirements
2.5.1	The HARA team shall identify and record all the potential hazards that are reasonably expected to occur at each manufacturing process step, and consideration of the following types of hazards: • microbiological • physical • chemical. The HARA shall take into account, the potential for: • migration of substances • issues arising from the use of recycled materials • limitations of use of the product • foreseeable unintended use by the customer or consumer • defects critical to consumer safety • hazards that may have an impact on the functional integrity and performance of the final product in use • malicious intervention • raw material fraud (e.g., substitution, adulteration or misrepresentation) • allergen contamination risks.
2.5.2	The HARA team shall conduct a hazard analysis to identify the significant hazards (i.e., those hazards that are reasonably likely to occur at an unacceptable level), which need to be prevented, eliminated or reduced to acceptable levels. Consideration shall be given to at least the following: • likelihood of occurrence, considering prerequisite programs in the absence of additional control • severity of the outcome.
2.5.3	The HARA team shall consider the control measures necessary to prevent or eliminate each product safety hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level. Consideration may be given to using more than one control measure, including relevant prerequisites. Where elimination of the hazard is not practical, justification for acceptable levels of the hazard in the finished product shall be determined and documented.
2.5.4	Where the control of a specific product safety hazard is achieved through prerequisite programmes (see requirement 2.2), or control measure other than a critical control measure (see requirement 2.6), this shall be stated. The adequacy of the programme to control the specific hazard shall be validated.

2.6 Determine the critical control measures

Clause	Requirements
2.6.1	For each hazard that requires control, control measures shall be reviewed to identify those that are critical. This requires a logical approach and may be facilitated by use of a decision tree. Critical control measures shall be those controls which are required in order to prevent or eliminate a product safety hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level. If a hazard is identified at a step where control is necessary for safety, but the control does not exist, the product or manufacturing operation shall be modified at that step, or at an earlier step, to provide a control measure.

2.7 Establish validated critical limits for each critical control measure

Clause	Requirements
2.7.1	For each critical control measure, the appropriate critical limits shall be defined in order to identify clearly whether the manufacturing process is in or out of control. Critical limits shall be: • measurable wherever possible • supported by clear guidance or examples where measures are subjective (e.g. photographs).
2.7.2	The HARA team shall validate each critical control measure including critical limits. Documented evidence shall show that the control measures selected, and critical limits identified are capable of consistently controlling the hazard to the specified acceptable level.
2.7.3	Where equipment settings are critical to the safety or legality of the product, changes to the equipment settings shall only be completed by trained and authorised personnel. Where applicable, controls shall be password-protected or otherwise restricted.

2.8 Establish a monitoring system for each critical control measure

Clause	Requirements
2.8.1	A monitoring procedure shall be established for each critical control measure to ensure compliance with critical limits. The monitoring system shall be able to detect loss of control of the measures and, wherever possible, provide information in time for corrective action to be taken. As a guide, consideration may be given to the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • on-line measurement • off-line measurement at predetermined intervals • continuous measurement.
2.8.2	Records associated with the monitoring of each critical control measure shall include the date, time and result of measurement, and shall be signed by, or be electronically traceable to the person responsible for the monitoring.

2.9 Establish a corrective action plan

Clause	Requirements
2.9.1	The HARA team shall specify and document the corrective action to be taken when monitored results indicate a failure to meet a control limit, or results indicate a trend towards loss of control. This shall include the action to be taken by nominated personnel regarding: • any products that have been manufactured during the period when the activity was out of control • how control was regained • how potential recurrence is minimised.

2.10 Validate the hazard analysis and risk assessment plan and establish verification procedures

Clause	Requirements
2.10.1	HARA plans shall be validated prior to any changes which may affect product safety, to ensure that the plan will effectively control the identified hazards before implementation. For existing HARA plans, this may be achieved using the established processes detailed in requirements 2.10.2 and 2.10.3.
2.10.2	Verification procedures shall be established to confirm that the HARA plan, including controls managed by prerequisite programmes, continues to be effective. Examples of verification activities include: • internal audits • review of records where acceptable limits have been exceeded • review of complaints or feedback • review of incidents of product withdrawal or recall. Results of verification shall be recorded and communicated to the HARA team.

Clause	Requirements
2.10.3	The HARA team shall review the plan, prerequisites and flow diagrams at least annually and prior to any change that impacts the potential hazards and/or the control measures which may affect product safety. As a guide, these may include the following, although this is not an exhaustive list: • change in raw materials or supplier of raw materials • change in product composition • change in manufacturing conditions, process flow, manufacturing environment, or equipment • change in packing material, storage or distribution conditions • change in customer use • trends in root cause and/or testing/analysis results • emergence of a new risk • results from verification activities as defined in clause 2.10.2 • internal and external audits • review following incidents of product withdrawal or recall • new legislation or developments associated with raw materials, manufacturing, or product. Appropriate changes resulting from the review shall be incorporated into the HARA and/or prerequisite programmes. Changes shall be fully documented, and the validation shall be recorded. Where appropriate, the changes shall also be reflected in the company's policy (clause 1.1.1) and objectives (clause 1.1.4).

2.11 Hazard analysis and risk assessment documentation and record-keeping

Clause	Requirements
2.11.1	Documentation and record-keeping shall be sufficient to enable the site to verify that the HARA and product safety controls, including controls managed by prerequisite programmes, are in place and maintained.

3 Product safety and quality management

3.1 Product safety and quality management system

The company's processes and procedures to meet the requirements of this Standard shall be documented to allow consistent application, facilitate training, and support due diligence in the manufacture of a safe and legal product.

Clause	Requirements
3.1.1	The site's policies, procedures, working methods and practices shall be collated in a navigable and readily accessible system. Consideration shall be given to translation into appropriate languages, including the use of photographs, diagrams or other pictorial instructions where written communication alone is not sufficient (e.g., there are issues of literacy or foreign language). Where the site is part of a company governed by a head office, the interaction between the site's system and that of other sites and the head office shall be documented. All policies and procedures necessary for the operation of the site being assessed shall be available at the site.
3.1.2	The system shall be fully implemented, reviewed at appropriate planned intervals and improved, where necessary.

3.2 Document control

An effective document control system shall ensure that only the correct versions of documents, including record forms, are available and in use.

Clause	Requirements
3.2.1	The company shall have a procedure to manage documents which form part of the product safety and quality management system. This shall include: • a register/list of all controlled documents indicating the latest version number • the method for the identification and authorisation of controlled documents • a record of the reason for any changes, or amendments to the documents • the system for the replacement of existing documents when these are updated, including communicating changes to relevant personnel.
3.2.2	Where documents and records are in electronic form these shall be: • stored securely (e.g. with authorised access, control of amendments, or password-protected) • backed up to prevent loss or malicious intervention.

3.3 Record-keeping

The site shall maintain genuine records to demonstrate the effective control of product safety, legality and quality.

Clause	Requirements
3.3.1	Records shall be legible, appropriately authorised, retained in good condition, and retrievable.
3.3.2	Any alterations to records shall be authorised and justification for the alteration shall be recorded.
3.3.3	The company's senior management shall ensure that procedures are established and implemented for the organisation, review, maintenance, storage and retrieval of all records relating to product safety, legality and quality.
3.3.4	The site shall document its period of retention for records which relate to the usable life of the product, the intended use, and respecting customer or legal requirements.

3.4 Specifications



Fundamental

Appropriate specifications shall exist for raw materials, work in progress and finished products, and for any product or service which could affect the safety, legality and quality of the finished product and customer requirements.

Clause	Requirements
3.4.1	Specifications shall be suitably detailed, accurate and compliant with relevant product safety and legislative requirements. They may be in the form of a printed or electronic document, or part of an online specification system. Where the material imparts or provides a functional effect on the safety of the final product, the specification shall contain reference to documented evidence to demonstrate effectiveness, or proof of effect claimed such as shelf-life extension, freshness, and temperature monitoring.
3.4.2	The company shall seek formal agreement of specifications with relevant parties where required by the customer. Where specifications are not formally agreed, then the company shall be able to demonstrate that it has taken steps to put an agreement in place.

Clause	Requirements
3.4.3	Where products are produced for direct contact with food, beverage, feed or hygiene-sensitive applications, a statement of compliance shall be maintained to enable the users to ensure compatibility between the item and the final product with which it may be in contact. The statement of compliance shall be compiled and authorised by a suitably competent person. It shall contain as a minimum: • the nature of the materials used in the manufacture of the product • confirmation that the product meets relevant legal requirements in the country of manufacture and where known, the country of use • the inclusion of any post-consumer recycled materials. The statement shall identify: • date of issue and, where appropriate, expiry date • any limitations of use • the usable life (where relevant). The site shall review the statements of compliance at a defined frequency, or if relevant changes occur (e.g., changes which impact on the content of the statements of compliance, legal requirements, product updates, supplier changes).
3.4.4	The presence of a trademark or logo on products shall, where appropriate, be formally agreed between the relevant parties.
3.4.5	A specification review procedure shall be in place, where the product composition or characteristics change, or at an appropriate predetermined interval. Reviews and changes shall be documented and communicated to the customer, where required.

3.5 Internal audits



Fundamental

The company shall be able to demonstrate that it verifies the effective application of the HARA, implementation of the requirements of the Standard, the site's product safety and quality management system and any applicable module through internal audits.

Clause	Requirements
3.5.1	There shall be a scheduled programme of internal audits spread throughout the year. The internal audit programme shall be fully implemented and effective. The frequency at which each activity is audited shall be established in relation to the risks associated with the activity and previous audit performance. All activities shall be audited at least annually.

Clause	Requirements
3.5.2	As a minimum, the scope of the internal audit programme shall include the: • HARA • product safety and quality management system, including the activities to implement it (e.g. supplier approval, corrective actions and verification) • prerequisite programmes (e.g. housekeeping, pest control, maintenance) • product defence and product fraud prevention plans • procedures implemented to achieve the Standard and modules. Each internal audit within the programme shall have a defined scope and consider a specific activity or section of the HARA or product safety and quality management system.
3.5.3	Internal audits shall be carried out by appropriately trained and competent auditors. Auditors shall be independent from the process or activity being audited to ensure impartiality (e.g. they must not audit their own work).
3.5.4	Internal audit reports shall identify conformity, as well as non-conformity and include objective evidence of the findings. The results shall be reported to the personnel responsible for the activity audited. Corrective and preventive actions, and timescales for their implementation, shall be agreed and their completion verified. All non-conformities shall be handled as detailed in section 3.13. A summary of the results shall be reviewed in the management review meetings (clause 1.2.2).
3.5.5	In addition to the internal audit programme, there shall be a separate programme of documented inspections to ensure that the factory environment and manufacturing equipment are maintained in a suitable condition. At a minimum, these shall include inspections to: • assess cleaning and housekeeping performance • identify risks to the product from the building or equipment. The frequency of these inspections shall be based on risk. The results shall be reported to the personnel responsible for the activity or area audited. Corrective actions, and timescales for their implementation, shall be agreed.

3.6 Supplier approval and performance monitoring

The company shall operate effective procedures for the approval and performance monitoring of its suppliers.

Clause	Requirements
3.6.1	The site shall have an initial approval and ongoing assessment procedure for suppliers of raw materials, including finished product packing materials, based upon risk analysis and defined performance criteria. The procedure shall ensure that these are procured according to defined requirements where there is a potential impact to product safety, legality and quality.

Clause	Requirements
3.6.2	The initial approval procedure of manufacturing sites of raw materials that influence product safety, legality and quality shall be based on risk and include either one or a combination of: • valid certification to a globally recognised product safety management system e.g., certification to the applicable BRCGS Global Standard or GFSI-benchmarked standard • certification to a globally recognised quality management system that incorporates an assessment of traceability and confirmation that products supplied are safe and legal, e.g. declaration of compliance. The scope of certification shall include the raw materials purchased • supplier audits, with a scope to include a review of the product safety system, traceability, prerequisite controls, undertaken by an experienced and demonstrably competent product safety auditor. A full audit report shall be available. Where the supplier audit is completed by a second- or third-party, the company shall be able to: • demonstrate the competency of the auditor • confirm that the scope of the audit includes a review of the product safety system, traceability, and prerequisite controls • obtain, review and approve a copy of the full audit report • supplier self-audit questionnaire or supplier-provided information may be used for approval, where a valid risk-based justification is provided. The questionnaire shall have a scope that includes the product safety system for the product supplied, verification of the traceability system, and prerequisite controls, and it shall be reviewed and approved by a demonstrably competent person. Where approval cannot be based on the above, then the site shall be able to demonstrate their criteria for approval and evaluation of the supplier to ensure that all supplied raw materials do not pose a risk to product safety, legality and quality and meet the specified requirements or specifications.
3.6.3	There shall be a procedure for ongoing supplier approval and performance review, based on risk and defined performance criteria. The process shall be fully implemented.
3.6.4	Where ongoing supplier approval is based on questionnaires, or supplier-provided information, these shall be repeated, and traceability systems verified, at agreed intervals based on risk. Suppliers shall be required to notify the site of any significant changes in the interim, including any change in certification status. Records of ongoing supplier approval, and any changes or necessary corrective or preventative actions shall be reviewed and approved by a demonstrably competent person.
3.6.5	The site shall have an up-to-date list, or database of approved suppliers. This may be on paper (hard copy), or it may be controlled on an electronic system. The list or relevant supplier information shall be readily available to the appropriate personnel.
3.6.6	Where raw materials are purchased from companies that are not the manufacturer or packer (e.g. purchased from an agent, broker or wholesaler), the site shall know the identity of the last manufacturer or packer. Information to enable the approval of the manufacturer or packer shall be obtained from the agent, broker or wholesaler, unless they are certificated to the relevant BRCGS standard (e.g. Global Standard Agents and Brokers/Storage and Distribution with Wholesaler module) or a relevant standard benchmarked by GFSI.

Clause	Requirements
3.6.7	The supplier approval procedure shall address procurement in emergency situations, to ensure the materials still conform to the specified requirements and specifications and the supplier has been evaluated. In these circumstances, an assessment of incoming materials may include certificates of analysis, statement of compliance, or through testing.

3.7 Product vulnerability, claims and chain of custody

Systems shall be in place to minimise the risk of purchasing or use of fraudulent raw materials and to ensure that all product descriptions and claims are legal, accurate and verified.

Clause	Requirements
3.7.1	The company shall have processes in place to access information on historical and developing threats to the supply chain which may present a risk of substitution, adulteration, or misrepresentation of raw materials (i.e. fraudulent raw materials). Such information may, for example, come from: • trade associations • government sources • private resource centres.
3.7.2	A documented vulnerability assessment shall be carried out on all raw materials, groups of raw materials or finished product packing materials to assess the potential risk of substitution, adulteration, or misrepresentation. This shall take into account: • historical evidence of substitution, adulteration, or misrepresentation • economic factors which may make fraudulent activity more attractive • ease of access through the supply chain • sophistication of routine and upstream testing • physical form • supplier relationships • adverse impact on the user of the final product. Personnel involved in the vulnerability assessments shall understand potential fraud risks. The output from this assessment shall be a documented vulnerability assessment plan. This plan shall be kept under review to reflect changing economic circumstances and market intelligence which may alter the potential risks. It shall be formally reviewed annually.
3.7.3	Where raw materials and finished product packing materials are identified as being at particular risk of fraudulent activity, or where claims are made (including the provenance, chain of custody or assured status), the vulnerability assessment plan shall include appropriate assurance and/or testing processes to mitigate the identified risks. This may include supporting information from the supplier to verify the claim.

3.8 Management of outsourced processes

Outsourced processes are defined as where intermediate manufacturing steps, or storage, in the manufacture of a product is completed at another site.

It should be noted that outsourced processes refer to an intermediate step – therefore during outsourced processes the product, or partly processed product leaves the site being audited for the completion of the outsourced manufacturing operation, or storage before returning to the site.

Where there is additional storage or processing of raw materials prior to their initial arrival on site, this is not considered as outsourced, but should be managed by the site using supplier approval, raw material risk assessments and raw material specifications.

Where a product undergoes further manufacturing operations off-site and the product does not return to site, this is not considered an intermediate step or outsourced processing. This is outside the scope of the audit.

Where any intermediate process step (including manufacturing or storage) in the manufacturing operation is outsourced to a third party, or undertaken at another site, and subsequently returned to the site, this shall be managed to ensure it does not compromise the product safety, legality or quality.

Clause	Requirements
3.8.1	The company shall be able to demonstrate that, where any intermediate manufacturing operations are outsourced and undertaken off-site, this has been declared to the customer and, where required, approval agreed.
3.8.2	Where any intermediate manufacturing steps are outsourced, the risks to the safety, legality and quality of the product shall form part of the hazard analysis and risk assessment and the company's evaluation of the outsourced manufacturing operations shall be recorded.
3.8.3	Requirements for outsourced operations shall be agreed and documented in a service specification, which includes an effective traceability system. This shall include any specific handling requirements for the products.
3.8.4	Where any manufacturing steps are outsourced, final release of the product shall remain the responsibility of the site. Controls on completed, outsourced manufacturing steps shall be undertaken to ensure product safety, legality, and quality meets specification prior to dispatch to the customer.

3.9 Management of suppliers of services

The company shall be able to demonstrate that, where services are outsourced, risks presented to product safety, legality or quality have been evaluated to ensure effective controls are in place.

Clause	Requirements
3.9.1	There shall be a procedure for the approval and monitoring of suppliers of services. Such services shall include, but are not limited to: • outsourced processes • pest control • laundry services • transport and distribution • storage • sorting or rework • laboratory services • calibration services • waste management • external expertise e.g. consultants, training providers • servicing and maintenance of equipment. Providers of utilities such as water, electricity or gas may be excluded on the basis of risk. The frequency of approval and monitoring shall be risk-based, or whenever significant changes occur and consider: • risk to the safety and quality of products • compliance with any specific legal requirements • potential risks to the security of the product (i.e. risks identified in the vulnerability and product defence assessments).
3.9.2	Contracts or formal agreements shall exist with suppliers of services which clearly define expectations and ensure potential risks associated with the service have been addressed. Where appropriate, copies of relevant licences should be retained or accessible.

3.10 Traceability



Fundamental

The site shall be able to trace all raw materials through manufacturing (including outsourced operations) to the distribution of the finished product to the customer and from finished product supplied to the customer through manufacturing, back to the raw materials.

Clause	Requirements
3.10.1	The site shall have a procedure designed to maintain traceability throughout the site's operations. At a minimum, this shall include: • how the traceability system works • the product identification systems (such as labelling and coding of raw materials, work in progress, finished products), and records required. Where continuous processes are used, or raw materials are in bulk silos, traceability shall be achieved to the best practical level of accuracy.

Clause	Requirements
3.10.2	Identification of raw materials, work in progress, finished products, non-conforming products and quarantined goods shall be adequate to ensure traceability.
3.10.3	An appropriate system shall be in place to ensure that the customer can identify a product or lot number. Where coding is applied, this shall be checked for legibility and accuracy.
3.10.4	The site shall test the traceability system across the range of product groups, to ensure traceability can be determined from raw materials through manufacturing, including outsourced operations, to the distribution of the finished product to the customer and from finished product supplied to the customer through manufacturing to the raw materials. The traceability test shall include a summary of the documents referenced during the test, and clearly show the links between them. The test shall occur at a predetermined frequency, at a minimum annually, and results shall be retained. Traceability should be achievable within 4 hours unless otherwise specified by local legislation or customer requirements.
3.10.5	Where rework or any recycling operation is carried out, traceability shall be maintained.
3.10.6	Traceability of test data and samples to manufacturing lots shall be maintained.

3.11 Control of non-conforming materials

The site shall ensure that non-conforming raw materials, work in progress and finished product is clearly identified and effectively managed to prevent unauthorised release.

Clause	Requirements
3.11.1	Procedures for the control of out-of-specification or non-conforming materials shall be in place and understood by all personnel. These shall include the effective identification and management of materials before a decision has been made on their final disposition.
3.11.2	Non-conforming materials shall be assessed, and a decision taken to reject, accept by concession, rework, or put to alternative use. The decision and reasons shall be documented.

3.12 Complaint-handling

Customer complaints relating to product safety, legality and quality shall be handled effectively and the information used to reduce complaint levels.

Clause	Requirements
3.12.1	All complaints shall be recorded and investigated and the results of the investigation into the issue recorded where sufficient information is provided. Actions appropriate to the seriousness and frequency of the complaint shall be carried out promptly and effectively.

Clause	Requirements
3.12.2	Complaint data shall be analysed to identify significant trends. Where there has been an increase or repetition of a complaint type, root cause analysis shall be used to implement ongoing improvements to product safety, legality and quality, and to avoid recurrence. This analysis shall be made available to relevant personnel.

3.13 Corrective and preventive action



Fundamental

The site shall be able to demonstrate that it uses the information from identified issues in the product safety and quality management system (e.g. non-conforming products, internal audits, complaints, incidents, product recalls, product testing, second- and third-party audits) to complete necessary corrective actions and prevent recurrence.

Clause	Requirements
3.13.1	The site shall have a procedure for recording, handling and correcting issues identified in the product safety and quality management system. The site procedures shall include the completion of corrective actions, root cause analysis and implementation of preventive action within appropriate timescales.
3.13.2	Where a non-conformity places the safety or legality of a product at risk, or where there is an adverse trend in quality, this shall be investigated and recorded including: • clear documentation of the non-conformity • assessment of consequences by a suitably competent and authorised person • the corrective action to address the immediate issue • appropriate timescales for corrective and preventive actions • the person(s) responsible for corrective and preventive actions • verification that the corrective and preventive actions have been implemented and are effective. When trend analysis shows that there has been a significant increase in a type of non-conformity, root cause analysis shall be used to identify preventive action to minimise potential for recurrence, and to implement ongoing improvements.

3.14 Management of incidents

The company or site shall have a procedure to manage incidents, including product withdrawals, recalls, and returns from customers.

Clause	Requirements
3.14.1	An incident management procedure shall be established, implemented and maintained and include as a minimum: • identification of the key personnel involved in assessing incident severity, impact and actions to be taken, with their responsibilities clearly defined • the actions required to effectively manage an incident to prevent release of product where product safety, legality or quality may have been affected • recovery including logistics for return, storage of recovered product and product disposal • a communications plan including methods of informing customers, logistics, organisations such as regulatory bodies and/or certification body, where relevant • root cause analysis and corrective action to implement appropriate improvements as required. The incident management procedure shall be capable of being put into operation at any time.
3.14.2	The incident management procedure shall provide guidance and instruction for relevant personnel regarding the type of event that would constitute an incident. Incidents may include: • accidental, malicious contamination, or sabotage of product • product failure or significant non-conformity • disruption to normal manufacturing operations • disruption to key services such as water, energy, distribution, personnel availability and communications • events such as fire, flood or natural disaster • failure of, or attacks against, digital cyber-security • spillage e.g., plastic pellets, ink, solvents etc., which may impact the environment. Personnel involved in incident management shall be trained in the procedure.
3.14.3	Where products have been released from the site that could be affected by an incident, the need to withdraw products and, where appropriate, advise customers to withdraw and/or recall products, shall be considered.
3.14.4	Where a site's products are involved in a product withdrawal, or recall, the site shall assist with provision of information (such as traceability) as required.
3.14.5	The incident management procedure relating to product recall/withdrawal shall be tested, at least annually, in a way that ensures its effective operation. Results of the test shall be retained and shall include timings of key activities. The results of the test, and of any actual incidents, shall be used to review the procedure and implement improvements as necessary.

Clause	Requirements
3.14.6	In the event of a significant product safety or legality incident, the site shall notify the current certification body within 3 working days. The site shall then provide sufficient information to enable the certification body to assess any effects of the incident on the ongoing validity of the current certificate within 21 calendar days. As a minimum, this shall include corrective action, root cause analysis and a preventive action plan.

4 Site standards

4.1 External standards

The site shall be of suitable size and construction, in a suitable location, and maintained to an appropriate standard to reduce the risk of contamination and facilitate the manufacture of safe, legal and quality products.

Clause	Requirements
4.1.1	Consideration shall be given to local activities and the site environment, which may have an adverse impact on the safety, legality or quality of the finished product or raw materials. Measures shall be taken to prevent contamination. Where measures have been put in place to protect the site, they shall be regularly reviewed to ensure they continue to be effective (e.g. flood controls).
4.1.2	The external areas shall be maintained in good order. Any grassed or planted areas surrounding buildings shall be regularly tended and well maintained. External traffic routes under site control shall be suitably surfaced to avoid contamination of the product.
4.1.3	The building fabric shall be maintained to minimise potential for product contamination, pest entry, ingress of water and other contaminants. External silos, pipework or other access points for the product and/or raw materials shall be appropriately sealed and secured. Where possible, a clean and unobstructed area shall be provided along the external walls of the buildings used for manufacturing and/or storage.
4.1.4	Where natural external drainage is inadequate, additional drainage shall be installed. External drains shall be properly protected to prevent entry of pests.

4.2 Building fabric and interiors: raw materials handling, preparation, manufacturing, packing and storage areas

The internal site, buildings and facilities shall be suitable for the intended purpose and shall be designated, constructed, maintained and monitored to effectively control the risk of product contamination.

Clause	Requirements
4.2.1	Walls shall be finished and maintained in good condition to minimise the accumulation of dirt and facilitate cleaning.
4.2.2	Doors shall be maintained in good condition. External doors and dock levellers shall be close-fitting, or adequately proofed. Where external doors to open product manufacturing areas are present, suitable precautions shall be taken to prevent pest ingress.
4.2.3	Ceilings and overhead structures shall be constructed, finished and maintained to prevent the risk of product contamination. Where suspended ceilings exist, they shall be accessible for cleaning and inspection for pests unless the void is fully sealed.

Clause	Requirements
4.2.4	Floors shall be suitably hard-wearing to meet the demands of the operations and withstand cleaning materials and methods. They shall be maintained in good repair and facilitate cleaning.
4.2.5	Where they constitute a risk to product, and based on the likelihood and risk of contamination, windows and roof glazing shall be protected against breakage.
4.2.6	Where they constitute a risk to product and based on the likelihood and risk of non-product glass contamination, all bulbs and strip lights, including those on flying-insect control devices, shall be adequately protected.
4.2.7	Suitable and sufficient lighting shall be provided to ensure a safe working environment, enabling effective operations, cleaning and inspection of the product.
4.2.8	Suitable and sufficient ventilation to prevent condensation, excessive dust, heat and fumes where applicable, shall be provided.
4.2.9	Based on risk, where elevated walkways, access steps, or mezzanine floors are adjacent to, or pass over manufacturing lines, they shall be: • designed to prevent contamination of products and manufacturing lines • easy to clean • appropriately maintained.

4.3 Utilities

All utilities to and within the manufacturing and storage areas shall be designed, constructed, maintained and monitored to effectively control the risk of product contamination.

Clause	Requirements
4.3.1	All water used in the manufacturing areas that could impact product safety shall be suitable for the intended use, adequately stored and be, where appropriate, potable or suitably treated. Where required, the site shall comply with local legislation on water quality. Where water is not intended for use in manufacturing operations, systems shall be in place to minimise risks to product safety.
4.3.2	Based on risk assessment, the microbiological and/or chemical quality of steam, ice, air, and compressed gases which come into direct contact with product shall be specified as suitable for the intended use or regularly monitored. These shall present no risk to product safety or quality and shall comply with relevant local legislation.

4.4 Site security and product defence

A product defence plan shall be in place to ensure that there are systems to protect products, and sites from malicious actions.

Clause	Requirements
4.4.1	The company shall undertake a documented threat assessment of the security arrangements and potential risks to the products from any deliberate attempt to inflict contamination or damage. This threat assessment shall include both internal and external threats. The output from this assessment shall be a product defence plan, specifying systems and procedures to be implemented to mitigate identified risks. The plan shall be monitored to ensure it is effectively implemented. Corrective and preventive actions shall be implemented where monitoring indicates failure. Areas shall be assessed according to risk. Areas where exposed food or hygiene sensitive contact surfaces are present shall be defined, clearly identified, monitored and controlled. This plan shall be kept under review to reflect changing circumstances and industry feedback. It shall be formally reviewed at least annually and whenever: • a new risk emerges (e.g. a new threat is publicised or identified) • an incident occurs where there is an identified failure in product security or product defence. Where applicable, the product defence plan shall meet the legal requirements in the country of sale or intended use.
4.4.2	Processes shall be in place to ensure only authorised personnel have access to manufacturing and storage areas, and access to the site by personnel, contractors and visitors shall be controlled. A visitor reporting system shall be in place. Personnel shall be trained in site security procedures and encouraged to report unidentified or unknown visitors.
4.4.3	External storage tanks, silos and any intake pipes with an external opening shall be sufficiently secure to prevent unauthorised access.

4.5 Layout, product flow and segregation

The factory layout, flow of manufacturing operations and movement of personnel shall be sufficient to prevent the risk of product contamination and to comply with all relevant legislation.

Clause	Requirements
4.5.1	There shall be a current map, or plan of the site which defines: • access points for personnel • travel routes for personnel, raw materials, work in progress and finished products • personnel facilities • routes for the removal of waste • flow of manufacturing operations • areas requiring additional control such as 'clean rooms' • storage areas.

Clause	Requirements
4.5.2	The flow from intake to dispatch shall be arranged to minimise the risk of contamination, or damage to the product.
4.5.3	Premises shall allow sufficient working space and storage capacity to enable all operations to be carried out properly under safe and hygienic conditions.
4.5.4	Sorting, or other activities involving the direct handling of the product shall take place in areas that have, as a minimum, the same standards as manufacturing areas.
4.5.5	Activities that could produce a contamination risk, such as the removal of outer packing, shall be carried out in a designated, segregated area.
4.5.6	Sites shall be designed so that movement of all personnel is by simple, logical routes. If it is necessary to allow access through manufacturing areas, designated walkways shall be provided that ensure that product safety, legality and quality is not compromised.

4.6 Equipment

Equipment shall be suitable for the intended purpose and shall be installed, maintained and used to minimise the risk to product safety, legality and quality.

Clause	Requirements
4.6.1	Manufacturing and storage equipment shall be designed, constructed of suitable materials, installed, commissioned and maintained for the intended purpose. Equipment shall enable effective cleaning, and minimise the risk of contamination. Lubrication points and application methods of any lubricant shall not be able to contaminate the product.
4.6.2	There shall be a specification prior to sourcing new, or new-to-site equipment. This may include: • details of intended use of the equipment and the type of materials it will be handling • where applicable, requirements for open product contact surfaces to meet any legal requirements. Depending on its intended purpose, new, or new-to-site equipment may require authorisation from a multi-disciplinary team which may include members of manufacturing, quality, engineering and the HARA team. The supplier should provide evidence that equipment meets these site requirements prior to supply.

Clause	Requirements
4.6.3	A risk-based commissioning procedure shall be in place to ensure that product safety and integrity is maintained during the installation of new or new-to-site equipment. New equipment to site shall be inspected for compliance with specification by authorised personnel before being accepted into operation. Installation work shall be followed by a clearance inspection which records that contamination hazards have been removed. The commissioning procedure shall include the update of any other site procedures that are affected by the equipment, for example, training, operating procedures, cleaning, environmental monitoring, maintenance schedules or internal audits.
4.6.4	Equipment that is not used or is taken out of service shall be cleaned and stored in a manner that does not pose a product safety risk.

4.7 Maintenance

An effective maintenance programme shall be in operation for equipment and support service equipment to prevent contamination risk and reduce the potential for breakdowns.

Clause	Requirements
4.7.1	A programme of maintenance shall be in place to prevent contamination and reduce the risk of breakdown. The programme shall cover all items of manufacturing and support service equipment critical to product safety, legality and quality. Maintenance and associated records shall be kept.
4.7.2	In addition to any planned maintenance programme, where there is a risk of product contamination by foreign bodies arising from equipment failure or damage, the equipment shall be inspected at predetermined intervals, inspection results documented, and appropriate action taken.
4.7.3	Maintenance work shall not place product safety, legality or quality at risk. Maintenance work shall be followed by a clearance inspection which records that contamination hazards have been removed and equipment is cleared to resume manufacturing. Tools and other maintenance equipment shall be cleared away after use and appropriately stored.
4.7.4	Where temporary repairs and modifications are made, these shall be documented and controlled to ensure that the product safety, legality or quality is not at risk. These temporary measures shall be permanently repaired as soon as practicable and within a defined timescale.
4.7.5	Engineering workshops/areas shall be kept clean and tidy, and controls shall be in place to prevent transfer of engineering debris to manufacturing or storage areas (e.g. by provision of swarf (debris) trap mats).
4.7.6	Contractors involved in maintenance or repair activities shall be suitably monitored by a responsible person from the site.

4.8 Housekeeping and cleaning



Fundamental

Systems shall be in place which ensure that appropriate standards of equipment and environment housekeeping and cleaning are maintained and that the risk of product contamination is minimised.

Clause	Requirements
4.8.1	Standards of housekeeping shall be maintained and include manufacturing, storage, and ancillary areas such as engineering workshops and laboratories. Housekeeping shall include a condition-based cleaning or 'clean as you go' policy.
4.8.2	Cleaning procedures shall be in place and maintained for buildings, equipment and vehicles. Cleaning schedules and procedures shall include the following information: • responsibility for cleaning • item/area to be cleaned • frequency of cleaning • method of cleaning • cleaning materials to be used • cleaning record and responsibility for verification. The frequency and methods of cleaning shall be based on risk. The procedures shall be implemented to ensure that appropriate standards of cleaning are achieved. Cleaning activities shall not pose a risk to product safety.
4.8.3	Cleaning equipment and facilities shall be fit for purpose, maintained in a suitable condition, cleaned and stored in a hygienic manner to prevent contamination and stored in a designated location.
4.8.4	Materials and equipment used for cleaning toilets shall be differentiated from those used elsewhere, and physically segregated where necessary.
4.8.5	The site shall consider the likelihood of survival of micro-organisms on materials and the intended use of the finished product. Where appropriate, and based on risk, a microbiological environmental monitoring programme shall be in place to ensure that the cleaning operations are effective in minimising the risk of contamination by micro-organisms that would be detrimental to the final products. Where a programme is in place, this shall include: • sampling protocol • identification of sample locations • frequency of tests • target micro-organisms • test methods • recording and evaluation of results.

Clause	Requirements
4.8.6	Where an environmental monitoring programme is in place, the site shall review the programme at least annually and whenever there are: • changes in manufacturing conditions, process flow or equipment which could impact the environmental monitoring programme • consistently negative results.

4.9 Product contamination control

All practicable steps shall be taken to identify, eliminate, avoid or minimise the risk of foreign-body, chemical or allergen contamination.

4.9.1 Glass and brittle materials control

Clause	Requirements
4.9.1.1	There shall be no unnecessary non-manufacturing glass or other brittle materials present, which may pose a foreseeable risk of contamination. Where non-manufacturing glass or other brittle materials are required in manufacturing, packing or storage areas, and where there is a risk of product contamination, systems for their safe use shall be in place. Systems for cleaning or replacing the above items shall be in place to minimise the potential for product contamination.
4.9.1.2	Glass or other brittle materials (other than the product) that pose a potential product contamination hazard shall be controlled and recorded on a register that includes, as a minimum: • a list of items detailing location, number, type and condition • recorded checks of condition of items, carried out at a specified frequency that is based on the level of risk to the product. Glass or brittle materials not in the manufacturing or storage areas shall be included in the register based on risk.
4.9.1.3	Where non-manufacturing glass or brittle materials breakage occurs, a responsible person shall be placed in charge of the clean-up operation and shall ensure that no other area is allowed to become contaminated due to the breakage. Any product that has become contaminated shall be segregated and disposed of. All breakages shall be recorded in an incident report.

4.9.2 Sharps and metal control

Clause	Requirements
4.9.2.1	There shall be a procedure for the controlled use and storage of sharp implements, including knives, blades, needles and wires, to prevent product contamination. The procedure shall include: • issue and control of sharp implements in the manufacturing, storage and ancillary areas, such as engineering workshops and laboratories • record of replacement or breakage. Snap-off blade knives shall not be used.

Clause	Requirements
4.9.2.2	Manufacturing equipment that incorporates blades or sharps shall be controlled and monitored. Blades or other sharp implements shall not be allowed to contaminate the product.

4.9.3 Chemical control

Clause	Requirements
4.9.3.1	Procedures shall be in place to manage the use, storage and handling of non-manufacturing chemicals, such as lubricants and cleaning chemicals to prevent product contamination. These shall include, as a minimum: • a register of approved chemicals for purchase • confirmation of suitability, including food or hygiene sensitive contact • use in accordance with manufacturer's instructions • availability of material safety data sheets and specifications • avoidance of strongly scented products, where potential risks of taint contamination may occur • the labelling and/or identification of containers of chemicals at all times • designated storage with access restricted to authorised personnel • procedures to manage any spills • use by trained personnel only.

4.9.4 Allergen management

Clause	Requirements
4.9.4.1	Where a potential for contamination from allergen or intrinsic allergenic components has been identified as part of the HARA, the site shall establish, implement, and maintain an allergen management plan. This plan shall minimise or eliminate the risk of contamination to and/or from the product. The plan shall meet legal requirements for labelling in the country of sale. The plan shall be reviewed based on risk, such as changes to manufacturing operations, personnel changes, raw materials and lubricants.
4.9.4.2	Where an allergen risk is identified, appropriate controls shall be established and implemented to eliminate or reduce the risk, through personnel training, raw material specifications, segregation and handling.

4.9.5 Other physical contaminants

Clause	Requirements
4.9.5.1	Notices on equipment shall be cleanable and secure and shall not pose a risk to product safety, legality and quality.
4.9.5.2	Where it poses a risk to product, wooden equipment including desks, chairs, tables, etc., shall be properly sealed to enable effective cleaning. This equipment shall be kept clean, in good condition and free from splinters or other sources of physical contamination.

Clause	Requirements
4.9.5.3	Staples, paper clips and drawing pins shall not be used in open product areas. Where staples or other items are present as packing materials or closures, appropriate precautions shall be taken to minimise the risk of product contamination.
4.9.5.4	Site issued portable handheld equipment, e.g., mobile phones, tablets, measuring equipment and similar portable items, shall be controlled by the site to minimise the risk of physical contamination.
4.9.5.5	Based on risk, procedures shall be implemented to minimise other types of foreign body contamination (i.e., types of contamination that are not specifically covered elsewhere in section 4.9).

4.10 Waste and waste disposal

Waste materials, including substandard trademarked materials, wastewater, inks, solvents and their disposal shall be managed in accordance with legal requirements and to prevent accumulation, risk of contamination and the attraction of pests.

Clause	Requirements
4.10.1	Where licensing is required by law for the removal of waste, it shall be removed by licensed contractors. Records of removal shall be maintained and available for audit.
4.10.2	Process waste shall be managed to minimise release to the environment. This shall include, but is not limited to, pellet, flake, powder, dust and offcuts.
4.10.3	Internal and external waste collection containers shall be identifiable, suitable and sufficient. They shall be emptied at appropriate frequencies and maintained in an adequately clean condition.
4.10.4	Where appropriate, waste shall be categorised according to legislative requirements based on the intended means of disposal (such as recycling). It shall be sorted, segregated, protected against contamination where necessary and collected in appropriate, designated waste containers.
4.10.5	Substandard trademarked materials shall be rendered unusable (unless otherwise agreed with customer) through a destructive process or transferred to a third party for destruction or disposal. The third party shall be a specialist in appropriate waste disposal and shall provide records of material destruction.
4.10.6	External storage of waste shall be in designated areas and designed or maintained to minimise the risk of pest harbourage.

4.11 Pest management

In order to minimise the risk of infestation and risk to products, the whole site shall have an effective preventive pest management programme in place and the resources available to respond immediately to any issues which occur.

Clause	Requirements
4.11.1	A preventive pest management programme shall be maintained, covering all areas of the site under the site's control. The site shall assess the suitability of its pest management programme to address variation in pest activity through different seasons, and consider any additional preventive activity required. The site shall document and implement any required additional activity.
4.11.2	The site shall either contract the services of a competent pest management organisation or have appropriately trained personnel for the regular inspection and treatment of the site in order to deter and eradicate infestation. The frequency of inspections shall be determined by risk assessment and documented. The risk assessment shall be reviewed whenever: • there are changes to the building or manufacturing processes which could have an impact on the pest management programme • there has been a significant pest issue. Where the services of a pest management contractor are employed, the service contract shall be clearly defined and reflect the activities of the site and comply with local legislation as required.
4.11.3	Where a site undertakes its own pest management, it shall be able to demonstrate that: • pest management operations are undertaken by trained and competent personnel with sufficient knowledge to select appropriate pest control chemicals and proofing methods and understand the limitations of use, relevant to the biology of the pests associated with the site • personnel undertaking pest management activities meet any legal requirements for training or registration • sufficient resources are available to respond to any infestation issues • there is ready access to specialist technical knowledge when required • legislation governing the use of pest control products is understood and complied with.
4.11.4	Equipment such as bait stations, traps or electric fly-killing devices shall be appropriately located and operational. Where pest control products are stored on site, dedicated locked facilities shall be used.
4.11.5	Effective precautions shall be in place to prevent pests entering the premises. The building shall be suitably proofed against the entry of all pests via doors, windows, ducts, drains and cable entry points. This shall include measures to prevent birds and flying mammals from entering buildings or roosting above loading or unloading areas.

Clause	Requirements
4.11.6	In the event of infestation, immediate action shall be taken to eliminate the hazard. Action shall be taken to identify, evaluate the potential for contamination or damage, and authorise the release of any product potentially affected.
4.11.7	At appropriate intervals, the site shall request a catch analysis from flying-insect control devices to help identify problem areas. In the event of increase in observed or measured activity, the site shall use risk assessment to determine the action required to eliminate the hazard.
4.11.8	Procedures and detailed records of pest activity, pest management inspections and recommendations shall be maintained. These shall include, as a minimum: • an up-to-date, signed and authorised site plan identifying numbered pest control devices and their locations • identification of the baits and/or monitoring devices on site • clearly defined responsibilities for the site management and the contractor • details of pest control products used and instructions for their effective use • detailed records of inspections, recommendations and of any pest infestation. It shall be the responsibility of the site to ensure that all the relevant recommendations made by the contractor or in-house expert are implemented in a timely manner and monitored for efficacy.
4.11.9	Personnel shall understand the signs of pest activity and be aware of the need to report any evidence to a designated person.

5 Product and process control

5.1 Product development

Product development or modification procedures shall be in place to ensure the manufacture of safe and legal products to defined quality parameters.

Clause	Requirements
5.1.1	Customer requirements relating to the design, development, specification, manufacture and distribution of the product shall be documented and agreed with the customer. This shall take into consideration manufacturing requirements and intended purpose where possible. Any critical-use parameters shall be identified and defined; for example, barrier requirements, maximum/minimum use temperature, machine running, use of recycled materials, and testing requirements (including migration, where relevant). Special attention shall be paid to any products that are required or requested to be manufactured from recycled materials to ensure that they are both appropriate and legal.
5.1.2	The site shall clearly define and document when a manufacturing trial is required. The site shall determine the outputs and success criteria required from a trial, and any changes and/or additions made to products, manufacturing characteristics or equipment as a result of a trial. Where appropriate, trials shall be carried out and testing shall validate that manufacturing operations are capable of producing a safe and legal product to defined quality parameters. New products or product changes shall be subject to suitable evaluation to ensure that required product safety, legality and quality parameters can be achieved. Settings derived from successfully conducted manufacturing trials or equipment installations shall be transferred accurately to manufacturing process control documentation.
5.1.3	The company shall ensure that manufacturing is carried out using defined operating conditions which result in safe and legal products to defined quality parameters.
5.1.4	Where required by the customer, a technical product specification shall be prepared and, where possible, agreed with the customer or brand owner before the manufacturing process begins.
5.1.5	Samples as agreed with the specifier shall be retained for future reference.
5.1.6	A procedure shall be in place to address the transfer of customer specifications or requirements to the site's own systems. This shall include (but is not limited to): • validation of accuracy of data transferred • how changes to customer specifications are updated and communicated • how the agreed customer defined testing requirements are met • evaluation of how changes made to the customer specifications affect the technical product specification.

5.2 Graphic design and artwork control

Artwork and all pre-press processes conducted by the site shall be managed to ensure that loss of information and variation from the customer's specifications are eliminated.

Clause	Requirements
5.2.1	The site shall have an artwork management procedure covering the activities for which the site has responsibility. This may include, but is not limited to: • collation of information to be included into artwork • receipt of artwork files from the customer • verification of completed artwork and approval by the customer including any product specific claims e.g. chain of custody.
5.2.2	A process shall be in place to seek formal acceptance and approval of final product concepts and artworks by the customer. The outcome shall be documented.
5.2.3	Where appropriate, print trials shall be carried out and testing shall validate that the agreed product quality and print standards can be consistently achieved.
5.2.4	Printing equipment such as plates, silk screens, anilox rollers, cylinders and blankets shall be verified as being correct to specification, artwork version or agreed master prior to use. They shall be fully traceable to the customer's approved origination material.
5.2.5	Customer-approved reference material, including artwork masters and colour standards used during print runs, shall be controlled to ensure minimisation of degradation and shall be returned to appropriate storage after use. The site shall have a policy to address requirements for the renewal of approved masters, as necessary.
5.2.6	The site shall have a procedure for managing changes to artwork and print specifications to manage obsolete artwork and printing materials.
5.2.7	Where artwork files and approved masters are in electronic form, these shall be suitably protected to prevent loss or malicious intervention.

5.3 Print control

Where products are printed or decorated, procedures shall be in place to ensure that the information is fully legible and correctly reproduced to customer specification and complies with any legal requirements.

Clause	Requirements
5.3.1	An assessment shall be carried out for the pre-press activity, print process and handling of printed product to identify: • risks of loss of essential information • mixing of printed product. Controls shall be established and implemented to reduce the risks identified.

Clause	Requirements
5.3.2	Printing plates, cylinders, cutting dies, print blankets and any other printing equipment shall be appropriately stored to minimise damage.
5.3.3	Each print run shall be approved against the agreed standard (or reference sample). This shall be recorded.
5.3.4	A system shall be in place to detect and identify printing errors during the run and to sort these errors from the acceptable printed product.
5.3.5	Where composite print is used, a system shall be in place to ensure effective segregation of differing print variants.
5.3.6	Any unused printed product shall be accounted for and either disposed of or identified and appropriately stored.
5.3.7	Lighting in print inspection cabinets and other means of print/colour checking shall be agreed with the customer or conform to accepted industry standards.

5.4 Manufacturing process control



Fundamental

Procedures, work instructions and specifications shall be in place to ensure effective compliance with product and customer requirements throughout the manufacturing operations.

Clause	Requirements
5.4.1	The site shall identify and record all potential product quality defects that are reasonably expected to occur at each step, in relation to the product and manufacturing operations.
5.4.2	The site shall identify manufacturing process control points that can prevent or limit the risk of producing products with quality defects.
5.4.3	For each manufacturing process control point, machine settings or control limits shall be established and documented.
5.4.4	A bill of materials and/or specification (including manufacturing process control points) shall be available for each batch or lot during manufacturing.
5.4.5	Manufacturing process checks shall be undertaken and recorded at start-up, following adjustments to equipment and periodically during manufacturing, to ensure products are consistently produced to the agreed specification.
5.4.6	In the event of equipment failure, or deviation of the manufacturing process from specification, procedures shall be in place to establish the quality status of the product and determine the action to be taken in accordance with clause 3.11.

Clause	Requirements
5.4.7	Where finished product is labelled and sold by quantity, the frequency and methodology of quantity control shall meet the requirements of the appropriate legislation governing quantity verification. A record of checks shall be maintained. Where the quantity of the product is not governed by legislation, the product shall conform to customer requirements and records shall be maintained.
5.4.8	Where appropriate, or as a customer requirement, identifiable and traceable samples of product shall be retained, for a defined period.
5.4.9	A manufacturing line clearance procedure shall be in place and fully implemented. The procedure shall ensure that at start-up and prior to any changeover, the line is clear of: • all previous work raw material • work in process • product and product packing • labels • manufacturing documentation. The line clearance procedure shall include: • the roles of persons involved • areas where materials can become trapped • validation of the line clearance • sign-off for continuing manufacturing.
5.4.10	Where a site handles products, materials or areas on site that are outside the scope of the certification, these shall be controlled to ensure they do not create a product safety, legality, or quality risk to products within scope.

5.5 Calibration and control of measuring and monitoring devices

The site shall be able to demonstrate that measuring and monitoring equipment is sufficiently accurate and reliable to provide confidence in measurement results.

Clause	Requirements
5.5.1	The site shall identify, and control in-line and off-line measuring equipment used to monitor critical control measures (where applicable) and product safety, legality and quality. This shall include, as a minimum: • a register of equipment and its location • an identification code and re-calibration due date, where applicable • the calibration date, as applicable, and any adjustments required • prevention from adjustment by unauthorised personnel • protection from damage, deterioration and misuse.
5.5.2	The accuracy of measuring equipment shall be specified (with permitted tolerances), having due regard to the product parameter being controlled.
5.5.3	All identified measuring equipment shall be checked and adjusted at a predetermined frequency, based on risk. This shall be carried out by trained personnel to a defined method, to ensure accuracy within defined parameters. All results shall be recorded.

Clause	Requirements
5.5.4	Where appropriate, reference measuring equipment shall be calibrated and traceable to a recognised national or international standard and records maintained. Where a traceable calibration is not possible, the site shall demonstrate the basis by which calibration is carried out.
5.5.5	Procedures shall be in place to record actions taken when a failure is identified of the equipment used for product inspection, testing or measuring. Any such failures shall be subject to an assessment of potential risk to the product. Where the safety, legality or quality of the product is based on equipment found to be inaccurate, action shall be taken to ensure at-risk product is not released.

5.6 Product inspection, testing and measuring

The site shall undertake appropriate inspections and testing that are critical to product safety, legality and quality.

Clause	Requirements
5.6.1	The site shall determine the need for product testing, inspection or measuring equipment to ensure product safety, legality and quality.
5.6.2	The inspection or testing procedures used by the site shall be validated to ensure their accuracy and reproducibility. Recognised test procedures shall be used, where available.
5.6.3	Product inspection and testing procedures shall be in place, and carried out at appropriate stages in manufacturing to demonstrate that the finished product is within the tolerances laid down in the agreed product specification. These procedures shall include: • frequency of product inspection or testing and sample quantity in accordance with industry-accepted practice, or customer requirements and based on risk • identification of authorised, trained and demonstrably competent personnel carrying out the product inspection or testing • records of product inspection or testing undertaken and results • review of the results to identify the significance and to enable action to be taken accordingly • definition of how samples used for product inspection or testing are managed. This may be by retaining, returning to stock, reworking/recycling, or disposal.

Clause	Requirements
5.6.4	Where inspection or testing equipment is integrated into the manufacturing operations and is critical to product safety, legality and quality, the site shall establish and implement procedures for the operation and testing of the equipment. The procedures shall ensure that equipment is correctly set up and capable of alerting, rejecting or identifying when the product is out-of-specification. Where appropriate, verification of accuracy and effectiveness of the equipment shall be completed at: • the start and end of manufacturing run • a frequency based on the site's ability to identify, hold and prevent the release of any implicated materials should the equipment fail (e.g., during manufacturing, or when changing batches of raw materials) • a frequency based on equipment manufacturer's recommendation.
5.6.5	Inspection and testing procedures and customer-approved reference samples (where required) shall be of the most recent version and be available at the location where the activity is conducted.
5.6.6	Where testing critical to product safety or legality is undertaken, the internal or external testing facility shall have gained recognised accreditation or operate in accordance with the requirements and principles of ISO/IEC17025, including competency testing where applicable. Documented justification shall be available where accredited methods or reference methods are not undertaken. The significance of the results shall be understood and acted upon.

5.7 Incoming goods

The site shall ensure that incoming goods are appropriately checked for contents, integrity and potential contamination.

Clause	Requirements
5.7.1	A raw materials and work-in-progress intake procedure shall be in place to ensure that incoming goods match purchase or product specifications. For example, checking of purchase orders, or delivery notes. Acceptance criteria for incoming goods shall be defined and may include testing, certificate of analysis, statement of compliance or certificate of conformance. All raw materials awaiting the results of testing or verification of data, shall be held until released for use.
5.7.2	There shall be a procedure for the inspection of incoming goods on arrival to ensure that products are free from pest infestation, contamination or damage and are in a satisfactory condition. Defects identified by the site shall be reviewed as defined in clause 3.11. Unloading areas for bulk deliveries shall be clearly identified and designed to prevent raw material cross-contamination.

Clause	Requirements
5.7.3	Receipt documents and/or product identification shall facilitate correct stock rotation of goods in storage and, where appropriate, ensure materials are used in the correct order and within the prescribed shelf life - e.g. first in first out (FIFO) and first expiry first out (FEFO).
5.7.4	The site shall have a system in place to verify all raw materials and work in progress, prior to their release to the manufacturing operation.

5.8 Storage of all materials, work in progress and finished products

The handling, management and storage of all materials and products shall minimise the risk of contamination or malicious intervention, and protect product safety, legality and quality.

Clause	Requirements
5.8.1	Procedures to maintain product safety, legality and quality during storage shall be risk-based, understood by the relevant personnel, and implemented accordingly. They shall include, as appropriate: • instructions for the packing of finished product • segregation of products where necessary to avoid cross-contamination, mixing of materials/batches, or taint • storage of product/materials off the floor and away from walls • specific handling or stacking requirements to prevent product damage.
5.8.2	All materials, work in progress and finished product shall be properly identified and protected during storage by appropriate packaging to protect them from contamination.
5.8.3	Storage, including off-site storage and external storage, shall be controlled to protect the product from contamination, including taint or odour and malicious intervention. Where off-site storage is used, the same site standards apply as for on-site storage. Where external storage of raw materials, pallets, work-in-progress or finished products is undertaken, these shall be stored to minimise the risk of contamination. Deliveries from external storage shall be inspected prior to entry to internal storage and manufacturing areas.
5.8.4	Storage practices where appropriate shall ensure effective stock rotation e.g. FIFO or FEFO.
5.8.5	To prevent contamination, procedures shall be in place to appropriately segregate raw materials, work-in-progress, products finished products and materials intended for recycling.

5.9 Dispatch and transport

The dispatch and transport of raw materials, work in progress and finished products shall be undertaken in a manner that minimises the risk of contamination or malicious intervention and maintains product safety, legality and quality.

Clause	Requirements
5.9.1	The company shall have procedures for the dispatch and transport of products, which shall include: • any restrictions on the use of combined loads (e.g. where materials from other companies are in the same transport) • requirements for the security of products during transit, particularly when vehicles are parked and unattended • product release systems.
5.9.2	All products and materials shall be identified and protected during distribution by appropriate external packing or transported under conditions to protect the product from contamination, risk of taint or odour and of malicious intervention.
5.9.3	Pallets that come into direct contact with finished products or raw materials shall not be allowed to cause contamination. Pallets shall be checked prior to use and be intact, dry, clean and free from damage and contamination. Unacceptable pallets shall not be used.
5.9.4	All company-owned or leased vehicles used for deliveries shall be included in the documented cleaning schedules and kept clean and in a condition that minimises the risk of product contamination.
5.9.5	All vehicles and shipping containers used for product movements shall be fit for purpose and subject to a recorded check of cleanliness and odour before loading.
5.9.6	Where the company employs third-party transport contractors, there shall be a contract or agreed terms and conditions. All the requirements specified in this section shall be clearly defined in the contract or the company shall be certificated to the Global Standard Storage and Distribution or other GFSI benchmarked standard. Where this is not possible, with general carriers, the packing shall be adequate to protect the product against damage, contamination hazards, taint and odour.
5.9.7	Vehicle drivers shall comply with the site rules relevant to this Standard. Access to the site for third-party transport personnel shall be controlled and, where possible, facilities provided to negate the need to enter storage or manufacturing areas.

6 Personnel

6.1 Training and competence: raw materials handling, preparation, manufacturing, packing and storage areas



Fundamental

The site shall ensure that all personnel performing work that affects product safety, legality and quality are adequately trained, instructed and supervised commensurate with their activity and that they are competent to undertake their job role.

Clause	Requirements
6.1.1	All relevant personnel, including temporary personnel and contractors, shall be appropriately trained prior to commencing work and adequately supervised throughout the working period. Induction training shall include the site personal hygiene requirements.
6.1.2	The site shall put in place procedures covering the training needs of relevant personnel. These shall include, as a minimum, the: • identification of necessary competencies for specific roles • provision of training, or other action to ensure personnel have the necessary competencies • review of the effectiveness of training and trainers • delivery of training in the appropriate language of trainees.
6.1.3	Where personnel are engaged in activities relating to manufacturing process control points and critical control measures, specific training and competency assessment shall be in place.
6.1.4	The site shall define how new or changed procedures, working methods and practices related to product safety, legality or quality are communicated to relevant personnel.
6.1.5	Records of training shall be available. These shall include the: • name of the trainee and confirmation of attendance • date and duration of the training • title or course contents, as appropriate • training provider (external or internal provider). Where training is undertaken by approved service providers on behalf of the company, records of the training shall be available.
6.1.6	The site shall routinely review and document the competencies of all personnel and provide relevant training as appropriate. This may be through training courses, refresher training, coaching, mentoring or on-the-job experience.

6.2 Personal hygiene: raw materials handling, preparation, manufacturing, packing and storage areas

Personal hygiene requirements shall be established to minimise the risk of product contamination from personnel. These shall be appropriate to the products manufactured. Personnel, including those supplied by agencies, visitors and contractors shall comply.

Clause	Requirements
6.2.1	The requirements for personal hygiene shall be based on risk assessment of the potential hazards that could occur during manufacturing and storage, and appropriate to the intended use of the finished product. Where identified, these requirements shall be documented and communicated to relevant personnel. The requirements shall consider as a minimum: • wearing of wrist bands, wrist-worn devices or watches • jewellery, including piercings on exposed parts of the body, except for a plain wedding ring, wedding wristband, medical alert jewellery or medical monitoring devices • fingernails including length, hygiene, varnish, false nails and nail art • excessive perfume or aftershave, where there is a tainting risk. Compliance with these requirements shall be checked routinely.
6.2.2	The presence of personal items and belongings, including mobile phones in manufacturing and storage areas shall be controlled and managed by the site.
6.2.3	The use and storage of personal medicines in manufacturing and storage areas shall be controlled and managed by the site.
6.2.4	All cuts and grazes on exposed skin shall be covered by an appropriately coloured plaster that is different from the product colour, preferably blue. These shall be site-controlled according to the level of product handling and to the intended use of the finished product. Where appropriate, in addition to the plaster, a finger stall or glove shall be worn.
6.2.5	Handwashing shall be performed prior to commencing work, after breaks and as often as appropriate to the level of risk to the finished product.
6.2.6	Where visitors cannot comply with site hygiene requirements, suitable control procedures shall be in place (e.g. non-handling of product, use of gloves).

6.3 Personnel facilities

Personnel facilities shall be sufficient to accommodate the required number of personnel and shall be designed and operated to minimise the risk of product contamination.

Clause	Requirements
6.3.1	Changing rooms shall be accessed without the need to enter manufacturing areas, unless appropriately segregated walkways are in place.
6.3.2	Appropriate storage shall be provided for all personnel who work in raw material handling, preparation, manufacturing, packing and storage areas.
6.3.3	Site-issued protective clothing and personal clothing shall not be stored in the same locker or shall be appropriately segregated based on risk.
6.3.4	Suitably located and sufficient hand-washing facilities shall be available. Such hand-washing facilities shall provide, as a minimum: • sufficient quantity of water at a suitable temperature to encourage handwashing • unscented liquid/foam soap • adequate hand-drying facilities • advisory signs to prompt use (including signs in appropriate languages).
6.3.5	Toilets shall not open directly into manufacturing and storage areas. Toilets shall be provided with suitable and sufficient hand-washing facilities, as defined in requirement 6.3.4.
6.3.6	Facilities for visitors and contractors shall enable compliance with the site's personal hygiene requirements.
6.3.7	All food brought onto site shall be stored in a clean and hygienic state. Food shall be consumed within designated areas.
6.3.8	Eating (including confectionery and chewing of gum or tobacco), drinking and smoking (including electronic cigarettes) shall not be allowed in the manufacturing, storage and other areas, such as laboratory, engineering, storage locker and changing rooms. If it is impractical for personnel to leave their work area for these purposes, designated, controlled facilities segregated from manufacturing areas (such as a fully walled, or clearly separated area with hand-washing facilities) shall be provided.
6.3.9	Drinking of water from purpose-made dispensers and/or by using disposable conical cups or spill-proof lidded containers may be allowed, provided it is confined to designated areas, away from product and manufacturing equipment.
6.3.10	Where smoking, including electronic cigarettes, is allowed within buildings under national law, designated controlled areas shall be provided isolated from manufacturing and storage areas with sufficient extraction to the exterior of the building. Adequate arrangements for dealing with smokers' waste shall be provided at smoking facilities, both inside buildings and at external locations.

6.4 Medical screening

Sites shall ensure that procedures are in place to ensure that health conditions likely to adversely affect product safety are monitored and controlled.

Clause	Requirements
6.4.1	The site shall make personnel aware of the symptoms of infection, disease or condition which would prevent a person working in contact with the product. It shall be based on risk to the intended use of the finished product, or where local legislation is in place. The site shall have a procedure which enables notification by personnel (including temporary personnel) of any relevant symptoms, infection, disease or condition, which they may have been in contact with or may be suffering from. Where there may be a risk to product safety, personnel suffering from any of the above shall be excluded from work involving contact with the product the direct handling of food contact or hygiene-sensitive product for as long as the symptoms persist.
6.4.2	Where permitted by law, visitors and contractors shall be required to complete a health questionnaire or otherwise confirm that they are not suffering from any symptoms of infection, disease or conditions which may put product safety at risk, prior to being allowed into manufacturing, packing or storage areas.

6.5 Protective clothing

Appropriate protective clothing shall be worn in manufacturing and storage areas to minimise the risk of product contamination.

Clause	Requirements
6.5.1	Based on risk assessment, and appropriate to the hazards posed to the intended use of the finished product, wearing of the following in manufacturing and storage areas, shall be considered: • hair coverings • beard snoods • protective clothing • protective footwear • protective gloves. Where risk assessment has determined these are not required in a particular area, it shall be fully justified.
6.5.2	Where worn, sufficient, site-issued sets of protective clothing shall be provided. Protective clothing worn by personnel, temporary personnel, contractors and visitors in manufacturing and storage areas shall be clean and provide adequate coverage of personal clothing. The protective clothing shall have no external pockets on the upper body garments or sewn-on buttons.

Clause	Requirements
6.5.3	Disposable protective clothing, if used, shall be suitably designed and subject to adequate control to avoid product contamination.
6.5.4	If gloves are used, they shall be replaced regularly, be distinctive, intact and not cause a contamination risk to the product.
6.5.5	Based on risk assessment, and appropriate to the hazards posed to the intended use of the finished product, the site shall define the rules regarding the wearing of protective clothing in all situations, including: • to and from the site • when away from the manufacturing areas, (e.g., removal before entering toilets, canteen, ancillary areas, or smoking areas).
6.5.6	Protective clothing, including health and safety clothing, shall be kept clean and laundered. Laundering shall be carried out by one of the following methods: • professional laundry service • site-controlled laundering facilities • home laundry.
6.5.7	Where home laundry of protective clothing is permitted, the site shall ensure that: • personnel have received written instructions regarding the laundering process to be used. These shall be reinforced as part of an induction or in-house training programme • personnel shall be provided with a bag or other suitable means to safely transport washed protective clothing from home to the site • there is a system for monitoring the effectiveness of home laundering • a procedure and system shall be in place for dealing with any case where personnel are unable to perform home laundry effectively.
6.5.8	Storage of clean protective clothing on site shall be controlled to prevent cross-contamination.

7 Requirements for traded products

Traded products are defined as site purchased products that would normally fall within the scope of the Standard and are stored at the site being audited, but are not manufactured, reworked, or packed at that site.

Intercompany/site product movements are not considered as traded products, as these are not normally purchased by the site receiving, storing and despatching the goods.

The site's management of these products is covered by the requirements in this section.

All the relevant requirements from sections 1 to 6 must also be fulfilled in addition to the requirements outlined in this section.

Where a site wishes to be audited against this section of the Standard, all the products and raw materials traded must be included in the audit scope. It is not permitted to include some traded products or raw materials and exclude others.

Non-conformities against clauses within this section of the Standard will be recorded on the audit report and included in the calculation of the site's grade.

Where a site has traded products or raw materials on site but wishes them to be excluded from the scope of the audit, this will be recorded as an exclusion from scope on the audit report and certificate. The BRCGS packaging materials logo can be used, but shall not be used for promoting traded products, even when included in the certificated scope.

7.1 Hazard analysis and risk assessment of traded products

The site shall operate a HARA plan for the operations for which it is responsible.

Clause	Requirements
7.1.1	The company shall either: • have a HARA plan specifically for the traded products handled on site or • incorporate the traded products into its existing HARA (see section 2). The scope of the traded products HARA plan shall include the products and the processes for which the site is responsible. At a minimum, this shall include receipt, storage and dispatch.

7.2 Approval and performance monitoring of manufacturers/packers of traded products

The company shall operate procedures for approval of the last manufacturer/packer of traded products to ensure that products traded are safe, legal and manufactured in accordance with any defined product specifications.

Clause	Requirements
7.2.1	The company shall conduct a risk assessment of the products traded considering: • the nature of the product and associated risks • customer-specific requirements • legislative requirements in the country of sale or importation of the product • the brand identity of the products.

Clause	Requirements
7.2.2	Based on the risk assessment (requirement 7.2.1) the company shall have a procedure for the initial and ongoing approval of the manufacturers/packer of traded products. This approval procedure shall include, either one or a combination of: • valid certification to a globally recognised product safety management system e.g. certification to the applicable BRCGS Standard or GFSI-benchmarked standard • certification to a globally recognised quality management system that incorporates an assessment of traceability and confirmation that products supplied are safe and legal e.g. declaration of compliance. The scope of the certification shall include the traded products purchased • supplier audits, with a scope to include a review of the product safety system, traceability and prerequisite controls, undertaken by an experienced and demonstrably competent product safety auditor. A full audit report shall be available. Where the supplier audit is completed by a second- or third-party, the company shall be able to: • demonstrate the competency of the auditor • confirm that the scope of the audit includes a review of the product safety system, traceability and prerequisite controls • obtain, review and approve a copy of the full audit report • a manufacturer/packer self-audit questionnaire or manufacturer/packer-provided information may be used for approval, where a valid risk-based justification is provided. The questionnaire shall have a scope that includes the product safety system for the product supplied, verification of traceability system, and prerequisite controls, and it shall be reviewed and approved by a demonstrably competent person. Where approval cannot be based on the above, then the company shall be able to demonstrate their criteria for approval and evaluation of the manufacturer/packer to ensure that all traded products comply with requirements associated with product safety, legality and quality and meet specifications. Ongoing approval of manufacturers/packers shall be at agreed intervals based on risk, and manufacturers/packers shall be required to notify the site of any significant changes in the interim, including any change in certification status.
7.2.3	Records shall be maintained of the manufacturer's or packer's approval process, including audit reports or verified certificates confirming the product safety status of the sites supplying the products traded. There shall be a process of review, and records showing the follow-up of issues identified at the manufacturing/packing sites with the potential to affect products traded by the company.
7.2.4	There shall be a performance review of manufacturers or packers, based on risk and using defined performance criteria, which shall include: • complaints • results of any product tests • regulatory warnings/alerts • customer rejections or feedback. The process shall be fully implemented.

7.3 Specifications

Specifications or information to meet legal requirements and assist customers in the safe usage of the product shall be maintained and available to customers.

Clause	Requirements
7.3.1	Specifications shall be available for all traded products. These shall either be in the agreed format as supplied by the customer or, where this is not specified, include key data to meet legal requirements and assist the customer in the safe usage of the product. Specifications may be in the form of a printed or electronic document, or part of an online specification system.
7.3.2	The site shall seek formal agreement of the specifications with relevant parties. Where specifications are not formally agreed, the site shall be able to demonstrate that it has taken steps to put an agreement in place.
7.3.3	The site shall operate demonstrable processes to ensure that any customer-specified requirements are met. This may be by inclusion of customer requirements within buying specifications.
7.3.4	Specifications shall be reviewed whenever products or manufacturers/packers change or at appropriate predetermined intervals. The date of review and the approval of any changes shall be recorded.

7.4 Product inspection and testing

The site shall operate processes to ensure that the traded products received comply with specifications and that the supplied product is in accordance with customer requirements.

Clause	Requirements
7.4.1	Risk assessment shall be used to identify product sampling or testing requirements to verify that the traded products are in accordance with specifications and meet product safety, legality and quality requirements. Where verification is based on sampling, the sample rate and assessment process shall be risk-based. Records of the results of assessments or analysis shall be maintained.
7.4.2	Where verification of conformity is provided by the supplier (e.g. certificates of conformity or analysis), the company shall use risk assessment to determine whether periodic independent product analysis may be required to ensure confidence in the information provided.
7.4.3	Where claims are made about the traded products, including the provenance, chain of custody or assured status, supporting information shall be available from the supplier, or independently to verify the claim.

Clause	Requirements
7.4.4	Where testing critical to traded product safety or legality is undertaken, the internal or external testing facility shall have gained recognised accreditation or operate in accordance with the requirements and principles of ISO/IEC 17025, including competency testing where applicable. Where accredited test methods or reference methods are not undertaken documented justification shall be available.
7.4.5	Test and inspection results shall be retained and reviewed to identify trends. Appropriate actions shall be implemented promptly to address any unsatisfactory results or trends.

7.5 Product legality

The company shall have processes in place to ensure that the traded products comply with the legal requirements in the country of sale, where known.

Clause	Requirements
7.5.1	The company shall have processes to verify the legality of traded products. These shall include, as applicable: • labelling information • compliance with relevant legal compositional requirements • compliance with quantity or volume requirements. Where such responsibilities are undertaken by the customer, this shall be clearly stated in contracts.

7.6 Traceability

The site shall be able to trace all traded product back to the last manufacturer/packer and forward to the customer.

Clause	Requirements
7.6.1	The site's traceability procedure (see clause 3.10.1) shall include details of the system used for the traceability of traded products. The site shall maintain a traceability system for all batches of traded product that identifies the last manufacturer or packer of the product. Records shall be maintained to identify the recipient of each batch of traded product from the site.
7.6.2	The site shall test the system at least annually to ensure that traceability can be determined back to the last manufacturer/packer and forward to the recipient of the traded product. This shall include identification of the movement of the product through the chain from the manufacturer/packer to receipt by the site and distribution to the customer including each movement and intermediate place of storage.
7.6.3	The traceability test shall include the reconciliation of quantities of product received by the site for the chosen batch. Traceability should be achievable within 4 hours (1 day when information is required from external parties).

Part III

Audit protocol

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Part III

Audit protocol

Introduction

The Global Standard Packaging Materials (the Standard) provides companies with a series of options with which to be audited and certificated. This flexible approach is in response to market demand and allows companies to choose an audit option which best suits their customers' requirements, factory manufacturing operations and the maturity of their product safety systems.

The audit protocol describes the requirements and explains the rules for auditing and certification which are applicable to all audit programmes (announced, blended and unannounced). This is an essential element of the Standard and should be read and fully understood.

Every effort has been made to ensure that the content of the Standard is accurate at the time of publication. However, it may be subject to minor change. Any additions or amendments to this normative document will be published as 'position statements' (see section 6.2). Reference should be made to the BRCGS website (www.brcgs.com) or BRCGS Participate where changes will be published.

Conformance by the company to the requirements of the Standard and its suitability for the awarding and continuing retention of certification will be assessed by an independent audit company – the certification body. Certification will be graded according to the audit option selected and the number and type of non-conformities, which shall also influence the frequency of ongoing audits.

The process is summarised in Figure 1 which summarises the steps to follow for a company seeking certification.

Learn

- Visit www.brcgs.com
- Download a copy of the Standard
- Review any appropriate guidelines

Audit preparation

- Select an audit option (announced, unannounced or blended), with or without additional modules
- Self-assess compliance with the Standard
- Select a certification body
- Define scope of the audit

Audit planning

- Ensure information and appropriate personnel are available for the audit, even in the event of an unannounced audit
- Provide information to certification body for audit preparation
- Define audit date (or parameters if unannounced) and agree audit duration based on audit duration calculator

Audit

- The audit will consist of several different audit techniques, including:
- Opening meeting
 - Manufacturing facility inspection
 - Document review
 - Vertical audit (including traceability challenge)
 - Final review of findings
 - Closing meeting

Non-conformities and corrective action

- Carry out corrective action, root cause analysis and develop a preventive action plan for any non-conformities identified. Evidence must be submitted within 28 days of the end of the audit
- Certification body reviews evidence in 14 days
- If corrective action, root cause analysis and preventive action plan are deemed satisfactory, a certificate, audit report and corresponding grade will be issued within 42 days of the audit

Post-audit

- Ongoing maintenance of the Standard and continual improvement
- Get login details for the BRCGS Directory and share audit report
- Use of BRCGS logo
- Ongoing communication with certification body
- Schedule re-audit date before the next audit is due

Figure 1 Audit protocol – how to gain certification

1 General protocol – audit preparation

1.1 Selection of an audit option

There are three options and processes available for sites to demonstrate their commitment to the Standard, as summarised in Figure 2.

1.1.1 Announced audit programme (with mandatory unannounced audit every 3 years)

This is available for existing certificated sites and those new to certification. For announced audits, the audit date is agreed with the certification body in advance of the audit and all requirements of the Standard are audited within the audit visit. Once every 3 years, the audit will be unannounced; the certification body will notify the site within 3 months of the previous audit date. This will ensure that the site is aware that an unannounced audit will take place in the coming year. However, the actual date of the unannounced audit will not be communicated to the site in advance.

For an announced audit, successful sites are awarded a certificate with a grade of AA, A, B, C or D, depending on the number and type of non-conformities identified. For the mandatory unannounced audit, successful sites will receive an unannounced grade of AA+, A+, B+, C+ or D+, depending on the number and type of non-conformities identified.

More details on the announced audit programme can be found in section 2.

1.1.2 Blended announced audit programme (with mandatory unannounced audit every 3 years)

The blended announced audit programme uses information and communication technology (ICT) to remotely audit documented systems and records.

The audit is split into two separate parts: a remote audit followed by an on-site audit. The remote audit (first part) uses ICT to focus predominantly on documented systems and records, while the on-site audit (second part) focuses predominantly on manufacturing, storage and other on-site areas.

A blended audit can only be offered by the certification body following a risk assessment which:

- confirms that a robust audit is possible (e.g. remote technology is available at the site)
- assesses the percentage of the audit that can be completed remotely.

More details on the risk assessment can be found in section 3.1.5.

At the time of publication, the blended audit option is available for announced re-certification audits only and not for initial audits (i.e. the first BRCGS audit at a site). Successful sites are awarded a certificate with grade AA, A, B, C or D, depending on the number and type of non-conformities identified.

More details on the blended announced audit protocol can be found in section 3.

1.1.3 Unannounced audit programme

The unannounced audit option is available to all sites; although sites which are not currently certificated need to recognise that the audit may not take place for up to 1 year from the date of application. The unannounced audit option provides sites with the opportunity to demonstrate the maturity of their quality systems and successful sites are awarded grades of AA+, A+, B+, C+ or D+ depending upon the type and number of non-conformities identified at the audit.

The conducting of an independent, unannounced review of the manufacturing facilities, systems and procedures under this scheme provides a site's customers with added confidence in the site's ability to consistently maintain standards. This may influence the frequency of customer audits, where conducted, and other performance measures applied by the customer.

More details on the unannounced audit programme highlighting the differences between the announced and unannounced protocols can be found in section 4.

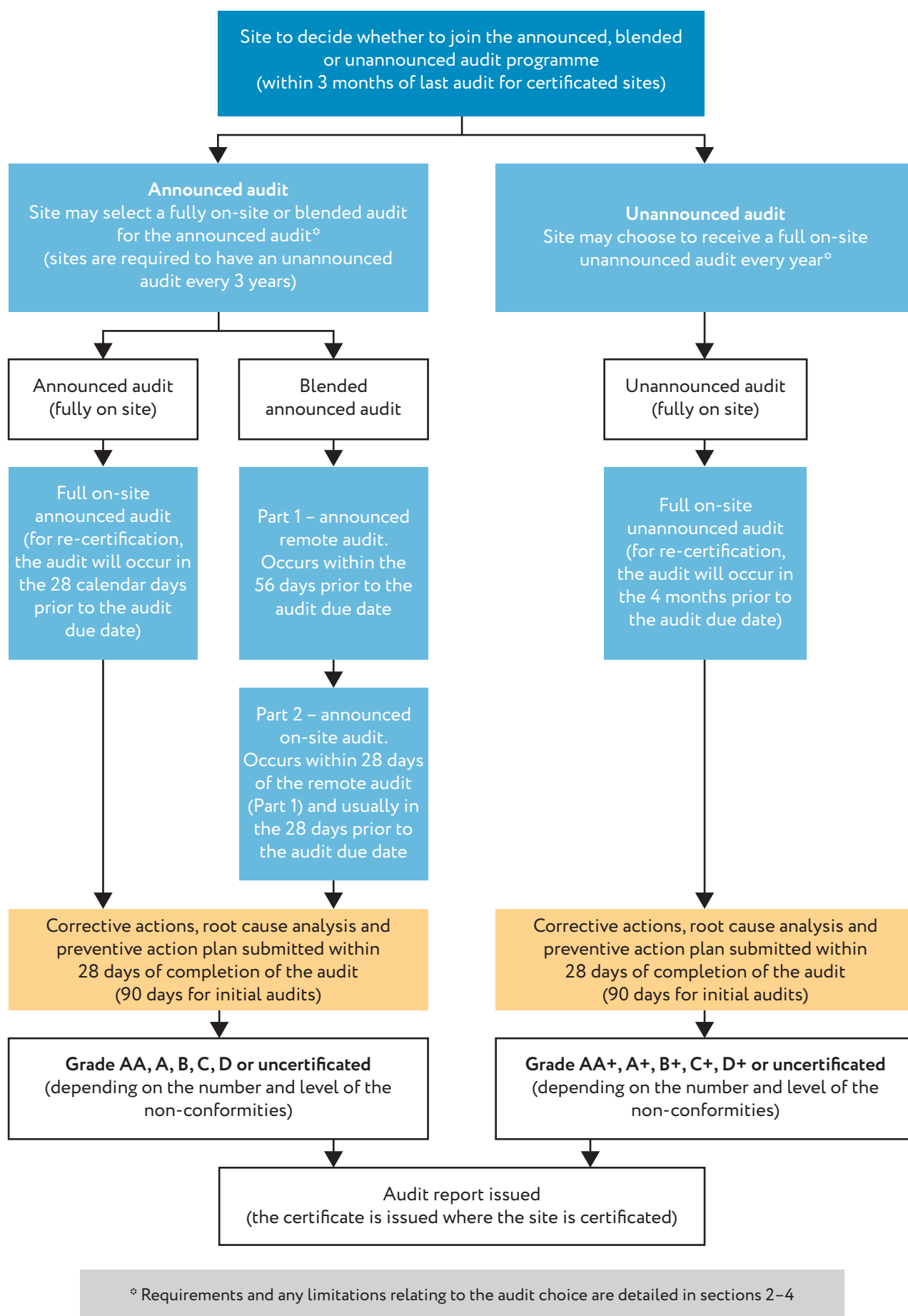


Figure 2 Audit options flow diagram

1.2 Self-assessment of compliance with the Standard

It is essential that the site is assessed against the current issue of the Standard and any current position statements, all of which are available on the **BRCGS website** or **Participate**.

The Standard should be read and understood, and a preliminary self-assessment should be conducted by the company against the Standard to prepare for the audit. Any areas that need to be improved to meet the requirements should be addressed by the company to prevent a non-conformity being raised at the audit.

Further information, guidance and training to ensure compliance with the Standard, including a downloadable self-assessment tool, are available from the BRCGS website. BRCGS also has a full range of further guidelines and supporting materials available through the website or, for certificated sites, from BRCGS Participate.

An optional on-site pre-assessment may be carried out by the selected certification body in preparation for the audit to provide guidance to the site on the process of certification.

Certification bodies shall ensure that any pre-assessment meets the requirements for accreditation. For example, consultancy cannot be provided by the certification body that will later undertake the certification audit, so the same auditor cannot be used for both the pre-assessment and the certification audit.

Manufacturing units that are newly built or 'commissioned' shall ensure that systems and procedures in place are compliant before an initial audit is undertaken. It is at the discretion of the company when it wishes to invite a certification body to carry out an audit; however, it is unlikely that full compliance can be satisfactorily demonstrated at an audit undertaken less than 3 months from commencement of operation. This is likely to be the situation even where the site for certification uses quality systems developed by other certificated companies in the group. Timescales for audits shall be agreed between the site and the certification body.

1.3 Selection of a certification body

Audits against a BRCGS Standard are only recognised if these are undertaken by certification bodies that are recognised and approved by BRCGS.

BRCGS cannot advise on the selection of a specific certification body; however, it has a comprehensive programme of measurement of certification body performance around specified key performance indicators (KPI's). The results of performance measurement are converted to a 5-star rating and published with the listing of all approved certification bodies in the **BRCGS Directory**. The company should ensure that its selected certification body is accepted by its customers (e.g. only 4- or 5-star-rated certification bodies may be accepted by some customers).

1.4 Company/certification body contractual arrangements

A contract shall exist between the company and the certification body in accordance with the requirements of ISO/IEC 17065, detailing the scope of the audit and the reporting requirements. The contract shall also contain clauses which allow the effective management of the scheme by BRCGS and accreditation of the certification body by their accreditation body. These are essential to ensure confidence in the way in which the scheme is managed and consistency achieved, which benefits all certificated sites. In particular, the following are conditions of certification to the scheme:

- A copy of the audit report and any subsequent certificate or audit result shall be supplied to BRCGS and may be supplied to the accreditation body in the agreed format for the Standard. Records may be viewed in conjunction with any GFSI compliance audit. Other documents in relation to the audit shall be made available to BRCGS upon request. All documents submitted to BRCGS shall be copies of original documents. Documents provided will be treated as confidential.
- Where agreements are in place, BRCGS may make audit reports and certificates available to customers of sites. Sharing can be removed by the site at any time through the BRCGS Directory.

- The auditor(s) may be accompanied by other personnel for training, assessment or calibration purposes. This activity may include:
 - training of new auditors by the certification body
 - routine certification body shadow audit programmes
 - witness audits by accreditation bodies
 - witness audits by BRCGS.

BRCGS reserves the right to conduct its own audit or visit to a site once certificated in response to complaints or as part of routine compliance activity to ensure the integrity of the scheme. Such visits may be announced or unannounced.

BRCGS may contact the site directly in relation to its certification status, for feedback on certification body performance or for investigation into reported issues.

This publication sets out the requirements against which sites will be audited. Contracts between the certification body and the site shall include a clause acknowledging these obligations. This contract will be formulated by the certification body.

Non-compliance with any of these contractual obligations shall be communicated to BRCGS and may result in additional certification integrity activities being undertaken. Non-compliance may also affect the certification status of the site.

1.5 Service fee

BRCGS requires a service fee to be collected by the certification body from the company for every audit undertaken. This covers the service package that allows the company to access a suite of BRCGS products, including BRCGS Participate, BRCGS Professional and the BRCGS Directory. The certificate and audit report shall be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory but shall not be valid until the service fee and the certification body's audit fees have been received, irrespective of the outcome of the certification process.

For more information about what is available in the service package, see www.brcgs.com.

1.6 Scope of audit

1.6.1 Defining the audit scope

The scope of the audit (products produced and manufacturing operations) shall be agreed between the site and the certification body in advance of the audit to ensure the allocation of an auditor (or auditors) with the correct category and product knowledge.

The audit shall include all applicable requirements within the Standard and all manufacturing operations undertaken for the products included within the scope at the site seeking certification.

The audit scope and any permitted exclusions shall be clearly defined and unambiguous both on the audit report and on any certificate issued.

The wording of the scope, description of the product, and where applicable, the intended use of the product, shall enable a recipient of the report or certificate to clearly identify whether the products supplied have been included within the scope.

The scope description on reports and certificates shall include:

- the manufacturing categories and products manufactured
- a description of the manufacturing activities undertaken at the site that fall within the scope of the Standard
- the intended use of the product (i.e. direct food contact, use in the food industry, use in non-food packaging industry)
- clear description of products purchased and stored for resale by a site ('traded products')

- clear indication of where the site contracts outsourced manufacturing steps.

The scope description shall enable a recipient of the report or certificate to clearly identify whether the products supplied have been included in the audit.

The wording of the scope will be verified by the auditor during the site audit.

1.6.2 Exclusions from scope

The fulfilment of the certification criteria relies on clear commitment from the site management to adopt the best-practice principles outlined within the Standard and to the development of a product safety and quality management culture within the business. It follows therefore that the exclusion of products from the scope of certification shall only be permitted by exception.

The exclusion of products produced at a site will only be acceptable where:

- the excluded products can be clearly differentiated from products within scope **and**
- the products are produced in a physically segregated area of the factory.

Where exclusions are requested, these shall be agreed with the certification body in advance of the audit and verified by the auditor during the site audit. Exclusions shall be clearly stated on the audit report and certificate and the justification recorded on the audit report.

The certification of products shall include an audit of the entire operation from raw materials reception to end-product dispatch. It is not possible to exclude either parts of the operations undertaken at the site, or parts of the Standard. Where exclusions are accepted, the auditor shall assess any hazards presented by excluded areas or products and will therefore need to audit those manufacturing operations, products and manufacturing areas (Part II clause 5.4.11).

Non-conformities may be raised relating to the excluded area where this poses a risk to the products within the audit scope.

The BRCGS packaging materials logo can only be used by sites that have no exclusions, other than those that choose to exclude traded products (Part II section 7).

Traded products can be excluded from the audit scope and in that situation the requirements of section 7 will not be applicable. Where excluded, this will be recorded as an exclusion from scope on the audit report and on the certificate. The BRCGS packaging materials logo cannot be used for promoting traded products, even when they form part of the certificated scope.

1.6.3 Defining the limits of a site

Audit reports and certificates, and therefore audit scopes, are expected to be site-specific. However, in some circumstances, a company may own additional facilities or storage at more than one location, all operated under common management as a single operation, and these may be included under a single certification. This will be considered exceptional, but allowable, where all the following conditions are met:

- All sites are under the same organisation's ownership.
- All sites operate within the same documented product safety and quality management systems.
- The sites manufacture product which is part of the same manufacturing process (i.e. sequential steps in the manufacture are completed at different sites).
- The sites solely supply the other sites, with no additional customers.
- The sites are no more than 30 miles/50 km apart.

All sites must be visited as part of the same audit schedule (i.e. within the same timeframe).

It shall be clearly stated on the report and certificate that the audit has consisted of visits to more than one site address (e.g. the die cutting of paperboard sheets at Sector 2 Industrial Zone, Packville, and the window patching with cellulose film, folding and gluing to form sweet packing cartons at Sector 23 Industrial Zone, Packville).

1.6.4 Auditing activities where the head office is located separately

When undertaking audits of sites which are part of a larger manufacturing group, it is not uncommon for some of the requirements within the scope of the Standard to be undertaken by a central function or head office.

The detailed requirements for acceptance and management of such circumstances within the audit protocol are defined in Appendix 3.

1.6.5 Storage facilities – off-site

While storage facilities on the same site as the manufacturing facility shall always be included within the audit of the site, it is not uncommon for sites to also own additional off-site storage facilities. Where additional storage facilities are owned/leased and managed by the company in the vicinity of the manufacturing facility (i.e. within a radius of 30 miles/50 km), these shall be identified on the audit report and either audited as part of the site audit or specifically excluded.

1.6.6 Additional modules

In addition to the core standard, BRCGS has developed a range of additional modules which may be added to the routine audit. These modules are voluntary and designed to enable sites to demonstrate compliance with specific sets of requirements to reduce multiple audits or to meet specific geographic or customer requirements.

A list of the modules, the applicable requirements and any specific protocol for a module is available on the BRCGS website, BRCGS Participate and the BRCGS Store.

The modules can be added to any of the full certification audit options (i.e. announced, blended or unannounced).

The general protocol for the modules is set out in section 5.

1.7 Auditor selection

It is the responsibility of the site to ensure that adequate and accurate information is given to the certification body, detailing the products it manufactures and the manufacturing technologies it uses, to enable the certification body to select an appropriate auditor (or audit team) with the required skills to undertake the audit. Auditors must be skilled to audit in the relevant manufacturing categories as listed in Appendix 2.

The certification body, auditors and the site shall be aware of the need to avoid a conflict of interest when arranging for auditors to visit the site. The site may decline the services of a particular auditor offered by the certification body.

The same auditor is not permitted to undertake audits on more than five consecutive occasions at the same site.

Where the audit is not being carried out by the auditor(s) in the native language of the site, an appropriate translator shall be provided who has knowledge of the technical terms used during the audit.

2 Announced audit protocol (with mandatory unannounced audit every 3 years)

This is an announced audit programme with one mandatory unannounced audit every 3 years.

All sites shall have at least one unannounced audit every 3 years. For sites with annual (12-month) audits, this will result in at least every third audit being unannounced. Sites that receive a grade C or D at any of their audits will still be expected to undergo an unannounced audit every 3 years, but there will be a larger number of announced audits in the interim.

2.1 Audit planning

2.1.1 Preparation by the company

For announced audits, the site shall agree a mutually convenient date, with due consideration given to the amount of work required to meet the requirements of the Standard.

There is a requirement on the site to be prepared for the audit, to have appropriate documentation for the auditor to assess and to have appropriate personnel available at all times during the on-site audit.

The site shall ensure that the manufacturing operations at the time of the audit covers products for the intended scope of the certification. Where possible, the widest range of products shall be in manufacture for the auditor to assess. Where the product range is large or diverse, the auditor has the discretion to continue the audit until sufficiently satisfied that the intended scope of the certification has been assessed. This may result in additional on-site time. Where a significant manufacturing operation is undertaken during a different period of the year from the audit, a separate audit will be required to assess the manufacturing method.

For the mandatory unannounced audit, the certification body shall notify the site of the year when the unannounced audit will take place. The actual date of the unannounced audit will not be communicated to the site. This discussion shall occur within 3 months of the previous audit to ensure that the site is aware of the year in which the unannounced audit will take place.

2.1.2 Information to be provided to the certification body for audit preparation

The site shall supply the certification body with background information prior to the audit to ensure the auditor (or audit team) is fully prepared and to provide the best opportunity for the audit to be completed efficiently. The information will be requested by the certification body and may include but is not limited to:

- background and structure of the company
- a summary of the site's hazard analysis and risk assessment and any critical control measures
- process flow diagram
- simple site plan
- management organisational chart
- list of products or product groups included within the audit scope
- description of the site and building fabrication
- typical personnel shift patterns
- manufacturing schedules, to allow audits to cover relevant manufacturing operations (e.g. night-time manufacture or where some manufacturing operations are not carried out every day or are only carried out at certain times of the day)
- outline of any outsourced processes
- recalls that have occurred since the last BRCGS audit
- recent significant quality issues, withdrawals or customer complaints, outline of operational controls, such as internal audits, testing and traceability
- significant changes to the management structure, ownership, site or manufacturing operations since the last BRCGS audit
- audit history.

Where the site is contracted with a new certification body, the site shall make the previous audit report with GFSI certification history and certificate available to the certification body, even if this was more than a year ago.

Submitting accurate and detailed information prior to the audit, and in the format requested by the certification body, may have an effect on the calculated duration of the on-site audit, therefore sites are encouraged to fulfil such requests in a timely manner.

The time needed for the auditor and certification body to assess all the submitted documentation is additional to the duration of the audit.

Additional information will be required for the unannounced audit (see section 4.1.3).

2.1.3 Scheduling the mandatory unannounced audit

The certification body is responsible for managing the audit process and ensuring that within the 3-year period, all certificated sites receive at least one unannounced audit. The certification body shall notify the site of the year when the unannounced audit will take place, without communicating the actual date of the unannounced audit. This discussion shall occur within 3 months of the previous audit to ensure that the site is aware of the year in which the unannounced audit will take place.

The unannounced audit will replace the normal scheduled (announced) audit. It can occur at any stage within the last 4 months of the audit cycle, including the last 28 calendar days before the date that the announced audit is due (i.e. the unannounced audit must occur within the 4 months leading up to the audit due date). The audit must take place during normal site operation, unless other arrangements have been agreed with the site.

The site shall not be notified of the proposed audit date in advance.

If the site chooses to change certification body or GFSI-benchmarked scheme, this does not change the requirement for the site to receive an unannounced audit. Therefore, the site must ensure that the new certification body is aware that the site is already certificated and provide the date of its last (un)announced audit. The certification body will also require evidence of the site's audit history (e.g. a copy of the most recent audit report) so that the 3-year cycle can be maintained.

Sharing the last audit report is a mandatory requirement of the BRCGS audit protocol (see section 2.1.2). Where a site fails to share its last report in a timely manner, the new certification body will have access to the last audit report through the BRCGS Directory. If a site fails to have an unannounced audit within the 3-year period, its final announced audit may be refused by BRCGS and the site will become uncertificated until an unannounced audit has been completed.

2.1.4 Nominating non-audit days for the mandatory unannounced audit

Applicable only to the mandatory unannounced audit.

Compliance with the Standard is expected to be maintained at all times, so the site should always be 'audit ready'. However, there may be dates when an audit genuinely cannot take place, such as when there is a planned customer visit. Therefore, a site may nominate up to 10 days when it is not available for an audit.

Sites on a 6-month audit schedule (e.g. sites certificated to the Standard with grade C or D) may nominate up to 5 days.

Days when the site is not operating (e.g. public holidays and site shutdowns) are not included with the nominated 10 days (or 5 days). The certification body must be notified of any such non-operational days, including the dates and reasons, at least 4 weeks in advance. The certification body may challenge the reason where this does not appear appropriate, and at its discretion accept these nominated dates. Certification bodies are expected to operate discretion in the case of emergencies.

It is a condition of the unannounced audit that the auditor shall be granted access to the site for the audit on arrival (see section 2.7.4).

2.1.5 Duration of the audit

Before the audit takes place, the certification body shall indicate the approximate duration of the audit. The typical duration of an audit is 1.5 - 3 days (typically 8-9 hours/day, but never in excess of 10 hours/day) at the site. Audits are usually on consecutive days, although there may be circumstances when this is not the case. A calculator has been developed to assess the expected time required to undertake an audit of any site to ensure consistency, and this shall be used as the basis for calculating the total audit duration. The calculator is available on the BRCGS website and Participate.

The calculation for the audit duration is based on:

- the number of personnel – as full-time equivalent manufacturing and warehousing personnel per main shift, including seasonal workers

- the size of the manufacturing facility, including any external covered or uncovered storage areas in square metres
- the number of hazard analysis and risk assessment (HARA) studies included within scope – a HARA study corresponds to a family of products with similar hazards and similar manufacturing technologies.

It is recognised that other factors may also influence the calculation but are considered less significant and therefore shall not influence the audit duration by more than 30% of the total calculated audit time. These factors include:

- whether it is an initial certification audit
- shortfalls in the information provided prior to the audit, as specified in section 2.1.2
- the complexity of the manufacturing operation the number of product manufacturing lines
- the age of the site and the impact on material flow
- the labour intensity of the manufacturing operations
- communication difficulties (e.g., language)
- the number of non-conformities recorded in the previous audit (requiring additional time to review the relevant systems and confirm implementation of effective preventive action)
- difficulties experienced during the audit requiring further investigation.
- the quality of site preparation (e.g. documentation, hazard analysis and risk assessment, product safety and quality management systems).

If additional storage facilities, locations or head office assessments are included within the audit process, additional time shall be allocated for this over and above that indicated by the audit calculator.

Where the audit against the Standard includes modules or is intended to be combined with other audit standards, the total audit time will need to be appropriately extended. Details of combined audits shall be specified on the audit report.

The calculation for audit duration shall determine the expected amount of time needed to undertake the audit at the site. Additional time will be required for the review of any documentary evidence provided and completion of the final audit report.

Deviation from the calculated audit timeframe shall be justified and specified on the audit report.

2.2 The on-site audit

The on-site audit consists of the following stages:

- **Opening meeting** To confirm the scope and process of the audit.
- **Manufacturing and storage facility inspection** To review the practical implementation of the systems, including observing start up and product changeover procedures and interviews of personnel.
- **Document review** A review of the documented HARA and product safety and quality management systems.
- **Discussions with site personnel and managers** For example, to confirm on-site procedures, the implementation of product safety and quality culture plans, process monitoring including critical control measures.
- **Vertical audit traceability challenge** Including a review of all relevant records of manufacturing (e.g. raw material intake, manufacturing records, finished product checks and specifications).
- **Review of the manufacturing facility inspection** To verify and conduct further documentation checks.
- **Final review of findings by the auditor(s)** Preparation for the closing meeting.
- **Closing meeting** To review audit findings with the site. (Note that non-conformities are subject to subsequent independent verification by the certification body management.)

There is no requirement for the auditor to carry out the audit in the order listed, apart from the opening and closing meetings, but the audit must include all elements.

The site shall fully assist the auditor at all times. It is expected that at the opening and closing meetings those attending on behalf of the site will be senior managers who have the appropriate authority to ensure that corrective action can be progressed if non-conformities are found. The most senior manufacturing or operations

manager on site at the time of the audit or their nominated deputy shall be available at the audit, attend the opening and closing meetings, and be available for a discussion on product safety and quality culture (see Part II, clause 1.1.9).

The audit process gives emphasis to the practical implementation of product safety procedures and general good manufacturing practices. At a typical audit, 30-50% of the total audit duration e.g. in a 1.5-day audit that a minimum of four hours of the audit will be spent auditing manufacturing and site facilities, interviewing personnel, observing operations and reviewing documentation in manufacturing areas with the relevant people.

During the audit, detailed notes shall be made by the auditor regarding the site's conformities and non-conformities against the Standard and these will be used as the basis for the audit report. The auditor shall assess the nature and severity of any non-conformity and shall discuss this with the accompanying site representative at the time.

At the closing meeting, the auditor(s) shall present their findings and reconfirm all the non-conformities that have been identified during the audit; however, they shall not make comment on the likely outcome of the certification process. Information on the process and timescales for the site to provide evidence to the auditor of the corrective action needed to close any non-conformities must be given. A written summary of the non-conformities discussed at the closing meeting will be documented by the auditor either at the closing meeting or within 1 working day after completion of the audit.

The site will be required to confirm who was present as part of audit team at the audit, when they were present and what role they took during the audit. This will include the auditor(s) and any trainee(s), witnesses, technical experts or translators etc. present on site for each day of the audit, along with start and finish times.

The declaration includes a clear statement that the site representative understands their responsibility in confirming the accuracy of information, and the consequences to certification status should the information be inaccurate.

A copy of the declaration will be left with the site.

The process for confirming this will be dependent on the certification body protocols.

At the closing meeting, the auditor will provide the site with information on the BRCGS Directory, BRCGS Participate and BRCGS Academy. The information will cover secure access to audit data to both the site and its nominated customers. This also includes feedback systems that enable the site to communicate with the certification body and BRCGS.

After completion of the certification process BRCGS will email the site contact with a welcome email giving details of any service package benefits and details of the BRCGS Certification Integrity programme.

The decision to award certification and the grade of the certificate will be determined independently by the certification body management, following a technical review of the audit report (including non-conformities) and confirmation of the site's post-audit actions, including:

- closing out of any non-conformities
- completion of root cause analysis
- development of a preventive action plan.

All site actions shall be completed within the appropriate timescale.

The company will be informed of the certification decision following this review.

2.3 Non-conformities and corrective action

The level of non-conformity assigned by an auditor against a requirement of the Standard is an objective judgement with respect to level and risk. It is based on evidence collected and observations made during the audit. This is verified by the certification body management.

2.3.1 Non-conformities

There are three levels of non-conformity:

- **Critical** Where there is a critical failure to comply with a product safety or legal issue.
- **Major** Where there is a substantial failure to meet the requirements of a 'statement of intent' or any clause of the Standard, or a situation is identified which would, on the basis of available objective evidence, raise significant doubt as to the conformity of the product being supplied.
- **Minor** Where a clause has not been fully met but, on the basis of objective evidence, the conformity of the product is not in doubt.

The objective of the audit is to provide a true reflection of the standard of the operation and level of conformity against the Standard. Consideration should therefore be given to awarding a single major non-conformity where minor non-conformities are repeatedly raised against a particular clause of the Standard. Clustering of a significant number of minor non-conformities against a clause and recording this as a single minor non-conformity is not permitted.

The certification body shall justify a high number (more than 20) of minor non-conformities where one or no major non-conformities are given. This shall be detailed on the audit report.

2.3.2 Procedures for handling non-conformities and corrective action

Following identification of any non-conformities during the audit, the site shall undertake corrective action to remedy the immediate issue and undertake an analysis of the underlying cause of the non-conformity (root cause), and develop a preventive action plan to address the root cause and prevent recurrence.

The process for 'closing out' non-conformities depends upon the level of non-conformity and the number of non-conformities identified.

Critical non-conformities or a combination of non-conformities resulting in non-certification

In some circumstances the number or severity of non-conformities raised at the audit prevents the site from being certificated following that audit. This will be the case where:

- a critical non-conformity is raised and/or
- a major non-conformity against the statement of intent of a fundamental clause is raised and/or the number or type of non-conformities exceeds the limits for certification, as shown in Table 1.

The grading of non-conformities will be reviewed by the independent certification process of the certification body as soon as possible after the audit. Where the review confirms that a certificate cannot be awarded, the site will be required to undertake another full audit before assessment for certification.

Due to the nature and number of non-conformities, it is unlikely that these non-conformities can be addressed, and fully effective improvements implemented and established within a 28-calendar-day period, although there may be some exceptions. Therefore, the re-audit shall not take place any earlier than 28 calendar days from the audit date.

Where this occurs at a certificated site, certification must be immediately withdrawn.

It is a requirement of some customers that they shall be informed when their suppliers have a critical non-conformity identified or when they fail to gain certification. In such circumstances the company shall immediately inform its customers and make them fully aware of the circumstances. Information on the corrective actions to be taken in order to address the non-conformities will also be provided to customers where required.

Major and minor non-conformities

No certificate shall be issued until major and minor non-conformities have been demonstrated as having been corrected, either permanently or via a temporary solution that is acceptable to the certification body.

For each non-conformity raised, the site shall, in addition to undertaking the necessary immediate corrective action, undertake a review of the underlying cause (root cause) of the non-conformity. The root cause shall be identified and a preventive action plan to correct it, including timescale, shall be provided to the certification body. A summary of the root cause and proposed preventive action shall be included in the audit report.

Close-out of non-conformities can be achieved in any of the following ways:

- objective evidence being submitted to the certification body, such as updated procedures, records, photographs or invoices for work undertaken
- remote audit techniques being used to assess corrective actions
- the certification body undertaking a further on-site visit.

An example of evidence submitted for the correction of a non-conformity is given in Appendix 4.

Where the audit would result in a grade of C or C+ with two major non-conformities, or a D or D+ grade being awarded, the closure of non-conformities shall be by means of a further site visit or remote assessment (see section 2.4.1) to review the action taken. This visit shall be within 28 calendar days of the audit if a certificate is to be issued.

If satisfactory evidence of corrective action, the root cause analysis and a preventive action plan are not provided within the 28-calendar-day period allowed for submission following the audit, certification will not be granted. The site will then require a further full audit in order to be considered for certification.

For initial audits only, up to 90 calendar days are allowed to provide objective evidence of correction of any non-conformities identified at the audit. The site will, however, remain uncertificated and will only be certificated following verification of the corrective action being implemented.

Non-conformities from the previous certification audit shall also be checked during the next site audit to verify effective close-out.

For each non-conformity at the last audit, the auditor will therefore expect to see the following:

- **Corrective actions** The site is required to implement corrective actions and report them to the certification body within 28 calendar days of the audit. The auditor shall therefore expect to see the corrective actions from the previous audit in operation (e.g. that the updated procedure submitted to the certification body as evidence of corrective action following the last audit is in use).
- **Root cause analysis** After being completed by the site following the last audit, the root cause analysis will have been submitted to the certification body, and full details should be available if the auditor requires them.
- **Preventive action** At the time of the previous certification decision, the site will have submitted a preventive action plan to the certification body but might not have completed the actual preventive action. The auditor will therefore expect to see evidence that the site has been effective in preventing recurrence of the non-conformity.

Where the corrective action or preventive action has been ineffective, a non-conformity shall be raised against Part II clause 1.1.10.

The certification body shall review objective evidence of corrective action completed prior to awarding a certificate.

2.4 Grading of the audit

The purpose of the certification grading system is to indicate to the user of the report the commitment of the site to continual compliance and will dictate the future audit frequency. The grade is dependent on the number and severity of the non-conformities identified at the time of the audit. Non-conformities are verified by a technical review process by the certification body management. If the review results in a change in the number and/or severity of non-conformities, the site shall be notified.

Table 1 Summary of grading criteria, action required and audit frequency

Grade		Critical	Major	Minor	Corrective action	Audit frequency
Announced	Unannounced					
AA	AA+			5 or fewer	Objective evidence within 28 calendar days (90 days for initial audits)	12 months
A	A+			6–10		
B	B+			11–16		
B	B+		1	10 or fewer	Objective evidence within 28 calendar days (90 days for initial audits)	6 months
C	C+			17–24		
C	C+		1	11–16		
C	C+		2	10 or fewer	Revisit required within 28 calendar days (90 days for initial audits)	6 months
D	D+			25–30		
D	D+		1	17–24		
D	D+		2	11–16	Certificate not granted. Re-audit required	
Not certificated		1 or more				
				31 or more		
			1	25 or more		
			2	17 or more		
			3 or more			

Note that shaded cells indicate zero non-conformities.

2.4.1 Revisits

Where a revisit is required to review the action taken in response to the non-conformities identified at the audit (i.e. some sites with grade C and all sites with grade D), this will be scheduled to be completed within the timescale for certification (i.e. 28 calendar days for certificated sites, and 90 days calendar days for initial audits).

The certification body shall assess whether a physical on site revisit is required or whether a remote audit will provide an effective assessment of the actions taken to close out the non-conformities. Where a remote audit is considered effective, the certification body can offer this option to the site.

The primary focus of the revisit (whether physical or remote) will be on reviewing the effectiveness of the corrective actions taken. However, if any new non-conformities are identified then these must also be satisfactorily resolved before a certificate can be issued, although they will not affect the grading. The action taken to correct the non-conformity shall be recorded in the final audit report.

2.4.2 Documentary evidence and remote auditing

Where a revisit is not required, suitable evidence of corrective action shall be provided to the certification body within 28 calendar days of the audit (or for initial audits, 90 days for any non-conformities). The evidence shall clearly demonstrate that adequate corrective actions have been taken and implemented. There are two options for submitting this evidence:

- **A remote audit of the corrective action** To confirm that effective corrective action has been implemented (e.g. a review of documents, discussions with site personnel, using webcams).
- **Provision of suitable documentary evidence** For example, updated procedures, records, photographs, and invoices for work completed.

Where appropriate, if satisfactory corrective action cannot be effectively demonstrated to the satisfaction of the certification body, a revisit may be required before a certificate can be issued.

2.5 Audit reporting

Following each audit, a full written report shall be prepared in the agreed format. The report shall be produced in English or in another language, dependent upon user needs. Where the report is produced in a language other than English, the audit summary sections shall always be reported in English in addition to the other language.

The audit report shall provide the company and customers or prospective customers with a profile of the company and an accurate summary of the performance of the site against the requirements of the Standard.

The audit report must assist the reader to be informed of:

- the product safety controls in place and improvements since the last audit
- 'best practice' systems, procedures, description of equipment and fabrication of the facility
- non-conformities, the corrective action taken and plans to correct the root cause (preventive actions).

The report shall accurately reflect the findings of the auditor during the audit. Reports shall be prepared and issued so that the certification decision is confirmed within 42 calendar days of the last day of the audit. Subsequently, the audit report shall be uploaded to and available from the BRCGS Directory within 49 days of the final day of the audit.

The BRCGS Directory is the source of accurate, authenticated and up-to-date certification status information. It enables a one-click audit report sharing option. Audit reports shall remain the property of the company commissioning the audit and shall not be released, whole or in part, to a third party unless the company has given prior consent or the release is otherwise required by law.

The audit report shall be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory irrespective of whether a certificate is issued. The owner of the audit report may allocate access to the audit report to customers or other parties in the BRCGS Directory.

The audit report and associated documentation including auditor's notes shall be stored safely and securely for a period of 5 years by the certification body, unless otherwise required by legislation.

2.6 Certification

After a review of the audit report and documentary evidence provided in relation to the non-conformities identified, a certification decision shall be made by the designated independent certification manager. Where a certificate is granted, this shall be issued by the certification body within 42 calendar days of the last day of the audit. The certificate shall conform to the format shown in Appendix 5. Logos used on certificates (e.g. the BRCGS and accreditation body logos) shall comply with their respective usage rules.

While the certificate is issued to the site, it remains the property of the certification body, and that body controls its ownership, use and display.

2.7 Ongoing audit frequency and re-certification

2.7.1 Scheduling re-audit dates

The re-audit due date shall be calculated from the date of the first day of the initial audit (irrespective of whether further site visits were made to verify corrective actions arising from the initial audit) and not from the certificate issue date.

Subsequent audits of certificated sites shall be carried out either 6 or 12 months after the previous audit due date, depending on the number and type of non-conformities identified at that audit (see Table 1). If it is an announced audit, it shall be scheduled to occur within a 28-calendar-day time period up to the next audit due date. This allows sufficient time for corrective action to take place in the event of any non-conformities being raised, without jeopardising continued certification.

Table 2 provides worked examples in accordance with the announced and mandatory unannounced re-certification audits.

It is the responsibility of the site to maintain certification, and the BRCGS Directory sends automatic reminders. Where an audit is delayed beyond the due date, except in justifiable circumstances (see section 2.7.3), this shall result in a major non-conformity being awarded at the next audit. Justifiable circumstances shall be documented in the audit report.

For details on scheduling the mandatory unannounced audit, see section 2.1.3. The unannounced audit shall take place during normal site operations unless other arrangements have been agreed in advance with the site. However, the site must not be notified of the proposed audit date in advance.

The unannounced audit certificate will supersede the existing certificate. It will be issued within 42 days of the last day of the audit, assuming that certification is achieved (based on the number and severity of non-conformities and completion of corrective actions). The certificate will have an expiry date based on the expiry date of the previous certificate, plus 6 or 12 months (depending on the grade achieved).

The site shall be responsible for maintaining valid certification, while the certification body shall assume responsibility for maintaining the ongoing audit programme.

Where a site cannot be certificated because of the number or level of non-conformities identified during the audit, the site will require a further full audit before certification can be considered. Once the site has addressed the non-conformities that were raised, the new audit can be arranged. The re-audit shall not take place any sooner than 28 calendar days from the audit date. If the audit was a mandatory unannounced audit, the re-audit may be announced. The re-audit shall be completed by the same certification body unless a concession is granted by BRCGS for a change of certification body during this period.

It should be noted that the site must have at least one unannounced audit every 3 years, and this frequency is not expected to change as a result of a failed audit.

Table 2 Worked examples of an initial audit followed by announced and unannounced re-certification audits

Announced/unannounced	Audit date	Next audit due date
Initial audit at site (announced)	1–2 June 2025	1 June 2026
Re-audit (announced)	20–21 May 2026 (audit within 28 calendar days prior to the audit due date)	1 June 2027
Re-audit (1 in 3 unannounced) (Audit window 01/02 - 01/06)	1–2 March 2027 (audit within 4 months prior to the audit due date)	1 June 2028
Re-audit (announced)	20–21 May 2028 (audit within 28 calendar days prior to the audit due date)	1 June 2029
Re-audit (announced)	20–21 May 2029 (audit within 28 calendar days prior to the audit due date)	1 June 2030
Re-audit (1 in 3 unannounced) (Audit window 01/02 - 01/06)	10–11 March 2030 (audit within 4 months prior to the audit due date)	1 June 2031

If the site chooses to change certification body or GFSI-benchmarked scheme, this does not change the requirement for the site to receive an unannounced audit. Therefore, the site must ensure that the new certification body is aware that the site is already certificated and provide the date of its last unannounced audit. The certification body will also require evidence of the site's audit history (e.g. a copy of the most recent audit report) so that the 3-year cycle can be maintained.

2.7.2 Certificate expiry – justifiable circumstances

There will be some circumstances where the certificate cannot be renewed on the 6-month or 12-month basis due to the inability of the certification body to conduct an audit. These justifiable circumstances, which would not result in the assigning of a major non-conformity (Part II, clause 1.1.10), are applicable when the site is:

- situated in a specific country or an area within a specific country where there is government advice not to visit and there is no suitable local auditor
- within a statutory exclusion zone that could compromise product/personal safety
- in an area that has suffered a natural or unnatural disaster, rendering the site unable to produce or the auditor unable to visit
- affected by conditions that do not allow access to the site or restrict travel (e.g. heavy snow).

Moving the audit date to a more 'acceptable' later date for reasons of combining audits, lack of personnel or undertaking building work are not acceptable reasons for missing the due date.

It is not a justifiable reason to delay audits where sites are not in full manufacture; however, audits must be undertaken while products are being manufactured.

If the renewal of the certificate is prevented due to these exceptional circumstances, the customer may still decide to take products from that site for an agreed time, as customers may still demonstrate legal compliance by other means, such as risk assessment and complaints records, to show that the site is still competent to continue manufacture until another audit can be arranged.

2.7.3 Audits undertaken prior to due dates

The due date of a renewal audit occurs within a 28-calendar-day window prior to the 6-month or 12-month anniversary of the initial audit.

In some circumstances it is possible to undertake the audit earlier than the due date; for example, to reset the audit dates to allow combined audits with another scheme, or to include a product that is produced during a different period. Where an audit date is brought forward, the following rules shall apply:

- The audit report will detail the reasons why an audit has been brought forward.
- The next audit due date will be 'reset' to the 12 months (or 6 months, depending on grade) from this 'new' audit date.
- The certificate (should it be issued) shall have an expiry date of 12 months (or 6 months, depending on grade) plus 42 calendar days from the last day of the new audit date.

2.7.4 Refusal of a company to undertake the unannounced audit

Sites are obliged to accommodate the auditor and allow the audit to commence upon the auditor's arrival at the site. Sites can nominate days when the audit cannot take place; however, they must do so in advance (see section 2.1.4).

Therefore, if the auditor arrives for the audit and is denied access, the site's certification will be suspended. The site shall remain suspended until a new unannounced audit can be completed. Since the new audit will be unannounced, the site shall not be told the new audit date, which may occur at any time within the 4 months following the refused audit. The audit shall be completed by the same certification body unless a concession is granted by BRCGS for a change of certification body during this period.

Liability for the auditor's time shall be covered by the certification body's contract with the site. Therefore, if access is denied, the site may also be liable for the auditor's costs.

2.7.5 Non-availability of key personnel at the opening and closing meetings or during the audit

The Standard requires the most senior manufacturing or operation manager (i.e. the person who is responsible for the 'hands on' running of the site) to be present at the opening and closing meetings (Part II, clause 1.1.9) and for relevant personnel to be available during the audit.

Where a key member of personnel (most senior manufacturing or operations manager) is absent on the day of the audit due to other commitments, a nominated deputy must be available (Part II, clause 1.1.9).

Therefore, the absence of a key member of personnel shall not be accepted as a reason to prevent an audit going ahead.

2.7.6 No manufacturing activity on the day of the unannounced audit

As part of the audit planning, the site must notify the certification body of any days or times when operations are not undertaken. If the unannounced audit takes place on a date when the site is supposed to be operational, but on arrival the auditor finds that there is either no manufacturing or the only products being handled are outside the scope of the audit, then the audit cannot go ahead. A further unannounced audit will need to be arranged.

Liability for the auditor's time shall be covered within the certification body's contract with the site (see section 2.7.4).

2.7.7 Changing the certification body for an early re-audit

In addition to the situations described in section 2.7.3, an early re-audit may occasionally be requested by a site – usually shortly after the previous audit or following a failure to be certificated. This often occurs because the site wants to improve its audit grade. In this situation, the early re-audit must be completed by the certification body that issued the current certificate.

However, in exceptional circumstances and if agreed in advance by BRCGS, a site may be permitted to change the certification body for this early re-audit. Justification for changing the certification body in this situation shall be provided in writing to the new certification body, who in turn shall submit it to BRCGS for consideration through the formal concession process. Where a change in certification body in this instance has not been agreed in advance, a re-audit by the new certification body will be null and void and will not be accepted in the BRCGS Directory.

This requirement applies only when an early re-audit has been requested; it does not change the process for re-audits completed to the normal 6- or 12-month schedule.

3 Blended announced audit protocol – two-part announced audit

This is a two-part audit consisting of a remote audit followed by an on-site audit.

The blended announced audit scheme allows the certification body to consider which requirements of the Standard may be audited using ICT to conduct an off-site remote assessment. This divides the audit requirements into two separate audits, comprising:

- **the off-site remote audit** – predominantly based on a review of documents and records, and may be planned to ensure that the appropriate personnel are available to retrieve and discuss the records
- **the subsequent on-site audit** – mainly focused on the site's operating practices (manufacturing facility inspection) housekeeping, fabrication, manufacturing operations, storage and product handling. This will also include the traceability vertical audit.

The certification body shall have a documented process for undertaking blended audits that ensures compliance with the latest version of IAF document MD4.

Additional information on the processes for blended audits is available in BRCGS080: Blended Audits – Remote Auditing Using ICT (available from the BRCGS website and BRCGS Participate).

Sites opting for the blended announced audit option are also required to have an unannounced audit at least every 3 years (see section 2).

3.1 Audit planning

3.1.1 Selection of the blended audit option

This option is available for re-certification audits only, not for the first BRCGS audit at a site or for audits at sites not holding a current BRCGS certificate.

The blended audit can be used irrespective of the site's previous grade (i.e. all grades from AA to D are eligible); however, the grade will be taken into account during the pre-audit risk assessment (see section 3.1.5).

The certification body can decide whether to offer and/or accept the blended audit option following the risk assessment.

Before planning the remote audit element of the audit, the certification body shall consider the willingness of the site to consent to the use of remote auditing by ICT. The availability of ICT is also a factor in the effective completion of this audit. It is important that both parties mutually agree to this option.

3.1.2 Preparation by the site

The preparation by the site is mainly the same as for the announced audit scheme (see section 2.1.1).

However, additional consideration is needed for the remote part of the audit. Examples include ensuring the availability of appropriate IT systems, agreement on any confidentiality, security and data protection requirements (see section 3.1.6), and the need to facilitate the audit in a quiet environment to avoid background noises and interference (e.g. considering the availability of office space and the use of noise-cancelling technology such as 'mufflers on microphones or headsets).

3.1.3 Information to be provided to the certification body for audit preparation

The information to be provided to the certification body is the same as for the announced audit scheme (see section 2.1.2.).

3.1.4 Scheduling the mandatory unannounced audit

Sites opting for the blended announced audit option are required to have an unannounced audit at least every 3 years. Details of the protocol for the mandatory unannounced audit are given in section 2.

3.1.5 Pre-audit risk assessment

The certification body shall undertake a full risk assessment to determine whether audit objectives can be achieved remotely. The risk assessment shall include the ability of the company to receive a remote audit, including the:

- historical audit performance of the site, including the risks from complaints and recalls
- availability of documentation and records in electronic form, and the site's willingness to share these remotely (including any limitations)
- capability of the certification body to conduct the remote audit (e.g. trained auditors, access to an IT system that both the certification body and the company will be able to use)
- capability of the site personnel to utilise technologies used in remote audit techniques, including on-site video.

Any limitations on document-sharing and record-sharing shall be understood before the audit.

The pre-audit risk assessment is not included in the calculation of the audit duration.

3.1.6 Confidentiality, security and data protection

The certification body shall consider local data protection and privacy laws (as stated in IAF MD4, clause 4.1). It is important that, if ICT (such as video) is utilised, the relevant consents have been sought from the individuals involved to ensure compliance with local privacy regulations.

To prepare for the use of ICT, all requirements (certification, legal and customer) related to confidentiality, security and data protection shall be identified, and actions taken to ensure their effective implementation. Evidence of agreements related to confidentiality, security and data protection (CSDP) must be available. The CSDP criteria shall be acknowledged by all participants, and measures to ensure confidentiality and security shall be confirmed during the opening meeting.

Where documented information is analysed, it shall be shared in a secure and agreed system, such as a cloud-based, virtual private network or other file-sharing system utilising CSDP guidelines. Once the audit is complete, the auditor shall delete from their system, or remove access to, any documented information and records that are not required to be retained as objective evidence.

Auditors must not take screenshots or record videos of auditees as audit evidence. Any screenshots of documents, records or other kinds of evidence must be authorised in advance by the site being audited. In the case of non-fulfilment of these measures or non-agreement of information security and data protection measures, the certification body shall not use the blended audit option.

3.1.7 Selection of clauses for remote and on-site audits

As a minimum, the on-site audit shall include inspection/physical verification of good manufacturing practices and implementation of the product safety and quality management system, including hazard analysis and risk assessment and related activities (e.g. the effective operation of prerequisite programmes, verification of the process flow diagram, critical control measure monitoring and verification) and the traceability challenge.

In addition, the requirements in the Standard are colour-coded to indicate which requirements may be audited remotely and which requirements must be audited during the on-site audit (see below).

Key for colour-coding of requirements

Audit of site facilities and good manufacturing practice	On site	
Audit of records, systems and documentation	Remote permitted	
Requirements assessed in both		

Clauses that are dual coloured must be audited during both parts of the audit.

It is important to note that although the colour-coding indicates the clauses that may be audited remotely, the certification body's pre-audit risk assessment (see section 3.1.5) may identify clauses that require on-site assessment, even though they relate to documents or records.

3.1.8 Duration of the blended audit

The total audit duration is the same regardless of whether the audit is completed fully on site (announced or unannounced) or as a blended audit using both remote and on-site auditing (see section 2.1.5).

The duration does not include time spent on audit planning, the risk assessment or report writing.

The remote part of the audit shall not exceed 50% of the total audit duration. It should be noted that 50% represents the maximum proportion of the audit that may be completed remotely. The actual duration of the remote audit will be dependent on the certification body assessment (i.e. the risk assessment in section 3.1.5). Therefore, it may be significantly less than the maximum permitted in some circumstances; for example, if:

- additional risks are identified
- specific documents are not available for the remote audit
- the nature or volume of complaints or recalls is a concern
- the historical performance of the site has been a concern
- the certification body identifies clauses that need to be audited on site, even when they relate to documents or records.

If additional storage facilities, locations or head office assessments are included within the audit process (see sections 1.6.3-1.6.5 and Appendix 3) then additional time shall be allocated for this.

The time allocated for the on-site audit may also be adjusted based on the findings from the remote audit; for instance, more time may be required if a large number of non-conformities require an on-site review of corrective actions.

For the head office or central function, the remote audit can be completed using the colour-coding of the relevant clauses of the Standard. In some situations, this may mean that the auditor does not need to visit the head office as all the clauses are appropriate for remote audits. If the head office contains a mixture of clauses (i.e. some that require on-site audit and others that may be audited remotely), the site may elect to have either:

- a full on-site head office audit or
- a remote head office audit with the remaining on-site elements being assessed at each of the site audits.

The expected audit duration shall be notified to the site by the certification body in advance of the audit. Deviation from the expected audit duration must be justified and specified in the audit report.

3.1.9 Auditor selection

The auditor conducting the blended audit shall be fully competent and qualified in the appropriate manufacturing categories (i.e. the same auditor category requirements apply to both the remote and on-site audits). See section 1.7.

Where audit teams are used, the audit report shall indicate whether each auditor has completed remote and/or on-site activities.

If a technical expert is used during the audit, the documents shared by the site shall also be made accessible to the expert.

Where different auditors are used for the remote and on-site audits, there shall be a clear handover process prior to the on-site audit to ensure that the auditor has all the necessary information to complete the audit in full and that all the requirements of the Standard are fully covered, either remotely or on site.

3.2 The site audit

3.2.1 The off-site remote audit

Scheduling the remote audit

The audit shall be announced, and the site shall agree a mutually convenient date with the certification body.

The remote audit shall be conducted first (i.e. before the on-site audit). However, where the BRCGS audit is combined with the audit for another GFSI-benchmarked standard, the sequence of the two parts of the audit may be reversed (i.e. the on-site audit would be completed first, followed by the remote audit).

The remote audit shall take place within the 56 calendar days before the audit due date. This is to ensure that:

- there is sufficient time to complete the on-site audit before the audit due date (and within 28 calendar days of the remote audit, although it is recommended that the remote and on-site audits are as close to each other as possible)
- the site has sufficient time (28 calendar days) to close out any non-conformities raised (see section 3.3)
- the certification body has sufficient time (42 calendar days) to make a certification decision after the on-site audit and before the site's current certificate expires.

Preparation for the remote audit

Preparation for the audit can be summarised in the following steps:

- The certification body shall prepare a clear audit plan which highlights the documents that will be needed remotely. This plan shall be shared with the site prior to the audit.
- The certification body shall agree with the site the technical requirements for the remote audit – for example, internet access, meeting software that is usable by both site and auditor, and hardware (including webcams/cameras and microphones).
- BRCGS recommends that the certification body tests the compatibility of the ICT platform with the site, especially prior to the first blended audit at the site or when new ICT platforms will be used. If testing reveals issues that cannot be recertified, then the audit shall be completed as a full on-site audit.
- Use of webcams/cameras shall be agreed.
- When assigning work to audit team members, including technical experts, this should take into consideration their ability to utilise the remote technologies.
- The remote audit shall be facilitated in a quiet environment wherever possible to avoid background noise and interference. The use of noise-cancelling technology (e.g. 'mufflers on microphones' or headsets) should be considered.
- When no agreement is reached for the use of ICT for a remote audit, the audit will revert to a full on-site audit. If it is not possible to maintain satisfactory conditions during the scheduled time of the remote audit, the auditor may decide to terminate it. This shall be recorded in the report. The remote audit may continue at a later date agreed between the two parties within the period described above.

In the event of the technology failing during the remote audit, the certification body and the site can reschedule, providing this occurs within the 28-calendar-day window. The site may be liable to pay for the lost audit day where the failure is a site issue, and this should be covered in the contract between the certification body and the site. Ultimately, if the audit cannot be completed remotely then the auditor will need to complete the audit on site. This on-site audit will follow the protocol for the announced audit option (see section 2) and shall be completed prior to the audit due date.

Completing the remote audit

The remote audit consists of the following stages:

- **Opening meeting** To confirm the scope and process of the audit.
- **Document review** The documents will have been confirmed by the certification body; for example, verification of the product safety and quality management system (e.g. hazard analysis and risk assessment, critical control measures monitoring).
- **Interviews/discussions with personnel** For example, to discuss the document, policy or record being audited.
- **Final review of findings** Conducted by the auditor in preparation for the closing meeting.
- **Closing meeting** To review the audit findings with the site and confirm any non-conformities.

Good practice is to include sufficient breaks in the audit plan (for a remote audit these may need to be more frequent), so that site personnel and auditors are not continuously using a computer screen for a prolonged period.

The remote audit may also include a live video if required. Any live video shall not be recorded, but a record shall be kept of its duration and what was covered. This information is to be recorded in the audit report.

The site shall fully assist the auditor at all times. It is expected that the opening and closing meetings will be attended by the site's senior managers or their nominated deputies (see Part II, clause 1.1.9) who have the appropriate authority to ensure that corrective actions can be progressed if any non-conformities are found.

A closing meeting at the end of the remote audit shall conclude the audit findings, confirm any non-conformities and discuss the next steps. Information shall be given on the process of providing evidence for closing out any non-conformities and the timescale within which the company must provide it.

A written summary of the non-conformities discussed will be documented by the auditor either at the closing meeting or within 1 working day after completing the audit. Any non-conformities are subject to subsequent independent verification by the certification body management.

If a critical non-conformity or the number and level of non-conformities would result in failure to achieve a certificate, the existing certificate for the site shall be immediately withdrawn. A new audit shall be arranged, which shall be fully on-site. (This process is identical to the protocol for on-site audits, which is documented in section 2.)

3.2.2 The on-site audit

Planning for the on-site audit

This is the same as for the announced audit option (see section 2.1).

The on-site audit shall be conducted within 28 calendar days of the remote audit and during the audit due window of the current certificate (i.e. during the 28 calendar days prior to the audit due date). It is recommended that the time between the remote and on-site audits is as short as practicable. In exceptional (but justifiable) circumstances, the certification body may ask BRCGS for an extension of up to 90 days.

Completing the on-site audit

To ensure consistency, it is strongly recommended that the on-site audit should be carried out by the same auditor who carried out the remote audit. If this cannot be arranged, a clear handover process shall be in place prior to the on-site audit to ensure that the auditor has all the necessary information to fully complete the audit and that all the requirements of the Standard are covered, either remotely or on site. All auditors shall be qualified in the appropriate product categories (i.e. the same auditor category requirements apply to the remote audit and the on-site audit).

The on-site audit consists of the following stages:

- **Opening meeting** To confirm the scope and process of the audit.
- **Audit of site and storage facilities** To audit practical implementation of systems, including, for example, auditing good manufacturing practices, accuracy of process flow diagram, product changeover and line start-up procedures.
- **Any requirements identified** For on-site audit during the risk assessment and remote audits.
- **Discussions with site personnel and managers** For example, to confirm on-site procedures, the implementation of product safety and quality culture plans, process monitoring including critical control measures.
- **Vertical audit, traceability challenge** Including a review of all relevant records of manufacturing (e.g. raw material intake, manufacturing records, finished product checks and specifications).
- **Verification of the hazard analysis and risk assessment** Review of critical control measures, prerequisites monitoring).
- **Review of manufacturing facility inspection** To verify and conduct any further comparison of documentation with actual practice.
- **Final review of findings by the auditor** Preparation for the closing meeting.
- **Closing meeting** To review the audit findings with the site (note that non-conformities are subject to subsequent independent verification by the certification body management).

The site shall fully assist the auditor at all times. It is expected that at the opening and closing meetings those attending on behalf of the site will be senior managers who have the appropriate authority to ensure that corrective action can be progressed if non-conformities are found.

The most senior manufacturing or operations manager on site at the time of the audit shall be available to attend the opening and closing meetings and be available for a discussion on product safety and quality culture. Where the most senior manufacturing or operations manager is not on site at the time of the audit, the defined deputy must attend (see Part II, clause 1.1.9).

The audit process gives emphasis to the practical implementation of product safety procedures and general good manufacturing practices. At a typical audit, 30-50% of the total audit duration e.g. in a 1.5-day audit that a minimum of 4 hours of the audit will be spent auditing manufacturing and site facilities, interviewing personnel, observing operations and reviewing documentation in manufacturing areas with the relevant people.

At the closing meeting, the auditor shall present their findings and reconfirm all the non-conformities that have been identified during the audit; however, they shall not make comment on the likely outcome of the certification process. Information on the process and timescales for the site to provide evidence to the auditor of the corrective action needed to close any non-conformities must be given. A written summary of the non-conformities discussed at the closing meeting will be documented by the auditor either at the closing meeting or within 1 working day after completion of the audit.

The site will be required to confirm who was present as part of audit team at the audit, when they were present and what role they took during the audit. This will include the auditor(s) and any trainee, witnesses, technical experts or translators etc. present on site for each day of the audit, as well as the start and finish times.

The declaration includes a clear statement that the site representative understands their responsibility in confirming the accuracy of information, and the consequences to certification status should the information be inaccurate.

A copy of the declaration will be left with the site.

The process for confirming this will be dependent on the certification body protocols.

At the closing meeting, the auditor will provide the site with information on the BRCGS Directory, Participate and Academy. The information will cover secure access to audit data to both the site and its nominated customers. This also includes feedback systems that enable the site to communicate with the certification body and BRCGS.

The decision to award certification and the grade of the certificate will be determined independently by the certification body management, following a technical review of the audit report (including non-conformities) and confirmation of the site's post-audit actions, including:

- closing out of any non-conformities
- completion of root cause analysis
- development of a preventive action plan.

All site actions shall be completed within the appropriate timescale.

The company will be informed of the certification decision following this review.

After completion of the certification process BRCGS will email the site contact with a welcome email giving details of any service package benefits and details of the BRCGS Certification Integrity programme.

3.3 Non-conformities and corrective action

Any non-conformities identified during the remote and on-site audits shall follow the existing requirements of the scheme (see section 2.3). Evidence of the action taken to correct any non-conformities shall be submitted to the certification body within 28 calendar days of the on-site audit (i.e. within 28 calendar days of the completion of the blended audit).

For initial audits only, up to 90 calendar days are allowed to provide objective evidence of correction of any non-conformities identified at the audit. The site will, however, remain uncertificated and will only be certificated following verification of the corrective action being implemented.

Verification of the preventive action plan and implementation of the corrective actions may take various forms (including further on-site assessment or the scrutiny of evidence submitted through ICT). Verification must be carried out by the certification body's technically competent personnel, who must use appropriate methods.

If a critical non-conformity or the number and level of other non-conformities identified at the remote audit (i.e. the first part of the audit) or the on-site audit (i.e. the second part of the audit), or as a result of the sum of both parts of the audit, would result in failure to achieve a certificate, the existing certificate for the site shall be immediately withdrawn. Where the critical non-conformity and/or number of non-conformities occurs during the remote (first) part of the audit, the existing certificate shall still be withdrawn immediately (i.e. after the remote audit) and not delayed until the second part of the audit has been completed.

3.4 Grading of the audit

The process for grading is the same as for the announced audit scheme (see section 2.4).

However, the grade awarded is based on the combination of non-conformities identified at the two audits (i.e. the sum of the non-conformities identified at the remote audit and the on-site audit).

Any non-conformities identified during the remote audit that were closed out and corrected before the on-site audit are still counted when calculating the grade.

3.5 Audit reporting

The audit reporting requirements are the same as for the announced audit scheme (see section 2.5). However, the report shall state 'Blended announced audit'.

The audit report shall clearly identify the extent to which any ICT has been used in carrying out the audit and the effectiveness of ICT in achieving the audit objectives. The audit report shall include all the summarised information and findings of the remote audit and the on-site audit so that a single report can be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory.

The report shall also reference the dates and the duration of the two audits, including the records of the people who attended them. The requirements assessed during the remote audit shall be identified by an asterisk placed at the beginning of the information.

The final report will not be produced until the on-site audit has been completed.

3.6 Certification

The certification requirements are the same as for the announced audit scheme (see section 2.6).

The design of and information on the certificate are the same as for all audits against the Standard, except that the certificate shall state 'Blended announced audit'. The dates of both audits (remote and on-site) shall be included on the certificate.

This certificate will supersede any existing certificate. It shall be issued within 42 days of the last day of audit and will have an expiry date based on the expiry date of the previous certificate plus 6 or 12 months, depending on the grade achieved.

3.7 Ongoing audit frequency and re-certification

This is the same as for the announced audit option (see section 2.7).

Sites that have opted into the blended announced audit option are required to complete a mandatory unannounced audit every 3 years (see section 2.1.3).

3.7.1 Scheduling re-audit dates

Subsequent announced audits can remain in the blended announced audit programme, irrespective of the site's previous grade (i.e. sites graded from AA to D can receive a remote audit). However, the certification body will include the previous grade within the pre-audit risk assessment (see section 3.1.5).

4 Unannounced audit protocol

This is a fully on-site unannounced audit.

The protocol of unannounced audits generally follows that of announced audits above; where it differs, this is outlined as follows.

This option involves a single unannounced audit against all the relevant requirements of the Standard.

The date of the audit shall not be notified to the site in advance of the audit. The audit will be unannounced and replace the normal scheduled audit. It can occur at any stage within the last 4 months of the audit cycle, including the 28 calendar days before the audit due date (i.e. at any point from 4 months before the audit due date).

4.1 Audit planning

4.1.1 Selection of the unannounced audit programme

The site shall notify its certification body within 3 months of the last audit date of its intention to join or remain within the unannounced audit programme. This allows the site to select an alternative certification body if required while allowing the audit to be undertaken at a time of the certification body's choosing.

A site may choose to change certifying body. Changes will not be permitted in the last 4-months before the re-audit due date, whether an unannounced audit is scheduled or not, unless agreed in writing with BRCGS through the certification body concession process.

Non-certificated sites may opt into the unannounced audit programme on the understanding that the initial audit may not occur for up to 12 months from the request.

4.1.2 Preparation by the company

The actual audit date will not be provided by the certification body, and it is therefore important that the site has arrangements in place to receive an audit and facilitate the audit process.

Success at an unannounced audit relies upon the ability of the site to share information and knowledge within the site, to have effective deputies to cover in the absence of a particular manager, and a shared responsibility within the management team for product safety and compliance with the Standard.

4.1.3 Information to be provided to the certification body for audit preparation.

In addition to the information specified in section 2.1.2, the certification body will require information to plan for the logistics of the audit process. This may include:

- recommended local hotels
- specific site directions, GPS location, site entrance requirements, car parking
- a list of contacts when first arriving on site
- specific protective clothing arrangements
- any specific security arrangements to follow to gain access to the site
- any health and safety or other company information that needs to be reviewed by the auditor on arrival (e.g. health and safety video) to avoid unnecessary delays before entering manufacturing.

4.1.4 Nominating non-audit days

Compliance with the Standard is expected to be maintained at all times and the site should therefore always be 'audit ready'. However, there may be dates when an audit genuinely cannot take place, such as a planned customer visit. The unannounced audit programme therefore allows sites to nominate up to 10 days when they are genuinely not available for an audit. Sites on a 6-month audit schedule (e.g. sites certificated to the Standard with grades C or D) may nominate a maximum of 5 days.

The dates and the reasons must be provided to the certification body within 3 months of opting into the programme. At the discretion of the certification body, other unavailable dates may be accepted when provided at least 4 weeks in advance of the next unavailable date. The certification body may challenge the reason where this does not appear appropriate and at its discretion accept these nominated dates.

Days when a site is not operating (e.g. weekends, public holidays and planned shutdowns for site holidays or maintenance) are not included within the 10 days (or 5 days). Any such non-manufacturing days shall be notified to the certification body when opting into the unannounced scheme.

Certification bodies are expected to operate discretion in the case of emergencies.

It is a condition of electing to join the unannounced audit programme that the auditor shall be granted access to the site for the audit on arrival. If access is denied, the site will be liable for the auditor's costs and will revert to the announced audit scheme. At the discretion of the certification body, the existing certificate may also be suspended or withdrawn.

4.1.5 Audit duration

The typical duration of an audit does not differ from that of an announced audit, subject to the variances described in section 2.1.5.

4.2 The on-site audit

Sites opting for the unannounced audit programme shall be obliged to accommodate the auditor and allow the audit to start immediately on arrival at the site. The audit process will follow the same procedures as outlined for an announced audit. There will be a short opening meeting, after which the site manufacturing facility inspection will be expected to commence within 30 minutes of the auditor arriving on site.

The on-site audit will follow the same stages as an announced audit (see section 2.2).

4.3 Non-conformities and corrective action

Non-conformities and corrective actions are the same as for the announced audit (see section 2.3).

4.4 Grading of the audit

The process for grading is the same as for the announced audit (see section 2.4). The grade awarded following certification shall be based on the number and severity of the non-conformities, as outlined in Table 1. Note that the grade will have the addition of a plus symbol after the grade (i.e. AA+, A+, B+, C+ or D+) to indicate that the audit was unannounced.

4.5 Audit reporting

The audit reporting requirements are the same as for the announced audit; however, the report shall state 'unannounced option' (see section 2.5).

4.6 Certification

The certification requirements are the same as for the announced audit (see section 2.6). However, the certificate shall state 'unannounced option'.

This certificate will supersede the existing certificate. The certificate shall have an expiry date based on that of the previous certificate plus 6 or 12 months, depending on the grade, provided that the site remains within the unannounced audit programme.

If the site decides to return to the announced audit programme, the certificate expiry date will be 6 or 12 months from the date of the unannounced audit.

This ensures that where the audit occurs before the expiry of the current certificate and the site remains within the unannounced programme, it is not disadvantaged by a shorter certificate life and increased frequency of audits.

4.7 Ongoing audit frequency and re-certification

4.7.1 Scheduling re-audit dates

The site can choose whether to:

- remain within the unannounced programmes (fully on site)
- revert to the announced audit programme (fully on site or blended).

If the site wishes to remain in an unannounced programme, the next audit will be unannounced. The audit may occur at any stage within the last 4 months of the audit cycle, including the 28 calendar days before the audit due date. This allows sufficient time for corrective action to take place in the event of any non-conformities being raised without jeopardising continued certification.

It is the certification body's responsibility to initiate the contractual procedures, within 6 months from the last audit and request all information from the site/company to enable scheduling of the unannounced audit within the audit window.

It is the site's responsibility to ensure all requirements are met to ensure that the unannounced audit can be undertaken in accordance with the audit protocol. This includes agreeing contractual terms with the certification body in advance of the start of the 4-month audit window, and keeping the certification body up to date on changes that may affect this planning, such as maintenance shutdowns (Part II, clause 1.1.8).

Clause 1.1.8 shall apply to any site which chooses to follow an unannounced audit programme.

Where the site has not made adequate arrangements with the certification body in due time prior to the start of the 4-month audit window, the audit due date will be moved to accommodate the 'late start'. The unannounced audit may be completed at any time in the following 4 months. Sites should be aware that their current certificate may therefore expire, due to a 'late audit'. In addition, a major non-conformity shall be awarded for lack of compliance to the requirements of the Protocol. Certification bodies shall inform BRCGS through the usual concession process.

If the site wishes to withdraw from the voluntary unannounced audit programme, the next audit will be scheduled to occur within the 28 calendar days up to and including the anniversary of the last audit date; this ensures that the maximum time between audits is not more than a year. Where the site received a grade of C+ or D+ at the last audit and wishes to withdraw from the voluntary unannounced audit programme, the next audit due date will be 6 months after the last audit date, and the audit will occur within the 28 calendar days prior to this date.

5 Additional modules

The Standard has been designed to enable additional modules to be included with the routine audit. The additional modules will enable sites to demonstrate compliance with specific sets of requirements to meet specific market or customer requirements.

It is expected that modules will be developed and become available for use throughout the life of this issue of the Standard. A list of the modules, the applicable requirements and any specific protocol for a module will be available on the BRCGS website and on BRCGS Participate.

The additional modules can be added to any of the full certification audit options.

The general protocol for the additional modules broadly follows the principles of the Standard; however, details will be given with each module.

The site should inform the certification body that an additional module is to be included within the scope of the audit. This ensures that sufficient extra time can be scheduled and that an auditor with the appropriate qualifications for the additional module is selected.

The site shall ensure that the manufacturing programme at the time of the announced audit covers products for the intended additional module where this is applicable. Where the site has opted into the unannounced audit programme, detailed information shall be given to the certification body regarding manufacturing planning so that an appropriate audit date can be selected. At its discretion, where there is a lack of information or no potential for choice of audit dates, the certification body may be unable to accommodate the request for the additional module at the unannounced audit.

There will be no grading of the additional modules. The modules will either be certificated or not. Any non-conformities identified when assessing a module shall not be taken into account when deciding the grade for certification against the Standard.

Note: the modules are certificated separately from the Standard. However, where certification to the Standard is not achieved, certification for the module cannot be awarded, irrespective of whether the requirements of the module have been met.

6 General protocol – post audit

6.1 Communication with certification bodies

In the event that any circumstances change within the site that may affect the validity of continuing certification, the site shall notify the certification body promptly or within the timescales defined within the Standard. Circumstances may include:

- legal proceedings with respect to product safety or legality, or that which significantly affects the operation of the site
- significant product safety, legality or quality incidents
- significant damage to the site (e.g. natural disaster such as flood or damage by fire)
- change of ownership (see glossary)
- any significant change to the manufacturing operations or scope
- significant personnel changes or prolonged shutdowns (e.g. considerable personnel losses or the loss of key product safety roles).

The certification body in turn shall take appropriate steps to assess the situation and any implications for the certification and shall take appropriate action.

Information shall be provided to the certification body by the site on request so that an assessment can be made as to the effect on the validity of the current certificate.

The certification body may, as appropriate:

- confirm the validity of certification
- suspend certification pending further investigation

- require further details of the corrective action, root cause analysis and preventive action plan implemented by the site
- undertake a site visit to verify the control of processes and confirm continued certification
- withdraw certification
- issue a new certificate with the new owner's details.

Changes to the certification status of a site shall be recorded in the **BRCGS Directory**.

In the event of an incident, the effectiveness of corrective and preventive actions taken by the site will also be reviewed at the next scheduled BRCGS audit to confirm their implementation and continued effectiveness.

6.2 Position statements

During the lifetime of the Standard, the BRCGS technical advisory committee (TAC) (see Part IV) may be asked to:

- review the wording of a requirement in the Standard or protocol
- provide an interpretation for a requirement
- rule on the grading of a non-conformity against a clause.

The outcome will be published as a 'position statement'. Position statements are binding on how the audit and certification processes are carried out. They are considered to be an extension of the Standard.

Sites shall be aware of any published position statements relating to the Standard and, where necessary, ensure that the information is transferred into action. Non-compliance with a relevant position statement may result in a non-conformity against clause 1.1.7 or a specific clause of the Standard.

Position statements are published on the BRCGS website and on BRCGS Participate. They are also communicated electronically to companies and certification bodies (e.g. in bulletins and newsletters).

More information on the development and publication of position statements can be found in Appendix 7.

6.3 Extension to scope

Once certification has been granted, any subsequent changes that are required to be included in the scope of certification (e.g. additional significant products manufactured or processes undertaken by the site) must be communicated to the certification body. The certification body shall assess the significance of the new products or processes and decide whether to conduct a site visit to examine the aspects of the required extension to scope.

A revisit is required before granting a scope extension in the following circumstances:

- inclusion of manufacturing facilities not taken into account in the original audit
- inclusion of a new processing technology (e.g. blow moulding where previously only injection moulding was included within the scope)
- inclusion of new products which introduce a significant new risk to the facility (e.g. new inclusion of recycled material).

A revisit is less likely where new products are extensions to the existing ranges produced on existing equipment.

Where an extension to scope is required shortly before the certificate is due to expire, it may be more appropriate to undertake a full audit and issue a new certificate. This option should be agreed between the certification body and its site prior to undertaking the extension to scope audit.

When a revisit is considered necessary, the duration of this visit will vary depending on the aspects to be examined for the required extension to scope. The site visit should be conducted along the same principles as the original audit (i.e. including an opening meeting, inspection of the operation of the manufacturing operations documentation trails and closing meeting). The revisit should be announced, irrespective of whether the site is certificated to the announced or unannounced programme.

Identified non-conformities should be documented and actioned within the normal protocol of the Standard, (i.e. the company has 28 calendar days to provide appropriate evidence of close-out and the certification body should review the information and confirm the certification decision in the normal manner). The additional non-conformities raised at the site visit will affect neither the current certificated grade nor continued certification. However, if practices are seen that give the certification body cause to doubt continued certification (e.g. the identification of a critical non-conformity) then the certification body shall arrange a full re-audit of the site. In these circumstances the current certificate shall be withdrawn.

A visit report should be documented but shall not be in the format of the standard BRCGS audit report. A short explanation of the nature of the visit, what was audited, and the conclusions should be given. The visit report should document what controls are in place and confirm the effectiveness of these controls. It should be clear in the report what aspects were looked at and what was excluded.

The site's current certificate will be superseded by any new certificate issued. The certificate must use the same expiry date as detailed on the original certificate. The due date of the next full audit will therefore remain the same and this should be made clear to the site by the certification body when arranging extension to scope visits. The grade shall also remain the same.

The certificate should include identification that it was a scope extension and the date of the visit.

6.4 Certification withdrawal

The certificate may be withdrawn by the certification body in some circumstances where the site may no longer comply with the requirements of the BRCGS certification scheme and ISO/IEC 17065. Examples of these instances are:

- evidence that the site no longer complies with the requirements and protocol of the Standard, raising significant doubt of the conformity of the products produced
- failure to implement adequate corrective action plans within appropriate timescales
- evidence of falsification of records
- failure to fulfil contractual obligations (e.g. payment failure).

6.5 Appeals

The company has the right to appeal the certification decision made by the certification body and any appeal should be made in writing to the certification body within 7 calendar days of receipt of the certification decision.

The certification body shall have a documented procedure for the consideration and resolution of appeals against the certification decision. These investigative procedures shall be independent of the individual auditor and certification manager. The documented appeals procedure of the relevant certification body will be made available to the site on request. Appeals will be finalised within 30 calendar days of receipt. A full written response will be given after the completion of a full and thorough investigation into the appeal.

It should be noted that where an appeal is made against a non-conformity, this does not delay or postpone the corrective action, root cause analysis or development of a preventive action plan (see section 2.3.2). The relevant information is still expected within 28 calendar days of the completion of the audit.

In the event of an unsuccessful appeal, the certification body has the right to charge costs for conducting the appeal.

6.6 Surveillance of certificated companies

For certificated companies, the certification body or BRCGS may carry out further audits or question activities to validate continued certification at any time. These visits may take the form of announced or unannounced visits to undertake either a full or part audit. These audits form part of the BRCGS Certification Integrity programme with random visits to certificated sites. Refusal of access to the site or unwillingness to co-operate with the auditor may affect certification status.

Any non-conformities identified at a visit must be corrected and closed out within the normal protocol (i.e. within 28 calendar days of the visit) and reviewed and accepted by the certification body. If there is no intention on behalf of the site to take appropriate corrective actions or the corrective actions are deemed inappropriate, certification shall be withdrawn. The ultimate decision to suspend or withdraw certification remains with the certification body. Any change in certification status shall be notified to BRCGS by the certification body and the status in the BRCGS Directory shall be amended accordingly.

In the event that certification is withdrawn or suspended by the certification body, the company shall immediately inform its customers and make them fully aware of the circumstances relating to the withdrawal or suspension. Information on the corrective actions to be taken to reinstate certification status should also be provided to customers.

6.7 Lapsed certification

BRCGS defines an initial audit as the first BRCGS audit at a site or an audit carried out at a site where the previous certificate has lapsed for more than 24 months.

BRCGS defines a re-audit as being a BRCGS audit carried out at a site where the previous BRCGS certificate has lapsed for up to 24 months. In this situation the previous audit report shall be shared with the current certification body and any non-conformances shall be reviewed by the auditor at the re-audit.

On returning to BRCGS certification the site shall be aware that the audit could be unannounced as the 3-year unannounced audit cycle for the site continues.

6.8 BRCGS logos

Achieving BRCGS certification is something of which to be proud. Companies that achieve certification and have no exclusions from their scope (see section 1.6.2) are qualified to use the BRCGS packaging materials logo on site stationery and other marketing materials.

Where a site has traded products or raw materials on site but wishes them to be excluded from the scope of the audit, this will be recorded as an exclusion from scope on the audit report and certificate. The BRCGS packaging materials logo cannot be used for promoting traded products, even when included in the certificated scope.

Information and conditions relating to the use of the BRCGS logo is available from the **BRCGS website**.

If a site is no longer certificated because of certificate expiry, withdrawal or suspension, it shall no longer use the logo or certificate claiming certification.

The BRCGS logo is not a product certification mark and neither it nor any reference to certification may be used on products or product packaging. Any certificated site found to be misusing the logo will be subject to the BRCGS complaints and referral process (see Part IV) and may risk suspension or removal of its certification.

The BRCGS logo may not be used by companies that do not include all products that are manufactured, processed, packed or labelled on site within the audit scope.

6.9 BRCGS Directory

The BRCGS Directory (www.directory.brcgs.com) is the database of all audits conducted against a BRCGS Standard and all BRCGS-approved certification bodies and auditors.

The Directory hosts audit reports and certificates in PDF format, including historic audit records from 2008 onwards.

Audit data can only be added to or edited on the Directory by BRCGS-approved certification bodies, who are also responsible for assigning audit records, and by extension access, to the audit-owning entity.

The Directory allows audit owners to 'share' their audit records with other participant users. Audit sharing configuration and access to confidential data is available to appropriately credentialled users only and requires sign-in.

Certification bodies are exclusively responsible for maintaining site records, including the site's name, address and contact details. All certification bodies are assessed and graded by BRCGS according to how quickly and accurately they update audit data.

6.9.1 Site code

All audited sites are allocated a unique 6-, 7- or 8-digit reference number known as a site code. Site codes are generated when a site record is initially created and added to the BRCGS Directory by a certification body. The site code remains unchanged, regardless of subsequent auditing certification bodies, Standard status or audit status.

Site codes can be located on the top right-hand corner of the first page of all audit reports and on corresponding certificates.

The listing for any certificated site can be located in the public area of the Directory by adding the site code to the 'site code' search field. If no results are returned for a search, contact BRCGS to confirm certification authenticity.

6.9.2 Audit-sharing

The BRCGS Directory allows audit owners to share their audit reports with customers, including retailers, manufacturers, suppliers and other Directory-registered specifiers.

Once audit-sharing has been configured customers can access the full current, archived and future audit documents (as they become available) without any further administration.

An audit owner can cancel sharing at any time. Audit documents shared in the BRCGS Directory cannot be edited or otherwise changed by the audit owner; therefore, audits obtained from the Directory can be considered as complete and authenticated.

6.9.3 Site-sharing

Only certification bodies authorised by the site owner can edit a site record. In the event of a transfer from one certification body to another, the new certification body must be given access to the site's records before a new audit can be added for that site or any edits to the site details can be made. Site-sharing can be arranged by the site owner on the BRCGS Directory or by BRCGS upon request.

6.9.4 Notification emails

The BRCGS Directory notifies audit owners, and anybody who has shared access to the audit, if a site's certification is suspended, withdrawn or expires without replacement. Notifications are via automated email and can be turned off if not required.

6.9.5 Directory assistance and contacting BRCGS

For further information regarding the BRCGS Directory, including how to configure audit-sharing with a customer or site-sharing with a certification body, visit the BRCGS Directory and click on the 'Audit & Site Sharing' and 'Contact' tabs.

Part IV

Management and governance

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Part IV

Management and governance

1 Requirements for certification bodies

The Global Standard Packaging Materials is a process and product certification scheme. In this scheme, businesses are certificated upon completion of a satisfactory audit by an auditor employed by an independent third party – the certification body. The certification body in turn shall have been assessed and judged as competent by a national accreditation body.

The process of certification and accreditation is outlined in Figure 3.

In order for a business to receive a valid certificate on completion of a satisfactory audit, the organisation shall select a certification body approved by BRCGS. BRCGS lays down detailed requirements that a certification body shall satisfy in order to gain approval. As a minimum, the certification body shall be accredited to ISO/IEC 17065 by a national accreditation body affiliated to the International Accreditation Forum (IAF) and recognised by BRCGS. Further details are available in the document 'Requirements for Certification Bodies Offering Certification Against the Criteria of BRCGS', which is available to certification bodies on request.

Companies looking to become certificated to the Standard should assure themselves that they are using a genuine, approved certification body. A list of all certification bodies approved by BRCGS is available in the **BRCGS Directory**.

BRCGS recognises that in certain circumstances, (for example, when new standards are introduced or there are new certification bodies wishing to commence auditing against the Standard), accreditation may not yet have been achieved. This is because the accreditation process itself requires some audits to have been completed which will then be reviewed as part of the accreditation audit of the certification body. The certification body shall be able to conduct audits as part of the process of achieving accreditation and so some unaccredited audits will be performed. This will be permitted where the organisation can demonstrate that:

- it has an active application for accreditation against ISO/IEC 17065 from an approved national accreditation body
- accreditation will be achieved within 12 months of the date of application and that the experience and qualifications of the auditors in the relevant product categories are consistent with those specified by BRCGS
- a contract is in place with BRCGS, and all other contracted requirements have been met.

The acceptability of audit reports and certificates generated by certification bodies awaiting accreditation (but meeting the above criteria) is at the discretion of individual specifiers. Full details of the BRCGS requirements for certification bodies and auditors are available from the BRCGS website or on request.

2 Requirements of accreditation bodies

2.1 General requirements

BRCGS recognises accreditation bodies that are signatories to the IAF Multilateral Agreement (MLA) for product certification and therefore work in accordance with the requirements of ISO/IEC 17011 'Conformity assessment – General requirements for accreditation bodies accrediting conformity assessment bodies'.

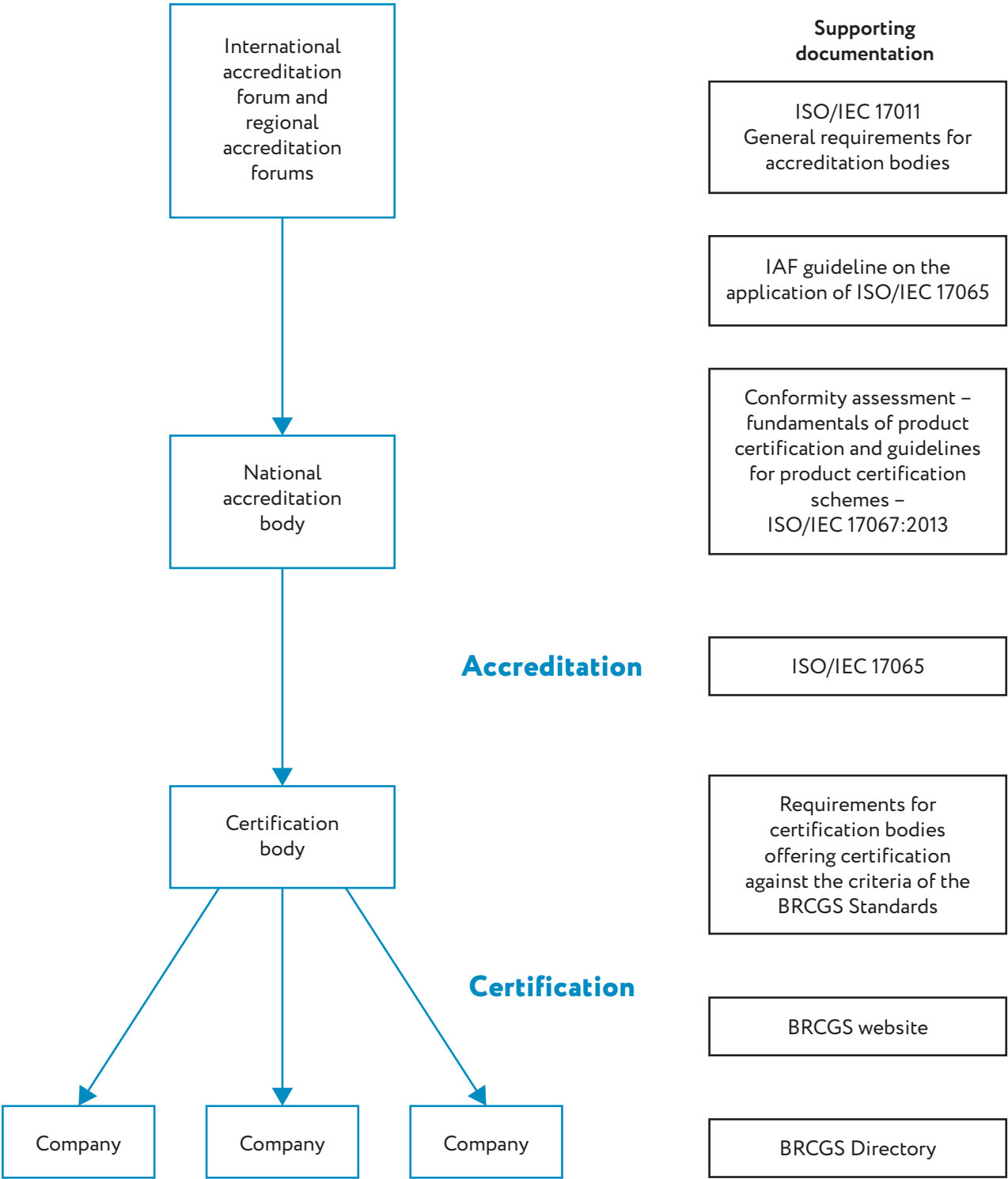


Figure 3 Process for the accreditation of certification bodies

2.2 Communication

Accreditation bodies shall have a working relationship with BRCGS, with interactive communication through a nominated contact within their organisation. BRCGS will:

- keep accreditation bodies up to date with relevant information and developments related to the certification programme
- provide an annual accreditation body conference
- share information through regular update bulletins
- provide specific data on its accredited certification bodies' performances.

Up-to-date information shall be available to BRCGS on initial and accreditation extensions granted, and any withdrawals or suspensions of accreditation of a certification body from the scheme. The scope of accreditation of the certification bodies shall be publicly available, up to date and defined in terms of the exact name of the Standard and its issue number.

Communications shall respect confidentiality requirements at all times.

2.3 Accreditation body personnel competencies

Accreditation body assessors shall have a working knowledge of ISO/IEC 17065 and the Standard's normative documents, as well as the packaging industry in general, to undertake their role.

BRCGS operates an 'Approved Training Provider' scheme where authorised trainers deliver BRCGS-developed training material together with a corresponding examination. This training may be optionally utilised.

Witness assessors shall be competent, have a working knowledge of, and be trained in, the Standard (either internally or externally), and have a recognised HARA and lead auditor qualification.

Head office assessors shall, as a minimum, have a detailed knowledge of the Standard and its normative documents, having been trained internally or externally.

2.4 Accreditation processes

Accreditation bodies shall implement processes that aim to complete any initial application for accreditation to the Standard within 12 months. Unaccredited certificates can be issued during this time with no limit on maximum numbers. Accreditation shall be completed prior to the new issue of the Standard becoming 'live' (i.e. before the certification body issues any certificates).

Accreditation bodies shall be able to demonstrate an approach which ensures that the requirements of BRCGS Standards are understood and effectively assessed as a part of the accreditation process.

Initial assessments shall include a head office assessment, with a review of at least two full certification processes for the Standard, as well as a minimum of one accreditation witness assessment.

During the surveillance of the 5-year accreditation cycle for accredited certification bodies, a head office assessment against ISO/IEC 17065 shall be completed annually. The sampling of activities and files shall sufficiently cover the breadth of activities conducted by the certification body, considering audit and auditor volume, geography and product categories.

A minimum of one accreditation witness assessment every 2 years shall be completed. The planning and scheduling of activities shall be based on risk, taking into account the breadth of product categories, geography, and the audit and auditor volume held by the certification body.

3 Technical governance of the Standard

The Standard and associated programme is managed by BRCGS with governance and technical advice provided through a number of stakeholder groups (see Figure 4), each of which works to a set of defined terms of reference.

3.1 International advisory boards

The technical management and operation of the Standard is governed by the BRCGS international advisory boards. These consist of senior technical representatives of international retail and global manufacturing businesses. The functions of the advisory boards are to provide strategic advice on the development and management of the BRCGS Standards and associated activities to ensure the effective management of the certification bodies and audit process.

3.2 Technical advisory committee

Each Global Standard is supported by at least one technical advisory committee (TAC), which meets regularly to discuss technical, operational and interpretational issues relating to the standard. BRCGS provides the technical secretariat for these groups.

The TAC for the Global Standard Packaging Materials is made up of senior technical managers representing the users of the Standard and includes representatives of retailers, packaging manufacturers and converters, food-service companies, trade associations, certification bodies and independent technical experts.

The Standard is reviewed approximately every 3 years to assess the need for updating or manufacture of a new issue. This work is undertaken by the TAC, which is expanded for the purpose to include other available expertise.

The TAC also reviews auditor competence requirements and supplementary technical documents supporting the Standards.

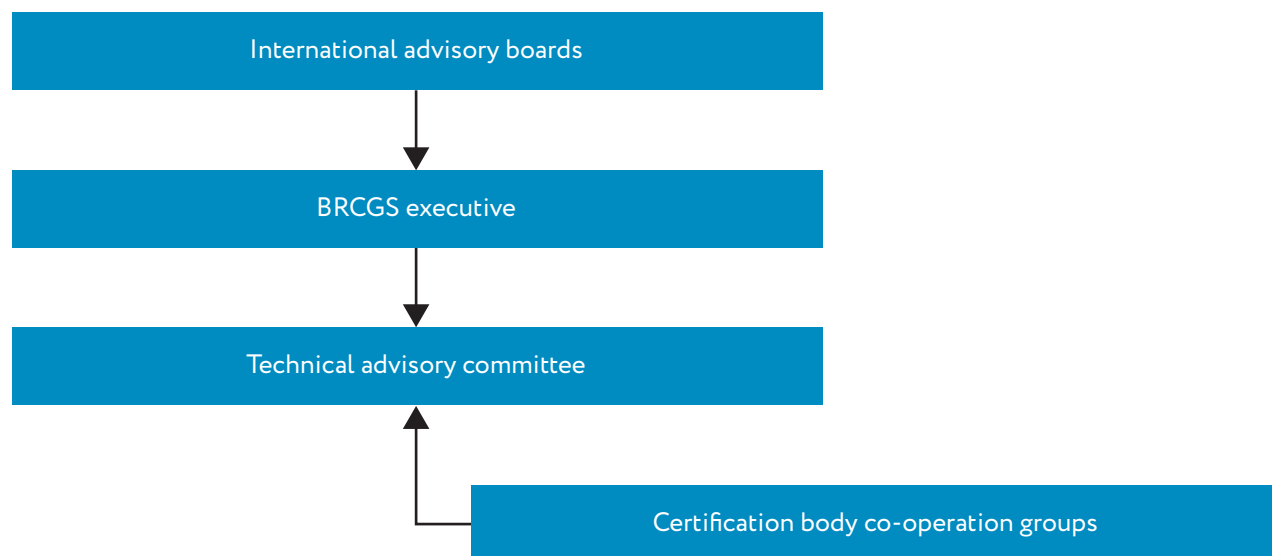


Figure 4 Technical governance structure for management of the Standard

3.3 The certification body co-operation groups

BRCGS encourages and facilitates meetings of the certification bodies participating in the scheme (co-operation groups) to discuss matters arising on the implementation of the Standard and discuss issues of interpretation. These groups report regularly to BRCGS on operational issues, implementation and suggested improvements. Representatives from the co-operation groups attend the TAC meetings.

3.4 Achieving consistency – certification integrity

The maintenance of a high and consistent standard of audit and certification, and the ability of the certificated sites to maintain the standards achieved at the audit, are essential to provide confidence in the scheme and the value of certification. BRCGS therefore has an active Certification Integrity programme to supplement the work of accreditation bodies and ensure high standards are maintained.

The Global Standards may only be certificated by certification bodies registered and approved by BRCGS and accredited by a BRCGS-recognised accreditation body. All auditors undertaking audits against the Standard must meet the BRCGS auditor competency requirements and shall be registered with BRCGS. All audits undertaken against the Standard shall be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory, which provides BRCGS with an oversight of the activity of the certification bodies and the opportunity to review the quality of the reports produced.

To support the Standard, BRCGS operates an Certification Integrity programme which reviews the performance of the certification bodies, samples the quality of audit reports, assesses levels of understanding of the scheme requirements and investigates any issues or complaints. As part of this programme, BRCGS provides feedback on the performance of each certification body through a key performance indicator (KPI) programme. The results are publicly available as a 1–5-star rating of each certification body listed on the BRCGS Directory.

BRCGS audits the offices of certification bodies and accompanies auditors at site audits to observe their performance. BRCGS also undertakes independent visits to certificated sites to ensure that standards of packaging safety and quality are being maintained in line with their certification status and that the audit and reporting process are to the expected standard.

3.5 Calibrating auditors

A key component of the programme is the calibration of the auditors to ensure a consistent understanding and application of the requirements. All certification bodies are required to have processes to calibrate their own auditors. An essential element of the training and calibration of auditors is the witnessed audit programme. Auditors are observed during an audit and provided with feedback on the performance of the audit. In order to ensure consistency between certification bodies and for the purposes of accreditation, an audit may be witnessed by a BRCGS representative or accreditation body auditor. Guidelines apply to these activities to ensure that sites are not disadvantaged by the presence of two auditors. This process forms an essential part of the scheme, and sites are obliged to permit witnessed audits as part of the conditions for certification.

3.6 Feedback

Companies audited against the Standard may wish to provide feedback to the certification body or BRCGS on the performance of the auditor. Such feedback sent to BRCGS will be considered in confidence. Feedback provides a valuable input to the BRCGS monitoring programme for certification body performance.

All audited sites are invited to complete a feedback survey which is treated confidentially.

3.7 Complaints

BRCGS has a formal complaint process, which can be found on the BRCGS website. Complaints can be reported confidentially on the **TellBRCGS reporting system**.

From time to time, failure to apply the principles and criteria of the Standards at certificated sites may be reported to BRCGS by, for example, retailers and companies conducting their own audits. In this event, BRCGS will conduct an investigation which may include as appropriate a visit to the site by BRCGS, either announced or unannounced or a request to the certification body to investigate; this may also include a visit to the site. BRCGS will require a full investigation of the issues raised, and a report from the certification body will be submitted to BRCGS within 28 calendar days (or a shorter time in urgent cases).

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Appendix 1

Education, work experience and qualification requirements for auditors

Full details of the BRCGS requirements for certification bodies and auditor qualification and competence are published separately from this document. Copies are available on request.

The following summarises the minimum requirements for auditors to conduct audits against the Standard.

Education

Generally, auditors will be drawn from two distinct disciplines: those with expertise and a primary qualification in packaging technology, and those with expertise and a primary qualification in food or biosciences.

The auditor shall have a degree or higher certificate in:

- packaging technology, or materials engineering
- food technology, food safety/hygiene or related bioscience or science
- work experience.

The auditor shall have at least five years' post-qualification work experience related to the packaging, food or consumer products industry.

Work experience shall involve work in quality assurance or product safety, quality management, or risk management functions within manufacturing, inspection or enforcement, at a managerial, decision-making level.

The auditor shall be able to demonstrate an understanding and knowledge of specific manufacturing categories of packaging for which they are approved. The verification of the auditor's ability to carry out work with specified manufacturing categories is the responsibility of the certification body.

Professional qualifications

The auditor must have successfully completed the following courses, including examinations:

- Management system lead assessor course, of at least 40 hours duration (e.g. IRCA) or the BRCGS third-party auditor course delivered by a BRCGS-approved trainer.
- Food safety and hygiene course (including allergen awareness) where the auditor has a packaging industry background.
- Packaging technology course, of minimum 40 hours duration plus examination, where the auditor has a food or consumer products industry background.
- Hazard analysis and risk assessment (HARA/HACCP) course, based on the principles of Codex Alimentarius, of at least 16 hours duration, and be able to demonstrate competence in the understanding and application of HARA/HACCP principles. It is preferable that the course is relevant to the risks associated with packaging technology. In exceptional cases, where the auditor can demonstrate practical use and practical application within the previous five years to a high level (e.g., being a recognised trainer of HARA/HACCP), then a formal training course may not be required.

Auditor training

Certification bodies shall develop a tailored training programme depending on the auditor's background.

Trainee auditors will have completed a significant number of relevant audits (at least 10 third-party audits which include assessment of HARA/HACCP, quality management systems, and good manufacturing practices in the previous two years). As a minimum, training shall require auditors to be assessed on their performance during at least three audits (including at least one witnessed audit) against the Global Standard for Packaging Materials, until they are assessed as competent. Full details of the witnessed audit requirements are available to certification bodies in BRCGS018 – *Requirements for Certification Bodies ensuring Auditor Competence through Witness Audits*.

Certification bodies must be able to demonstrate that every auditor has appropriate training and experience for the specific manufacturing categories in which they are considered competent.

Training programmes for each auditor shall incorporate:

- Global Standard Packaging Materials Awareness course delivered by a BRCGS-approved trainer.
- initial training covering product safety, hazard analysis and risk assessment, and prerequisite programmes and access to relevant laws and regulations.
- supervised training to cover quality management systems, audit techniques and specific category knowledge.
- assessment of knowledge and skills for each manufacturing category (See Appendix 2) that the auditor is considered competent to audit.
- a documented sign-off after the satisfactory completion of the training programme.

Each auditor's training programme shall be managed and approved by a person/person within the certification body who can demonstrate technical competence in the manufacturing categories for which the training is given.

Full, detailed training records of the individual shall be maintained by the certification body throughout the term of employment and retained for a minimum period of five years after leaving the employment of the certification body.

Exceptions

Where a certification body employs an auditor who does not fully meet the specific criteria, but has been assessed as competent, there shall be a fully documented justification in place to support the employment of the auditor, which is agreed by the BRCGS.

Responsibility of the certification body

It is the responsibility of the certification body to ensure that the processes are in place to monitor and maintain the competence of the auditor to the level required by the Standard.

Appendix 2

Manufacturing categories

Manufacturing categories are used to categorise the sites and ensure that auditors selected to conduct the audit are sufficiently competent to understand the processes carried out at the site.

Manufacturing category	Scope of manufacturing category and typical key processes
Glass manufacture and forming	Key processes include: • raw materials to finished product of glass containers from one furnace through independent section machines to cold end lacquer(s) • further processes for extra furnaces. Any print/decoration is an additional key process. Typical manufacturing techniques include: • blow and blow • press and blow • extrusion of ampoules • forming and firing of ceramic bottles, jars or decanters.
Paper-making and conversion	Pulp to sheet or web, or conversion of sheet or web-fed paper where no printing operations take place (printing activities are additional key processes). Any print/decoration is a further key process. Key processes include: • manufacture of paper from raw materials (e.g. tree/pulp) to sheet or web (e.g. board, liner, carton board) • die-cutting, folding and gluing (erecting), and corrugating (from pulp) to corrugated sheet/reel • conversion of paper sheet into bags or sacks (including stitching) • manufacture of self-adhesive label stock (label and carrier/substrate) • die-cutting of sheet or web (including corrugated) to pads or fitments • moulding of pulp (of any source) into trays or fitments • manufacture of spirally wound tubes (including trimming and cutting) • manufacture of single use paper products e.g., drinking straws, napkins, plates, bags, cups, lids, trays and liners.
Metal-forming	Smelting of raw materials into aluminium, steel or tin, and conversion of those materials into packaging containers/materials. Any print/decoration is an additional key process. Key processes include: • smelting with output to sheet or reel • rolling/pressing of aluminium foil • slitting or trimming of aluminium foil • pressing of foil trays or containers • impact extrusion • manufacture of three-piece can bodies • manufacture of two-piece can bodies (steel or aluminium) • manufacture of can-ends • stamping/punching of closures (compounds or wads are a raw material for metal closures and a second manufacturing category is not required).

Manufacturing category	Scope of manufacturing category and typical key processes
Rigid plastics forming	Forming of resin into rigid plastic packaging materials. Any print/decoration is an additional key process. Key processes include: • injection moulding • in-mould labelling (additional key process if labels are not applied in other processes on site) • blow-moulding (extrusion/injection/press) • thermoforming • manufacture of single use plastic products, e.g. drinking straws, cutlery, cups, lids.
Flexible plastics manufacture	Forming of resin into flexible plastic packaging materials and laminating of multi-material layers into one layer. Any print/decoration is an additional key process. Key processes include: • extrusion (cast/blown) (addition of shoulder for flexible tubes can be included as part of first key process) • laminating (of any material) • laminating and seaming of flexible tubes, addition of shoulder • construction of plastic bags, pouches and sachets • vacuum metallising • blow-moulding • winding/rewinding films; slitting, scoring, perforating • coating (e.g. wax) • manufacture of single use plastic aprons, tablecloths, gloves etc.
Other manufacturing	This category will encapsulate the manufacture of those materials not able to be classified into other categories. Key processes include: • construction of pallets, boxes and crates, decorative wooden boxes • processing of wood for food and cosmetic use, wooden utensils (e.g. for lollipops, cutlery) • processing of natural cork, rubber • construction of hessian sacks, jute products, woven string (plastic or cotton) • processing of strings for tea bags or meat-packing.
Print processes	Any packaging material which is printed using any of the following print processes (each constitutes one key process) in addition to any manufacturing process: • flexographic, lithographic, gravure, letterpress (and offset) • screen, tampo or digital print • decoration by hot or cold stamping/blocking. Any post-printing conversion, such as cutting/creasing and gluing of folded cartons, is considered part of the print process, as printed packaging materials are typically converted further once printed. Specify printing technologies used at the site.
Chemical processes	Essentially, the manufacture of raw materials used in the printing and conversion of other packaging materials. This includes the manufacture of: • resins • adhesives • inks, varnishes and coatings.

The assembly of aerosol valves, actuators and dispensing systems shall be categorised according to the majority material. Where additional materials are used (e.g. metal springs), the other appropriate material category shall also be considered.

Appendix 3

Auditing of activities managed by a head office or central function

A manufacturer may have multiple locations, with a head office or central function managing some of the requirements within the scope of the Standard. Typically, this may apply to activities such as purchasing, supplier approval, product development, product recall and, occasionally, document control and procedures (where there is a group-shared quality management system).

In order to complete the audit process and make a certification decision, all the requirements within the scope of the Standard must be assessed as satisfactory. This means that any centrally managed systems shall be included within the audit process. There are two alternative processes for achieving this:

- Request and review information while at each manufacturing site as part of the site audit (one-stage audit).
- Undertake a separate audit of the centrally managed processes at the group/head office location (two-stage audit).

Approach 1 - Requesting and reviewing information at the manufacturing site (one-stage audit)

This is recommended only where:

- satisfactory links can be established with the central office (e.g. ICT or video-conferencing links for interviews and meetings with relevant personnel; email or online systems to allow documents to be requested and viewed) and arrangements can be put in place to ensure availability of relevant personnel
- head office involvement in the site operations is limited, or the amount and type of information can be effectively reviewed and challenged remotely.

Note: where a site elects for the information to be assessed during the manufacturing site audit and satisfactory information cannot be provided during the audit, unsubstantiated requirements shall be recorded as non-conformities on the site audit report.

Reporting

The audit report shall make it clear where a requirement is managed by a central office together with a comment on how the company complies with the requirement.

Non-conformities

Non-conformities raised against a centrally operated requirement shall be recorded on the audit report and included within the count of non-conformities contributing to the site grade.

Corrective action, root cause and preventive action plans shall be assessed in the same way as for non-conformities raised at the manufacturing site and must be satisfactorily corrected before a certificate can be issued to the site.

Subsequent manufacturing site audits

The central function requirements shall be challenged, and evidence of compliance be provided at each manufacturing site audit.

Approach 2: Separate central function and manufacturing site audits (two-stage audit)

This approach is recommended where it is not practical to effectively assess requirements from the manufacturing site. For example, where:

- practical arrangements to allow assessment cannot be provided
- there are too many centrally managed requirements to effectively review remotely.

This shall be offered to the site being audited and undertaken when requested.

Stage 1 – Central function audit

The audit of the central function shall be completed before undertaking the manufacturing site audit.

For the unannounced audit, the central function audit may be completed as an announced audit, while the manufacturing site audits shall be completed as unannounced audits. The date of the central function audit shall ensure that there is sufficient time for the unannounced audits of the participating manufacturing sites to occur before each site's audit due date.

The company can select the blended audit option for its central function and site audits. This will operate in accordance with the blended audit protocol (see Part III, section 3). The clauses that can be audited remotely are in accordance with the normal audit protocol (i.e. based on the certification body risk assessment and the colour-coding of the clauses in Part II). Part III, section 3.1.7 provides further information on the selection of clauses. In some situations, this may mean that the auditor does not need to visit the head office as all the clauses are appropriate for remote assessment. If the head office audit contains a mixture of clauses (i.e. some that require on-site assessment and others that may be audited remotely), the company may elect to have:

- a blended audit of the central function (i.e. a two-part audit, partially remote and partially on site at the head office)
- a full on-site head office audit
- a remote head office audit with the remaining on-site elements being assessed at each of the site audits.

The audit shall assess both how the central function complies with the relevant requirements of the Standard and how well the central function interacts with the manufacturing site operation.

Reports for the central function audit

The certification body may produce a report of the central function audit for the benefit of the company. However, as this audit will only include some of the requirements of the Standard:

- no grade may be allocated
- no certificate may be issued
- the report must be in a format which is clearly different from the full BRCGS audit report.

The central function report shall not be uploaded to the BRCGS Directory, but the findings shall be incorporated into the final audit report of each of the associated manufacturing sites.

Recording non-conformities identified at the central function audit

All non-conformities identified at the central function audit shall be recorded on each subsequent site audit report irrespective of whether they have been closed out before the manufacturing site audit.

Only those non-conformities raised at the central function audit which have not been closed out to the satisfaction of the certification body at the time of the first manufacturing site audit shall be counted when calculating the grade for the manufacturing site.

Closure of central function's corrective actions

Corrective actions, root cause analysis and preventive action plans that are required following the central function audit shall be assessed in the same way as corrective actions raised at the manufacturing site (within 28-calendar days from the last day of the audit) and must be satisfactorily corrected before a certificate can be issued to the manufacturing sites. This may be documentary evidence or a revisit, as appropriate.

Stage 2 – Manufacturing site audits

Information from the central function audit (including any evidence of corrective actions taken) shall be made available to the auditors of the associated manufacturing sites by the certification body.

The auditor shall establish that the central function components assessed are the same as those operating at the manufacturing site. The auditor shall verify any corrective actions already taken following the central function audit.

Audit duration

It may be possible to reduce the duration of the manufacturing site audit to take account of systems already audited at a central office. A reduction of any audit duration at the manufacturing site needs to be justified by the certification body when a head office central function audit has been undertaken.

BRCGS audit report

The site audit report shall be applicable to the manufacturing site and shall capture specific information related to the head office/central function details.

The central function audit shall be commented upon in the site company profile; for example: 'An audit was carried out at the central office at on the to assess requirements as indicated in the report'.

The audit report shall include the names of key personnel present at the central function audit.

The manufacturing site audit report shall include information about how both the site and the central function comply with the requirements of the Standard. The report shall indicate where a requirement is managed by a central function/head office and provide an explanation of how that requirement is satisfied.

Corrective action

The 28 calendar days allowed for evidence of corrective action to be provided starts from the date of the manufacturing site audit.

It is the responsibility of the site to ensure that evidence of the central function's corrective actions has been provided to the certification body to allow the site to become certificated. This will require effective communication with the central function's office.

Where the central function's corrective actions have been accepted prior to the first manufacturing site audit, these non-conformities, corrective actions and relevant acceptance dates shall be recorded on each manufacturing site audit report thereafter.

Certificate

The certificate, where awarded, is issued to the manufacturing site. The re-audit date for the manufacturing site is based on the grade achieved and shall be 6 or 12 months from the initial audit date.

The central function audit shall be carried out every 12 months and shall occur before the anniversary of the audit of the first manufacturing site.

Audits of other manufacturing sites associated with the central function

Usually there will be several manufacturing sites associated with a central function. The information from the annual central function audit shall be used for each subsequent manufacturing site audit.

Non-conformities originally raised at the central function and effectively corrected before the audit of manufacturing sites shall be recorded on the site's audit report. This will indicate the correction, root cause, preventive action and review date of closure of the non-conformity by the certification body. Any outstanding non-conformities at the time of the manufacturing site's audit shall be included within the site's audit report and used to calculate the grade.

BRCGS shall be contacted for advice before carrying out audit programmes for more complex arrangements of sites and centralised systems.

Scheduling re-audit dates

The head office/central function of the company shall be visited annually. Re-audits of individual sites under the head office's control are performed at a frequency dependent on the previous audit performance of that particular site.

Appendix 4

Corrective action, preventive action and root cause analysis

This appendix includes an example of a completed non-conformity summary sheet.

An important principle of the Standard is the need to ensure that actions are taken to address any failure in the product safety and quality management system.

This is highlighted in several places within the Standard, most notably within Part II, section 3.13 and Part III, section 2.3.

There are two types of action recognised within the Standard:

- Corrective action (sometimes referred to as correction) defined as action to eliminate a detected non-conformity or non-conforming product.
- Preventive action defined as action to eliminate the underlying cause (root cause) of a detected or potential non-conformity or other potential undesirable situations and prevent recurrence.

To identify the correct preventive action, it is necessary to complete root cause analysis, which is a problem-solving process for investigating an identified incident, non-conformity or situation. The aim of the root cause analysis is to enable the investigators to look beyond the solution to the immediate problem and understand the causes of the situation, so that the causes can be eliminated and therefore recurrence of the non-conformity or situation is prevented (preventive action).

For example, following a BRCGS audit, a site is required to complete corrective action, root cause analysis and preventive action for each of the non-conformities identified during the audit, and submit information demonstrating completion of these activities to its certification body. The final audit report will include details of each non-conformity, along with a summary of the corrective action taken and the proposed preventive action. (Preventive actions often take longer than 28 calendar days, and sites are therefore not expected to fully complete the preventive action prior to publication of the audit report.) A summary of the root cause analysis will also be included.

Table 3 is an example of a completed summary sheet from the audit report. It is worth noting that this is only a summary of the actions and analysis completed by the site, and does not include the full details that the site shares with the certification body.

Table 3 An example of a completed non-conformity summary sheet

MAJOR						
Requirement ref.	Details of non-conformity	Corrective action	Proposed preventive action plan	Root cause analysis	Date reviewed	Reviewed by
4.8.4	Equipment used for cleaning the toilets was noted on a trolley in the manufacturing area.	Immediate removal of the trolley of cleaning equipment from the manufacturing area at time of audit.	Retraining of cleaning personnel. Clear labelling of equipment trolleys. Allocation of a dedicated storage area within the toilet block for cleaning trolley's.	Lack of training and understanding of cleaning agency personnel. Lack of provision of segregated storage area and identification of cleaning equipment.	2025-07-01	AN Other

Root cause analysis is not always straightforward and can take time to identify why something occurred. BRCGS standards are not prescriptive in the methods by which root cause analyses are completed, and a number of tools exist. The simplest of these is the '5 Whys' technique, where the investigator continues to ask why or how something happened until the root cause procedure or process is identified.

It must be noted that root cause analysis never seeks to blame an individual or group, even when human error may seem to be a contributory factor, but aims to consider why the error was made, thereby identifying which process, procedure or way of working failed (resulting in the error). The preventive action will then relate to the process or procedure that can be introduced or amended to prevent recurrence of the non-conformity in future. Examples of non-conformities, with poor-quality and acceptable root causes, as well as corrective and proposed preventive actions, are shown in Tables 4 and 5.

Table 4 Summary of a root cause analysis (for failure to complete internal audit programme)

Requirement	Non-conformity	Poor-quality root cause	Acceptable root cause	Proposed preventive action
3.5.1	The internal audit programme schedule indicated that the site only planned to perform one internal audit on one date against the requirements of BRCGS Packaging Materials, Issue 7 in 2025.	Due to lack of trained auditors, there was only sufficient resources to perform one audit.	During the past year we have lost two members of personnel both of which were trained internal auditors. We had recruited new personnel members but had not scheduled internal audit training for them. A suitable internal auditor course was not available.	The two new members of personnel are booked on an internal auditing course. Review of internal audit programme to ensure that internal audits are planned over more than one date spread throughout the year. Continuing review of internal auditing resources.

In Table 4, there are two challenges associated with the poor-quality root cause analysis.

Firstly, the lack of resources is not the root cause, but is a symptom of provision of inadequate capacity in resource. This issue is within the control of the site's senior management. An acceptable root cause for this issue is for the management to look at capacity and build more resources to ensure the ability to meet the requirements of the Standard.

Table 5 Summary of a root cause analysis (identified personnel error)

Requirement	Non-conformity	Corrective action	Poor quality root cause	Acceptable root cause	Proposed preventive action
5.8.2	Lack of identification to support traceability of a number of batches of raw materials in the storage area. 1: 10 reels of Kraft Paper received on site on 10 May 2025. 2: 6 reels of coated paperboard received 2 May 2025.	All reels of paper retrospectively identified, and information captured on the stock rotation system SAP. All warehouse personnel trained in the new procedure.	Warehouse intake personnel did not follow correct procedure for the labelling of reels of paper.	Review of personnel training confirmed that new people working in the warehouse at the time of the audit, had not been trained in the goods receipt procedure. The procedure was undergoing revision and had not been formally released on our document control system to be available for training. The warehouse manager had not authorised as he was on holiday.	Authorised documentation release system has been formalised. Allocated authorised deputies for procedure release. Checking of identification labels added to the monthly GMP inspection checklist.

Table 5 is an example of a root cause analysis that has identified personnel not following the procedure as the root cause factor associated with a non-conformity. In these situations, it is important to consider how the error could have occurred and therefore what process could be improved to make the error less likely.

BRCGS has published a full guideline document to help sites understand preventive action and root cause analysis, which includes tools for completing root cause analysis and some pitfalls to be avoided. This guideline is available on the BRCGS Store and BRCGS Participate.

Appendix 5

Certificate template

Auditor number

CERTIFICATION BODY NAME OR LOGO

[Certification body name, certification body number] certifies that, having conducted an audit

For the scope of activities:

Manufacturing categories:

Including additional modules of:

Exclusions from scope:

At COMPANY NAME
SITE CODE
AUDIT SITE ADDRESS

Has achieved grade: [insert grade]

Meets the requirements set out in the
GLOBAL STANDARD PACKAGING MATERIALS
Issue 7: October 2024

Audit programme: [announced, unannounced or blended audit, or reissued after extension to scope]**Date(s) of audit:** [Include two dates for the blended announced audit. If the audit is an extension to scope, include original audit date]**Certificate issue date:****Re-audit due date:** from to**Certificate expiry date:**Accreditation
body logo

Authorised by

BRCGS
logo

Name and full address of certification body

Certificate traceability reference

This certificate remains the property of [name of certification body]

If you would like to feedback comments on the BRCGS Standard or the audit process directly to BRCGS, please contact brcgs.enquiries@lgcgroup.com or use the BRCGS reporting system at <https://tellusbrcgs.whistleblownetwork.net>

To verify certificate validity, please visit <https://directory.brcgs.com>

Appendix 6

Other BRCGS standards

BRCGS has developed a range of Global Standards which set out the requirements for the manufacture of food and consumer products; the packaging used; the storage, distribution and procurement of these products; and the retail environment in which they are sold. These Global Standards complement the Global Standard Packaging Materials and provide precedents, frameworks and resources for the auditing and certification of suppliers.

The **Global Standard Agents and Brokers** is a certification standard applicable to companies that buy and sell products or facilitate the trade of products but do not manufacture, process, pack or store the traded products in their own facilities or on their own sites (although such activities may be offered to their customers via subcontracted service providers). The standard is GFSI-benchmarked.

The **Global Standard Consumer Products** is a certification standard applicable to the manufacture and assembly of consumer products. To reflect the needs of the market, it is composed of two separate standards: personal care and household, and general merchandise. Each standard sets out the requirements for the manufacture of relevant non-food consumer products, including the manufacture of raw materials and components, as well as finished products. There are two levels of certification to this standard: foundation and higher.

Ethical Trade and Responsible Sourcing (ETRS) is a certification standard that is applicable to manufacturers and processors of food and non-food products; it also covers the facilities provided by agents and brokers, storage and distribution, and the provision of services to these companies. It sets out the requirements for the sites to manage ethical trade and responsible sourcing issues. In addition, there is a separate risk assessment module that provides a 'health check' on the way sites manage ethical trade issues. This module can be bolted onto a product safety audit or conducted separately.

The **Global Standard Food Safety** is an auditing standard that sets out the requirements for the manufacture of processed foods and the preparation of primary products supplied as retailer-branded products, branded food products and food or ingredients for use by food service companies, catering companies and food manufacturers.

The **Global Standard Gluten-Free** is a certification standard for the control of gluten in the manufacture, processing and packing of processed foods and ingredients, pet foods, cosmetics, natural health products, and drugs. The standard provides on-pack trademarks for global use.

The **Plant-Based Global Standard** is a certification standard concerned with the control of materials of animal origin in the manufacture, processing and packing of plant-based processed foods and ingredients, pet foods, and natural health products. It is based on a comprehensive management system approach to ensure the integrity of plant-based products.

The **Global Standard Retail** is a certification standard that sets out the requirements to manage product safety, quality and legality for businesses in the food retail industry. The scope of certification covers applicable operations both at the retailer's head office and at its respective retail stores.

The **Global Standard Storage and Distribution** is a certification standard that sets out the requirements for the storage, distribution, wholesaling and contracted services of packaged food products, packaging materials and consumer goods. The standard is not applicable to storage facilities under the direct control of the production facility management, which are covered by the relevant manufacturing standard (e.g. the Global Standard Food Safety). The standard is GFSI-benchmarked.

Appendix 7

Position statements

During the lifetime of the Standard, the BRCGS technical advisory committee (TAC; see Part IV) may be asked to:

- review the wording of a requirement in the Standard or protocol
- provide an interpretation for a requirement
- rule on the grading of a non-conformity against a specific clause.

This outcome will be published as a 'position statement'. Position statements are binding on how the audit and certification process are carried out, and they are considered to be an extension of the Standard.

Companies shall be aware of any published position statements relating to the Standard and, where necessary, ensure that the information is transferred into action. Non-compliance with a relevant position statement may result in a non-conformity against Part II, clause 1.1.7 or a specific clause of the Standard relating to the position statement.

Position statements are published on the **BRCGS website** and on BRCGS Participate. They are also communicated electronically to companies and certification bodies (e.g. in bulletins and newsletters).

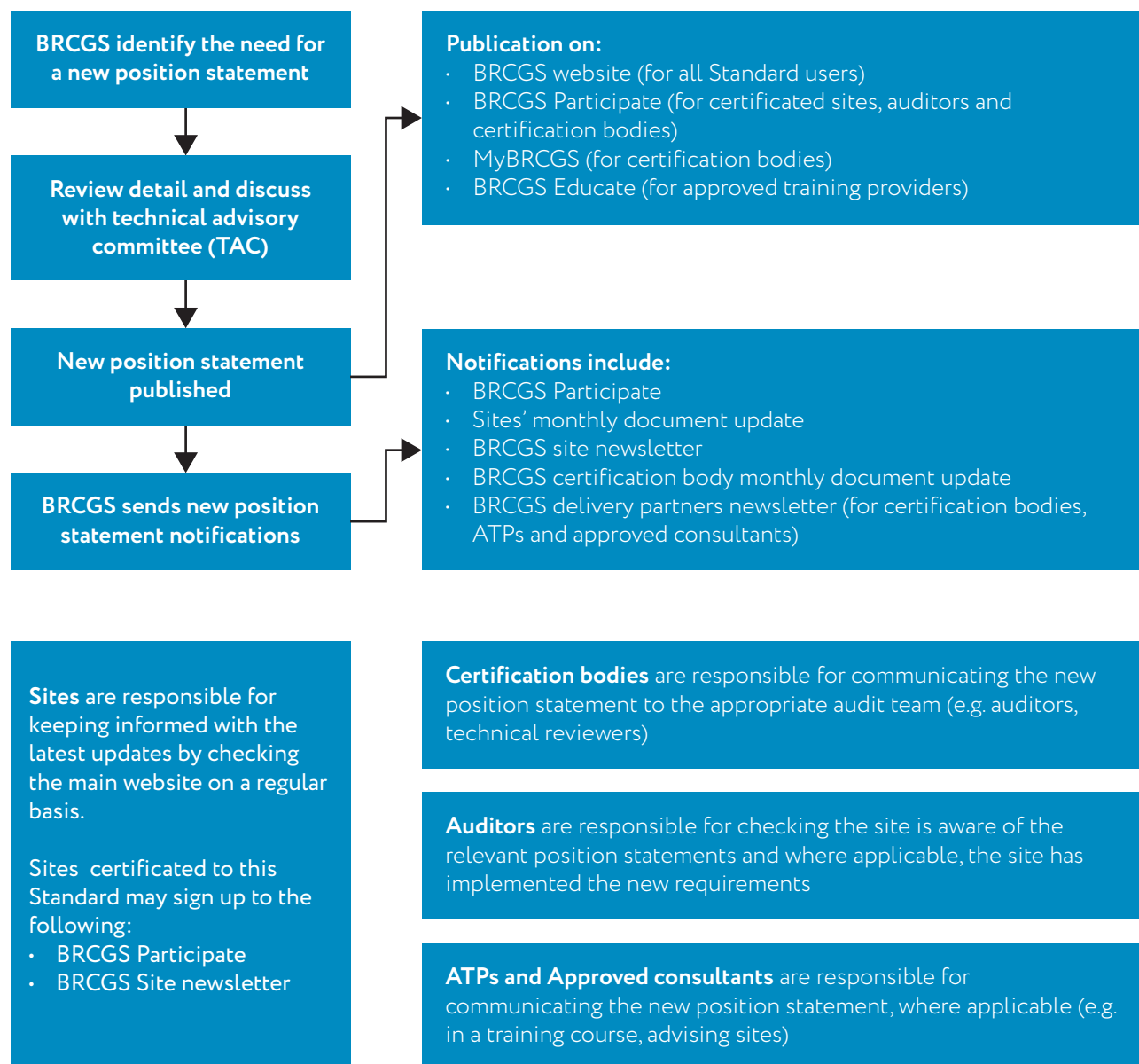


Figure 5 Position statement development and publication process

Appendix 8

Glossary

Accreditation	The procedure by which an authoritative body gives formal recognition of the competence of a certification body to provide certification services against a specified standard.
Activity	Work of an individual or group to achieve a specific aim.
Adulteration	The addition of an undeclared material into a raw material or product for economic gain.
Agent	A company or person that facilitates trade between a site or company and its raw material or packaging suppliers or its customers through the provision of services, but does not at any point own, or take title to the goods.
Allergen	A known component which causes physiological reactions due to an immunological response.
Ancillary areas	Supplementary areas that support the main function of the manufacturing or storage areas and serve specific purposes, and could include personnel facilities, engineering workshop, utility areas or laboratories.
Announced audit	An audit where the company agrees the scheduled audit day in advance with the certification body.
Annual/annually	Within twelve months since the action was last conducted.
Artwork	The elements that constitute a mechanical drawing, supplied as type, proofs and illustrations.
Assured status	Products produced in accordance with a recognised product certification scheme, the status of which needs to be preserved through the certified manufacturing facility.
Audit	A systematic examination to measure compliance of practices with a predetermined system, and whether the system is implemented effectively and is suitable to achieve objectives.
Auditor	A person possessing the appropriate competence and skills to carry out an audit.
Batch	A discrete quantity of products made using the same operation and raw materials (alternative term is 'lot').
Blended audit	An audit that is completed in two parts: • a remote audit of documents and records using ICT • an on-site audit concentrating on manufacturing, storage, good manufacturing practices and other on-site activities.
Bill of materials	A list of the raw materials, sub-components, work in progress, packing components and the quantities of each required for manufacturing a finished product. It is often related to a production order.
Brand	The brand, logo or name placed on products, owned by the company or a customer.
Broker	A company or person which purchases or 'takes title to' products for resale to businesses (e.g. manufacturers, retailers or food service companies) but not to the ultimate consumer.

Calendar days	Calendar days are consecutive days, inclusive of Saturdays and Sundays.
Calibration	A set of operations that establish, under specified conditions, the relationship between values of quantities indicated by a measuring instrument or measuring system, or values represented by a material measure or reference material, and the corresponding values realised by standards.
Certificate suspension	Revocation of certification for a given period, pending remedial action on the part of the company.
Certificate withdrawal	Where certification is revoked. Certification may only be regained following successful completion of the full audit process.
Certification	The procedure by which an accredited certification body, based on an audit and assessment of a company's competence, provides written assurance that a company conforms to a standard's requirements.
Certification body	Provider of certification services, accredited to do so by an authoritative body and registered with BRCGS.
Chain of custody	A process of following materials through every step of the supply chain as they go through various stages of sourcing, manufacturing, storage and distribution.
Claim	To assert or affirm that a certain characteristic, quality or benefit associated with a product is true or is a fact and is able to be substantiated such as FSC, PEFC, Nordic Swan, combustible, recycled content, etc.
Clause	A specific requirement or statement of intent that a site must comply with in order to achieve certification.
Clean room	A dedicated area free from dust, airborne particles and other contaminants used for the manufacture of sensitive products where such contamination could affect the final product.
Cleaning	Cleaning is the process of achieving and maintaining an area, including equipment, to a standard deemed free from significant debris.
Company	The entity with legal ownership of the site which is being audited against the Standard. Sometimes called 'organisation'.
Competent/competence	Being able to demonstrate the ability to apply skills, knowledge and understanding of a task or subject to successfully achieve intended results.
Complaint	A complaint is a statement of dissatisfaction with a product or service provided.
Compliance	Meeting the Standard, regulatory or customer requirements concerning product safety, legality and quality.
Composite printing	A mixture of different designs printed together on the same sheet or roll.
Consultants	An external technical expert, company, organisation or individual that is contracted by the site to provide technical services relating to the product safety and quality management systems (for example, the development, implementation or maintenance of the product safety management system; the development or implementation of the HARA plan; internal auditing, training and assistance in the production of manuals or procedures).
Consumer	The end-user of the final product.
Contamination	Introduction or occurrence of an unwanted organism, taint or substance that could negatively affect the finished/final product.

Contract	An agreement that creates a legal duty or responsibility between two or more people or parties. Parties entering a contract might include individual people, companies, and organisations.
Contractor or supplier	A person or organisation providing services or materials.
Control	To manage the conditions of an operation to maintain compliance with established criteria, and/or the state wherein correct procedures are being followed and criteria are being met.
Control measure	Any action or activity that can be used to prevent or eliminate a product safety, legality or quality hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level.
Controlled document	A document which is identifiable and for which revisions and removal from use can be tracked.
Corrective action (correction)	An action to eliminate a detected non-conformity or non-conforming product.
Critical control measure	A step at which control can be applied and is essential to prevent or eliminate a product safety hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level.
Cross contamination (cross-contact)	The process by which a substance that is potentially detrimental or harmful or dirty, transfers from one area or product to another.
Customer	A business or person to whom a product has been provided, either as a finished product or as a component part of the finished product.
Customer approved reference sample/ material	An agreed product sample that is used to compare with or verify another product.
Debris trap mat	A mat designed to capture debris from the bottom of footwear to avoid transference to other areas. Also known as a swarf mat.
Decoration	An addition, adornment or embellishment applied to a product and may contain legally required text.
Dispatch	The point at which the product leaves the factory site or is no longer the responsibility of the company.
Distribution	The transportation of goods within any container (goods on the move) by road, rail, air or ship.
Due diligence	The action of taking reasonable precautions in the manufacture of a safe and legal product.
Electronically traceable	Ability to trace and verify the identity of a person responsible when recording electronic data for monitoring activities, through password protection and individual logins.
Emergency	Unforeseen event that happens unexpectedly and potentially affects the supply chain.
FIFO/FEFO	Stock rotation method 'first in, first out' or 'first expiry, first out'.
Final product	Products that are ready for use by the consumer.
Finished product	Product manufactured by the site and supplied to their customers.
Finished product packing materials	Packing materials used to package the finished products manufactured by the site.

Foreseeable unintended use	Use of the product in a way not intended by the manufacturer, but which can result from predictable human behaviour e.g. by not using as directed, different usage or reuse.
Functional effect, integrity and performance (packaging)	Materials that can be used with food, beverage and other hygiene-sensitive product and have functions beyond containment but offer additional benefits such as shelf-life extension, freshness monitoring, tamper evidence, maintain quality and improve convenience. Alternatively, it can be used as a barrier that can prevent shock or compression damage to a consumer product. Can also be referred to as active packaging, incorporating components that actively engage with the packaged product and its environment to improve preservation. For example, oxygen, ethylene, moisture, odour and microbiological scavengers or fragrance odour patches.
Fundamental requirement	A requirement of the Standard that relates to a system which must be well established, continuously maintained and monitored by the company, as absence or poor adherence to the system will have serious repercussions on the integrity or safety of the product supplied.
Global Food Safety Initiative (GFSI)	Managed by the Consumer Goods Forum, a project to harmonise and benchmark international product safety standards (www.mygfsi.com).
Good manufacturing practice (GMP)	Implemented procedures and practices undertaken using best-practice principles.
Hair covering	Coverings designed to hold dislodged head hair in place, preventing it from falling and contaminating product.
Hazard	An agent of any type with the potential to cause harm (including biological, chemical, physical or radiological).
Hazard analysis and risk assessment (HARA)	A system that identifies, evaluates and controls hazards which are significant for product safety, quality and legality, based on globally recognised industry guidelines such as Codex Alimentarius.
Hygiene-sensitive product	A product intended for human consumption e.g. pharmaceutical products, or for contact with the body; for example, by application to the skin.
ICT	Information and communications technology.
Incident	An event that has occurred that may result in the manufacture or supply of unsafe, illegal or non-conforming products.
Initial audit	The first BRCGS audit at a specific site address, or an audit carried out at a site where the previous certificate has lapsed for more than 24 months.
Initial supplier	New supplier to the site.
Inspection	Targeted internal verification to ensure operations are being carried out to ensure the manufacture of a safe legal and quality product.
Intercompany/site movements	Products that are transferred between sister sites to facilitate distribution effectively to customers. These are not considered traded products.
Integrated	Being part of the equipment rather than being separate.
Intended use/purpose	The ultimate use for which the product is intended for.
Intermediate steps/operations	Partly manufactured product or step that are outsourced and returned to site for further processing/manufacturing once returned to the original site.

Integrity (packaging)	Once a product has been filled and sealed its integrity is based upon its ability to contain, protect and preserve the contained material during its intended use.
Internal audit	An internal audit is an independent objective review of the company's internal systems, processes and procedures providing verification that the governance and internal control processes are effective. Conducted by or on behalf of the company for internal purposes.
Label/labelling	Any tag, mark, picture or other descriptive matter, whether it is written, printed or otherwise marked, on or attached to the packaging of the product.
Legality	In compliance with the law in the place of production and in the countries where the product is intended to be sold.
Logistics	Activity of organising the movement of products through the supply chain.
Lot	See definition of 'batch'.
Manufacturer	A company that manufactures product from raw materials and/or components and supplies product to a customer.
Manufacturing process control	Control measures associated with activities not critical to the safety and legality of the product.
Manufacturing run	Distinct quantity of production typically referred to a batch or lot.
May	Indicates a requirement or text which provides guidance but is not mandatory for compliance with the Standard.
Medical alert jewellery/ medical monitoring devices	Medical alert jewellery contains information on medical conditions related to the wearer. Medical monitoring devices are used to monitor a medical condition e.g. blood glucose, blood pressure. Fitness trackers are not medical monitoring devices.
Migration	Transference or movement of chemical substances present in the product/material into a food or hygiene sensitive product.
Misrepresentation	Giving false or misleading information of the nature of a material. Either given fraudulently, negligently or innocently.
Mitigate	Steps taken to reduce the severity, risk or impact to an acceptable level. It is often used in product defence where controls are needed to prevent potential threats from occurring.
Monitoring	A planned sequence of observations or measurements of defined control parameters to assess whether predefined limits are being met.
New to site	Previously used equipment that is brought onto site for use and not purchased new.
Non-conformity	The non-fulfilment of a specified product safety, legal or quality requirement or a specified system requirement.
Non-production/ manufacture	Items not used as part of the manufacture of products or the product themselves e.g. glass windows in a glass bottle manufacturing facility.
Not applicable	Does not apply to the operations or activities completed at the site.
On-site	Activities present or undertaken at the site covered by the certification scope.
Open product	Areas where food or hygiene sensitive contact surfaces are exposed, or open to the environment.

Outsourced processes	Outsourced processes (also referred to as 'subcontracted processes and services') are defined as where intermediate manufacturing steps, or storage in the manufacture of a product is completed at another site.
Ownership (change of company ownership)	A change of ownership occurs when the title is transferred from one individual or entity to another and results in a change of control of the organisation.
Packaging/product	The finished product manufactured by the site. The scope for this Standard includes packaging materials, and single use disposable products used in the food service sector such as paper napkins, paper plates, paper cups, etc.
Packing	Materials used for wrapping either raw materials or the finished product for protection during storage and distribution.
Performance	Quantified data that provide information on the level of compliance against agreed targets.
Personal items/ belongings	Items that belong to personnel and that are small enough to be carried e.g. rucksacks, bike helmets, handbags.
Personnel	All individuals employed by the site, including full-time, part-time, temporary, agency supplied, seasonal, based on-site contractors such as cleaners, ink technicians and engineers. The term is often used interchangeably with staff or employees.
Physical form	Overall appearance, configuration or shape.
Position statement	Where clarification of the interpretation of a requirement of a BRCGS Standard or its protocol is necessary, this will be published as a position statement. Such statements are binding on the way that the audit and certification process are carried out and are considered to be an extension of the Standard. They are applicable from the date specified for implementation (or the date of publication, where no date is specified).
Potable water	Water being safe to drink, free from pollutants and harmful organisms and conforming to local legal requirements.
Premises	Buildings or areas owned by the company and audited as part of the certificated scope.
Prerequisite	The basic environmental and operational conditions at a site that are necessary for the production of safe, legal and quality products. These conditions provide the necessary control of generic hazards required for good manufacturing practice and shall be taken into consideration within the hazard analysis and risk assessment system.
Preventive action	Action to eliminate the underlying cause (root cause) of a detected or potential non-conformity or other potential undesirable situations and prevent recurrence.
Procedure	Agreed method of carrying out an activity or process which is implemented and documented in the form of detailed instructions or a process description.
Product defence	Procedures adopted to ensure the safety of raw materials, products and sites from malicious actions and damage.
Product recall	Any measures aimed at achieving the return of non-conforming or unsafe product from consumers.
Product release	Measures to ensure a product or material is of an acceptable standard prior to release.

Product safety culture	The attitudes, values and/or beliefs which are prevalent at the site, relating to the importance of product safety and the confidence in the product safety systems, processes and procedures used by the site.
Product withdrawal	Any measures aimed at achieving the return of non-conforming products from customers, but not from consumers.
Protective clothing	Clothing (for example overalls, hair nets, hats and beard snoods) designed to protect the product from potential contamination by the wearer.
Provenance	The ability to demonstrate the origin or the source of raw materials.
Quality	Meeting the customer's specification and expectation.
Quarantine	The status given to any material or product set aside while awaiting confirmation of its suitability for its intended use or release to customer.
Raw material	The basic material or work in progress used by the organisation for the manufacture of a product.
Recognised accreditation (laboratory)	Laboratory accreditation schemes that have gained national and international acceptance, awarded by a competent body and recognised by government bodies or users of the Standard (e.g. ISO/IEC 17025 or equivalents). The schedule of accreditation will identify the test methods for the testing undertaken for the site.
Reconciliation	Process of matching and synchronising physical product amounts with stock intake and movement records. Sometimes referred to as mass balance.
Record	Documents stating results achieved or providing evidence of activities performed. This may be paper-based or electronic, providing clear evidence of identity of the person responsible for the monitoring activity, through signature, initials, employee number or password access for electronic data recording system.
Recycled/recycling	Raw material that has been reprocessed from recovered (reclaimed) material, including pre-consumer (post-industrial) or post-consumer and reprocessed, e.g., cullet in glass production, shredded and pulped paper. Pre-consumer - material that has been reprocessed from recovered materials such as manufacturing residue e.g. off cuts, trim, rejected material etc. and has not been used and recycled by a consumer. Post-consumer - material that has been used and originated from consumer material streams such as from household recycling or back of store collections.
Regulatory	A law, rule or other order prescribed by an authority that has been designed to regulate conduct or conformity to regulatory requirements.
Requirement	Those statements comprising a clause with which compliance will allow sites to be certificated.
Rework	An action undertaken on a non-conforming product to make it conform to the specification.
Risk	The likelihood of occurrence of harm from a hazard.
Risk analysis	Codex Alimentarius defines risk analysis as being a process consisting of three components: • Risk assessment - identification of risks, likelihood and impact. • Risk management - procedures and records. • Risk communication - awareness, understanding and consistency.

Risk assessment	Risk assessment is one of the major components of a risk analysis. It is: • a process with multiple steps that intends to identify and analyse the potential risks and issues that are detrimental to the operation • a systematic process that identifies, assesses and evaluates potential risks, to understand their likelihood of occurrence and potential impact and to determine appropriate controls.
Root cause	The underlying cause of a problem which, if adequately addressed, will prevent a recurrence of that problem.
Samples/sampling	A defined, representative number of examples of products taken from the manufacturing run or traded products received, intending to measure acceptance or rejection.
Schedule	A defined plan for carrying out a process or procedure, listing intended events and planned dates or times.
Segregation	Separation of areas or groups of products with differing characteristics and result in potential cross-contamination hazards.
Senior management	Those with strategic/high-level operational responsibility for the company and the capability to authorise the financial or human resources necessary for the implementation of the Standard.
Significant	Sufficiently important and may have reasonably foreseeable potential to result in having an effect on product safety, legality or quality.
Site	A unit of a company; the entity which is audited and encompassed within the audit scope, audit report and certificate.
Specification	An explicit or detailed description of a material, product or service.
Specifier	A company or person requesting the product or service.
Spill-proof containers	Containers that do not leak or spill when knocked over or when not stored in an upright position. Lids of spill-proof containers are not removed for drinking and are usually opened by a press button or pull up mechanism.
Standard, the	The Global Standard Packaging Materials (Issue 7).
Suitable temperature (in relation to hand washing)	A temperature that is comfortable to the user and encourages handwashing.
Supplier	A person, company or other entity to which a site's purchase order to supply is addressed.
Supplier relationship	Historical evidence of having used the supplier for a number of years and therefore having confidence in that supplier to be able to supply products to specification.
Support services/ support service equipment	Miscellaneous equipment that supports the site operations, including air compressors, air handling/filtration systems, steam boilers, vacuum pumps, etc.
Timely manner	An agreed action time limit which is based on the required action and the time it is expected to take to address the issue and is not exceeded.
Traceability	Ability to trace and follow raw materials, components and products, through all stages of receipt, manufacturing and distribution both forwards to customers and backwards to the raw material suppliers.

Traded products	Traded products are defined as site purchased products that would normally fall within the scope of the Standard and are stored at the site's facilities, but are not manufactured, processed, reworked, packed or labelled at the site being audited. Storing and distributing sister company manufactured products are not considered traded products.
Trademarked	Words or symbol/logo that identifies the product as belonging to a specific organisation or signifies certification status or claims.
Trend	A positive or negative pattern or movement in identified results.
Usable life	The expected life of a product to maintain its functional properties e.g. biodegradable products, resisting degradation, breakage or deterioration.
Validation	Obtaining evidence through the provision of objective evidence that a control or measure, if properly implemented, is capable of delivering the specified outcome.
Verification	The application of methods, procedures, tests and other evaluations, in addition to monitoring, to determine whether a control or measure is or has been operating as intended.
Vulnerability	A potential weakness that can be exploited.
Where appropriate	Where appropriate generally refers to something suitable or fitting for a particular situation based on general industry standards.
Where relevant	Where relevant means that something is closely connected or applicable to particular situations based on general industry standards.
Work in progress	Partially manufactured products, including product returned from outsourced manufacturing operations, or materials waiting for completion of the manufacturing operation.
Working day	A day on which work is usually or routinely done at the site.

Appendix 9

BRCGS Participate

BRCGS Participate is a document information management system that allows BRCGS to deploy the content from its full range of standards, guidelines and additional modules through digital channels. It is a managed online service that certificated sites can access to view content, download PDFs and watch webinars.

Sites certificated to any one of four BRCGS Standards (Agents & Brokers, Food Safety, Packaging Materials or Storage & Distribution) can access the standards and other supporting documents across many devices.

Other BRCGS Participate features include:

- multi-format publications
- multi-lingual content
- searchable content
- a library to save content for easy access in the future
- a monthly newsletter listing updated content
- 24/7 worldwide access on web-enabled devices using a secure password system.

To learn more, please visit lgcassure.com/participate.

BRCGS publishes additional guidance on topics covered by requirements within the Standard. Registered sites can download this guidance free from BRCGS Participate or copies can be purchased from the **BRCGS Store**. Topics include:

- air quality
- allergen management
- cleaning of workwear
- environmental monitoring
- high risk, high care and ambient high care
- internal audit
- lighting
- lubrication
- pest management
- root cause analysis
- product changeover
- product recall
- product safety culture
- vulnerability assessments

Appendix 10

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